

SEDUCING ROBIN

Things We Do For Lust Bk 3

Sean Geist



Seducing Robin
The Things We Do For Lust Book 3
By
Sean Geist

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All characters in this story are over the age of 18 unless specified. V3

Acknowledgement

I want to thank my wife. Her support was essential in seeing me through the completion of this project. She also helped me edit the story. Any mistakes that remain, are completely my fault.

I also want to thank the readers. I love knowing there are people out there waiting to read the words I put down in pixels.

Please, before you read this story, throw out all your preconceptions. This is a romance and an erotic tale. It is also a farce and a tragedy. I'm sure that some people will be pissed as they read it, some may not finish it. I'm not writing this to scare you off, but to give you a heads up. If you enjoy the read then I have done my job.

Table of Contents

[Chapter 1](#)

[Chapter 2](#)

[Chapter 3](#)

[Chapter 4](#)

[Chapter 5](#)

[Chapter 6](#)

[Chapter 7](#)

[Chapter 8](#)

[Chapter 9](#)

[Epilogue](#)

[Afterward](#)

[Other Stories by Sean Geist](#)

Chapter 1

Robin

She lays in bed and stares at the shadows on the ceiling – vertical lines cast by the street lamps shining through half-closed blinds. She sees a cage, of course. It's what her life's become. A job that's taken all her time, leaving little for her husband – and her lover.

She has missed Peter, truly and deeply. He's laying in bed, his back to her, quietly breathing. She never meant to hurt him, but she knows she has. She's not sure what he means by saying she can't be 'his wife and Scott's wife.' It doesn't make sense. She's Peter's wife and she wants nothing to change that. Unfortunately, she loves them both, equally – truly and deeply.

Peter is her rock. He brings comfort and warmth to her life. He's a blessing she does not feel she deserves.

Scott is something else. He's handsome and bold, with a confidence she's never encountered before – a confidence she admires. For him, the glass isn't half full or half empty. It's just waiting for him to fill it.

Her lover may be a cocky S.O.B., but he backs it up, always. He sees what he wants and he takes it. Robin knows Scott had his eye on her the moment he sat down at that roulette table, three and a half months ago.

It made her feel special – another man wanting her, lusting for her. It was a new experience, one she's never had before, even from Peter. *I was an easy mark for his advances*, Robin thinks to herself.

She knew her husband loved her, but she never felt he wanted to possess her. He was kind and loving in bed, never forceful or rough. Scott

was more of a beast in bed. He never hurt her. He knew where the threshold was and he never crossed it, but he did love pushing right up to it.

Now, Robin has a problem. Her heart is rent, two pieces, equal in size, but not enough for her husband. Peter demands it all. He doesn't understand. For Robin, love is unlimited. Infinity divided by two is still infinity. She needs to make him understand.

Robin falls asleep, thinking of her husband, but she dreams of her lover.

Vegas, Last April

“You order a drink yet?” Scott said. He was behind her, his hands placed casually on her waist.

She thought he was playing. They've known each other for less than two hours and already he was pushing boundaries, flirting with a married woman.

Robin liked it, the attention, and why shouldn't she? She was married, not dead. But maybe the hands on the hips were too much. She gently reached down and removed them.

“No,” she said, referring to his question, as well as his actions. “I was waiting for you. Did you get us a table?” She looked around and saw plenty of empty seats in the restaurant.

“I want to sit outside,” Scott said. He sat down on the stool next to Robin and made a show of placing his hands on the bar, neutral territory. He slid a square pager across to her. “Should be a table open in about twenty minutes.”

Robin felt good about fending off Scott's advances, but also disappointed. He gave up a little too easily.

Robin waved the bartender over. He was a young man, about twenty-two, his name tag read Jin-Ho and indicated he was from Korea. “Can I have a Tanqueray and tonic?” She was about to ask for two slices of lime when Scott interrupted.

“Hold up on that order, Jin,” he said, turning his attention to Robin. “Let me order you something else. I know you'll love it.” He didn't wait for her answer before turning back to the bartender. “A Johnny Walker Black for me and a mojito for the beautiful lady.”

“A mojito, huh?” Robin said. “Never had one of those.”

“It still has lime, but it's rum, not gin. And it has mint.”

“Sounds interesting.” At first, Robin was put off by Scott changing her order, but his charming demeanor made it easy to forgive.

They talked for a few moments – idle chit-chat – about the type of topics you use to get to know someone: where you're from, where you went to school. Scott was filling her in on the details of the spa he was opening in Kansas City when their drinks arrived.

Robin took a tentative sip of hers. It was minty and sweet, without a hint of alcohol flavor. She could easily get sloppy drunk on these and not know what hit her.

“Yummy,” she said and smiled at Scott. “This is tasty. Good call.”

“Knew you'd like it,” he said.

They both took a drink.

“So tell me, beautiful, what do you do to keep busy?”

Robin was so keen to listen to Scott talk, she totally missed the blatant flattery. “Not much, right now,” she said. “I've got a part-time job at a small clothing boutique in Tempe. Other than that, it's just puttering around the house”

“So, no kids?”

“Nope. Just me and Peter.”

“Sounds kinda boring.”

“Sometimes,” Robin said without thinking. Before this evening, she would have denied she could ever be happier than she was. This trip was well on its way to blowing up her previously contented perspective. “What do you do for fun?” she asked.

“Most of my time is devoted to my business. I love to work out. Luckily I can do that on the clock.”

“Must be nice.”

“It is. I also like surfing. Try to catch a wave every now and then.”

“Never been, but I love sitting on the beach.”

“Then you'd love my place in Cali,” Scott said. “One of my houses overlooks a really lovely spot on the Pacific. It's a little north of L.A.”

“You lucky shit,” Robin said, giving him a playful punch in the arm. Scott was taking a sip of his whiskey and he splashed a little on his lip.

“One of your houses?”

Scott licked off the stray drop of booze. Robin paused and watched, wondering what his tongue tasted like. It was so unlike her.

“It's a nice secluded beach,” he said. “Warm sands and gentle waves. It's public land, but hardly anyone knows about it, just me and a few neighbors.”

“You surf there?”

“Nah, not a good place for serious waves. If there were it'd be crawling with surfers.”

“Bet it's a great place to sunbathe. Relax, oil-up and get a really nice tan.”

“Absolutely,” Scott said. He looked around, making sure no one was paying attention and leaned into Robin.

She thought he was going to kiss her – why that idea popped into her head she couldn't tell. Wishful thinking?

He didn't. Scott brushed back a strand of her long brown hair and put his mouth next to her ear. Instead of kissing her, he whispered, "It's a really great place to work on my full body tan. I can lay out in the nude and get an even, golden tone all over my body."

Robin laughed. "You're so naughty, Scott" She couldn't help but blush as visions of this handsome man, without any clothing. She was picturing him laying out, his toned, well-defined body exposed. She'd love to know if he was a true blond and how big of a piece he was packing. She felt a tingle of desire building in her core. She grabbed his arm and immediately felt guilty.

Where's Peter, she thought. She was losing her self-control around this man, and worse still, she was loving every minute of it. She looked around the restaurant and was thrilled when she spotted her husband entering from the casino. *Saved*.

Robin waved him over. Scott gave an almost inaudible grunt of disgust, one Robin chose to ignore.

"What took you so long?" she asked, giving him a quick kiss on the cheek.

"I had a beer," Peter said. There were no empty seats at the bar, so he kept standing. "Didn't think we'd get a seat right away."

They continued chatting. Any sexual tension that might have developed between Scott and Robin was easing. Peter was about to ask Scott for some stock tips when the pager went off announcing their table was ready.

The threesome followed the hostess out to the patio. Peter was slightly ahead so he failed to notice Scott had reached his arm around Robin's waist,

placing his hand gently against the small of her back.

It was a simple gesture, a mere light touch that sent shivers up Robin's spine. She knew what Scott was doing, but she failed to stop him, content in the belief she could control any situation that arose. It was all a game to her, a harmless game. She was wrong.

The seduction of Robin had begun.

Peter

The drive back from Sedona was long, but not as long as the drive up. Robin and I talked, we argued, we screamed and we cried. For most the drive we sat in silence. It was hard, but I finally explained how I felt to her and I think she understood. I loved her and only her, and I wanted that same feeling in return from her. I didn't care if she slept with Scott, or any other man for that matter. I was beyond being jealous of her body. I didn't even care if she kept working for him. I just wanted to be the only one she loved and I didn't want her living with him. Call me selfish, but fuck you.

In the end, she asked for a few weeks to decide. I said yes. I dropped her off at the house Scott had bought in Sedona, the one they shared. We had a quick goodbye, hugged and kissed, and I left.

The long drive back through the desert, alone, refreshed me. My ultimatum to Robin was one of the signs of my new found confidence. Right now I didn't really know or care about how she felt. I was sure that would come later. I knew I still loved her, but currently I had other desires to take care of.

I pulled into the Oasis parking lot around six in the evening. It was a Tuesday, and finding a spot among the dozen or so cars was easy, half were parked away from the lounge in the employee zone.

I saw her as soon as I walked in, her red hair a beacon. Angie was behind the bar, pulling a pint of beer. She looked up and our eyes met. A smile appeared on her face. It felt good to know I could do that to a woman, I hoped it wasn't just because I was a good tipper.

I looked around. The place was mostly quiet. There was a couple sitting in one of the booths along the side wall. They were oblivious to their surrounding, playing kissy face with each other, their drinks sat untouched. The only other customer in the place was a middle aged white dude in a worn blue business suit sitting at the end of the bar, it was his beer Angie was pouring.

I walked to the bar with measured steps. I had a purpose and I had to keep my composure to pull it off. The red-head barkeep leaned across the bar and greeted me with a kiss on the cheek.

“Peter, it's great to see ya. You need a drink? Scotch right?”

I leaned closer “I can't stay long,” I said, my voice a whisper. “But there's something I've been wanting to do.”

Angie leaned closer still, joining my conspiracy. “What's that?” she asked under her breath.

“Do you trust me?”

She stood up straight. The question caught her off-guard, part of the purpose. A puzzled expression formed on her face. “Uhm – I don't know how to answer that.”

“Yes or no,” I said.

The guy at the end of the bar looked our way. He looked like he wanted in on the secret, and I'm sure he would have loved knowing what was going on. He opened his mouth, as if to say something, but then thought better of it and took another sip of his beer.

“Like I said, there's something I've wanted to do, something I should have taken care of several weeks ago, but didn't.”

I was thinking back to when I took her to the ballgame. We had a good time and later at her apartment Angie and I ended up making out. I was finally taking advantage of the bargain I had with my wife, that she could fuck Scott and I could fuck other women. It wasn't perfect, but it worked.

Angie squinted at me, raising one of her eyebrows. I had peaked her interest.

“What's that?” she asked.

“First, I need to know your answer. Do you trust me?”

She thought about it for a moment then said, “Okay, Peter. I guess I do trust you. You have seen me naked.”

“Can you step away from the bar for a few minutes?” I reached my hand out and uncurled my fingers, revealing the condom I had pulled from my pocket.

Angie's eyes grew wide and she smiled. “I'll get Rita to spell me.”

Rita turned out to be a waitress in the attached restaurant. She didn't have any tables so she agreed to babysit the bar while Angie took a break. She gave me a funny look as I followed Angie into the back. We walked down a dimly lit hall, doors to the restrooms on one side, boxes of beer bottles stacked on the other. At the end we came to a tee. Left was the kitchen, we went right, into the manager's office.

It was a small room, with a desk and filing cabinet on the far side of the door, a couch sat on along the wall to the right, more boxes of booze on the left.

Most of the other details of the room I missed since my attention was focused on the beautiful creature who stood before me. Her fiery locks were pulled back in a pony tail, her ample breasts looked constrained in the

black button-down shirt she wore, despite the fact she had several buttons undone. The shirt and a pair of black jeans completed her uniform. She leaned back casually, her butt on the edge of the desk, the palms of her hands, flat on top.

“So, what brought...”

“Shh.” I said, interrupting her. “No talking now. I’ll explain later. Just do as I say.”

Spitting all that out was hard. I wasn’t used to ordering women around, sexually. I did manage a few female assistants and secretaries at the clinic, but this was something different.

“Take off your pants,” I said, trying so hard not to snicker.

Angie looked pensive, as if she were trying to decide how far to let this go, how far she really trusted me. I guess my good nature and handsome face won her over, because she started to undo her belt without saying a word. I turned to lock the office door and when I turned around her jeans and undies were around her ankles and she was stepping out of them.

She was nude from the waist down. Her creamy white skin a lovely contrast to the black shirt that she started to unbutton.

I stopped her.

“No. No time,” I said.

I moved toward her, three or four steps and I was in front of her, nose to nose. I grabbed the back of her head with my right hand and pulled her face to mine, seizing her lips with my own. I kissed her hard and with a passion that caught me off guard. My tongue explored her willing mouth. The act of taking this beautiful woman thrilled me.

She tasted of bourbon and breath mints. An odd but intoxicating combination.

I glided my left hand down the front of Angie's shirt, my fingernails clicking along the buttons as I made my way down her torso to cup her bare mound. I could feel the soft downy texture of her pussy. With a finger I explored the folds of her labia, starting to moisten with her arousal.

I continued my kiss as I massaged her opening, my thumb playing across her clit as I thrust my fingers in and out. I continued this until Angie began moaning into my mouth.

“Oh, Peter. That's...”

“Shush. No talking.”

When making love to Robin, I was always concerned about how she felt, what she wanted me to do, if I was doing it right or too hard or too soft. Tonight was about me. What I wanted. What I was willing to take.

I continued finger fucking Angie, sliding my index and middle finger into her pussy as deep as they would go, while rubbing her throbbing clit with my thumb. I could feel her orgasm approaching. First she started moaning, a soft sensual sigh that quickly built to an urgent cry for release. Her breathing quickened and soon I was feeling her muscles contract around my fingers. This was a powerful climax.

To avoid detection, I moved quickly. Just as she came I forced my mouth over hers again, to catch her shouts of pleasure, muffling their volume, but not their intensity.

I held Angie tight as she came. I ran my fingers across her cheek, leaving a trail of her juices to mingle with a few tears falling from her eyes. This was a first for me, bringing a woman to tears with my sexual skills.

“Peter, that was amazing,” Angie said. “Ouch!”

I had slapped her naked ass.

“I didn't tell you to speak.” I said. I wasn't finished with Angie. I hoped she'd still respect me after tonight. I needed to know she was still

cool with our game. There wasn't a lot of time and we never talked about any boundaries or safe words. I guess she was okay, as long as she kept obeying my commands.

I bent down and picked up her panties, blue and white cotton, very practical. I sniffed them, my nose filled with the heady aroma of musk.

“What a bouquet.” I said, again stifling a giggle. “We need to keep you quiet, while I take you. Put these in your mouth.”

Angie's eyes got big at my outrageous demand, and for a moment I thought she would call me out on it, but then she tentatively took her panties and bit down on them.

“Now, turn around and bend over.”

My lovely companion did as I asked, turning her back to me and bending over the desk. She pushed her hands against the cork-board on the wall, her fingers scrunching the vendor invoices and employee schedules tacked up there.

Her ass looked so inviting. I smacked it again, eliciting another cry from Angie, this one muffled by her undies. Her butt check reddened where my palm landed. I smacked the other side so it matched.

I grabbed her hips and pulled her towards me, her hands slipped off the wall and slammed on the desk, papers went flying. While Angie stood there, bent over and vulnerable, I undid my shorts and dropped them around my ankles.

I spread Angie's ass open, just a bit, and stepped into her, rubbing my throbbing cock through her folds, sliding it through her wetness. I could hear her muffled moans.

“You have a wonderful butt, Angie,” I said. I rubbed the lubed up tip of my penis against her tight puckered ass. Her moans became louder and a

bit frantic. I was afraid I had gone to far, teasing her. I really wasn't planning on taking her in the ass, so I pulled back.

“Don't worry dear, there'll be no ass-fucking tonight.” I heard a sigh. “Maybe next time,” I added, with an unseen smile.

I quickly pulled out the condom and rolled it on. After using one with Robin and then Kelly, I was getting quite good at putting it on. My latex sheath fully in place, I shuffled forward a bit and thrust my cock into Angie's womb. I held still, enjoying the moment. She felt wonderfully tight, yet warm and inviting. Then, I slowly began pumping my hips back and forth, feeling her vaginal walls rub against my shaft. I felt powerful, in control, like an alpha male taking his woman. I ignored the tiny voice of guilt in the back of my head and continued pounding Angie. I knew she was enjoying herself because she pushed back with each of my thrusts, allowing for full penetration, my balls hitting her thighs.

I soon felt a tingle in the base of my cock, the first sign I was getting close. I took control, pulling and pushing Angie's ass at a frantic pace, feeling my climax grow, and then I felt my scrotum grow taut and I came, filling the rubber. The release was mind-numbing. For a second, I was back on the primal savannah, sewing my seed, before going off to die a cruel and brutish death. This was no petite-mort.

After I was throughly spent I pulled out. Part of me wanted to drop the role-play, but I didn't. I liked being in control, dominate and uncaring. It was so not-me.

I took off the condom and dropped it in the trash can next to the desk. I made sure there was a plastic liner so it wouldn't make too much of a mess.

Angie turned around and looked at me. She was fiercely working her fingers over her clit. She obviously hadn't come yet, and she wasn't waiting

for me to give her permission. Any other time I would have stayed to help, probably with my tongue, but I was playing the dick tonight.

“Love to stay and watch you get off,” I said, “but I gotta go.”

I pulled my pants up and turned to leave. I stopped at the door. I walked back over to Angie and watched her continue to masturbate, her moans increasing. Her eyes were closed so I surprised her when I said, “I’ll take these,” and pulled her panties out of her mouth and put them in my pocket. I kissed her on the cheek and left the office.

I heard her final climatic scream as I walked down the hall and out the back exit.

On the drive home I felt dirty, like a real creep. I didn’t know how some men did it. Thinking of women as just fuck toys, to use as needed and discard.

I love women. I love to pleasure women. But I guess every so often one needs to step out of their comfort zone.

I was going to have to write Angie and very long and very contrite thank you note in the morning.

And maybe send a bunch of flowers.

I didn’t get back to Angie on Wednesday like I intended. Too many injured pets to deal with along with working on the details of the expansion of our veterinary clinic. Alex, our pharmaceutical rep called for clarification on some drug orders and by the time I was ready to leave, I was too tired to stop by the bar.

I thought I’d be able to stop by on the weekend, but that didn’t happen, either. No real excuse for me, I just forgot.

It wasn't until the following Friday that I finally manned up and went to see her. On the way to the Oasis, I stopped at a florist to pick up a bouquet of roses, three pink and three yellow. I wanted her to know I enjoyed the time I was spending with her, but that I didn't really want a serious relationship. I needn't have worried.

“Peter, where you been?” the red-head shouted across the bar the moment I walked in. “Planning another hit and run?”

I didn't say anything. Rita, the waitress was walking behind me and snickered. I guess Angie told her about our encounter.

“Hey, Angie,” I said, ignoring the barb. The bar was pretty busy but I was able to squeeze in to one of the few open seats.

“You been taking notes from Jason?” Angie said, a sarcastic bite to her voice. Jason was her boyfriend; he might have been her ex by now. “You don't stop by, you don't call.”

“Sorry,” I said. I kept the flowers hidden behind my back. “Been busy at work.”

“Water under the bridge, Pete. What'll you have.”

“Sam Adams.”

“What? No Scotch?”

“Feel like something different today.”

Angie leaned across the bar and lowered her voice. My attention was drawn to the tantalizing cleavage spilling out of the black button down shirt she wore. “Like maybe swapping out a blond for this red-head?”

“Never!” I took on a mock air of outrage. I handed the flowers to my friend with benefits. “These are for you.”

“Nice.” Angie tried to play it cool, but I could see a hint of her true feelings. I could tell she was a little surprised and impressed. “Okay, I take

that back. Jas would never have bothered with these.” She took the roses and put them in an ice bucket full of water.

She told Kenny, the other bartender, that she was taking a quick break and she came around the bar. She tapped the shoulder of the guy on the stool next to me and said, “be a sweetheart and move down.” He was a slightly portly fellow, a broken halo of brownish-grey hair on his mostly bald head. She threw him the sweetest, yet sexiest smile I’d ever witnessed. The poor guy had no choice, but to move. It was in his DNA. She gave the guy a quick peck on the cheek as way of a thank you. He blushed and went back to drinking.

I was the first to speak. “I really want to apologize for what happened last week. I’ve been working out some issues and I took it out on you. I shouldn’t have.”

“Peter, you’ve got nothing to be sorry about. I didn’t let you do anything I didn’t want you to.” She looked at the guy next to her. He didn’t seem to be paying us any attention, but she leaned in close to me and lowered her voice anyway. “It wasn’t the best sex I’ve ever had, but it wasn’t bad, just different.”

“Did you enjoy it?”

“A little. I came didn’t I?”

“Yeah, I guess. So we’re good?”

Angie shook her head, her rusty locks swished back and forth. “Oh, no, no, Peter. We are not good.”

“Then you are mad?”

“No. Not mad. I just don’t think we’re even. The flowers are a good start, but they aren’t going to paper over what you did. I have plans for you.”

She had a weird grin on her face as she reached over and took a sip of my beer. It was a look that told me she had given plenty of thought to payback, and I was frightened.

“A plan? For me?” I said with a little bit of trepidation.

“Oh, yes, Peter. I got a plan for you.” Angie stood up. “Break time's over. I gotta get back to work.” The gorgeous red-head moved behind me and whispered into my ear. “Do you trust me?”

I got hard thinking of the possibilities.

The next morning, Saturday, I called my wife. She answered on the third ring.

“Sedona Spirit Rejuvenation Spa and Fitness Center, this is Robin, how can I make your day better.”

I couldn't help but snicker at that mouthful of a greeting.

“Peter, is that you?”

“Yeah. Using the personal phone for business, I see.”

“The office lines are getting installed next month and I'm doing a lot of work off-site. So, yes, I'm using my personal phone for business.”

“You might want to change that name. It's really long and people might hang-up on you before you finish.”

“You're funny. Nope, the name stays. Maybe I'll shorten the pitch.

After the small talk, it was time to get down to why I'd called. “You think any more about what I said?”

“You mean about us?” Robin asked. I knew she was stalling, but I really didn't have the heart to call her out on it with any malice. Hell, I was enjoying my own extra-marital affairs so I really couldn't be too aggressive.

“Yeah, about us. About you and Scott.”

Silence on the line. I could hear her taking long deep breathes. I could almost picture the look on her face, her hazel eyes staring off into the middle distance. Maybe she was reaching for a strand of her hair before realizing she'd had it cut short in Vegas. I gave her a few moments before breaking the silence.

“You still there, Robin?” I said, knowing full well she was.

After a pregnant pause she said, “yeah, I'm thinking.”

“What is there to think about?”

“Peter,” my wife said. The volume of her voice caught me by surprise. “I love you, but you don't seem to believe me.”

“Bull shit. I do believe you, Robin. I also believe you love Scott, and that's the problem.” More silence; I continued. “I'm finding it so hard to share you, share your heart.”

“What about Kelly or that Angie girl?”

“Robin, I don't love them.”

“But you'll fuck them.”

As far as I knew, Robin couldn't have known I'd fucked Angie. But I couldn't really deny it either. “Yes, I fucked them and I enjoyed it.” I couldn't help throwing that barb in. “But I don't love them. I love you.”

“I know. I love you, too.” My wife paused before adding, “I can't turn off my feelings for Scott.” More silence. “I'm not a robot.”

“I need to know where I stand with you,” I said. “I need to know if you still want to be my wife.”

“Goddamit, Peter! Yes. I want to be your wife. What do you want from me.”

She knew damn well what I wanted. She needed to break up with Scott.

“I want you, Robin. All of you. Nothing else, but you.”

“Would you give up your other girlfriends?” If my wife thought she had me over a barrel, she was wrong.

“In a heartbeat,” I said. And I meant it. I enjoyed the sex, but Robin was my priority.

More silence on the line, but this time I heard a little sniffing. I didn't mean to make my wife cry, but it was good to know she cared.

“I know you want an answer from me, Peter. You deserve an answer. I'm just not feeling too well and I can't give you one right now.”

I wasn't satisfied with that, but it was what I expected. Robin never liked to be forced to do anything. She always needed to act on her own volition.

“It's been a week,” I said. I needed to know if my marriage was still intact or if I needed to get a lawyer. I didn't, however, want to put it in those words. “How much more time do you need?”

“Peter.” Robin paused. Was she going to answer me, finally? I hoped so, yet I didn't. I so wanted to hear her say she didn't really love Scott anymore and she was coming back to me. No more boyfriends.

I would have been more than willing, hell, I'd be eager to continue our open relationship – both of us enjoying all the strange we wanted as long as I knew I was the only one she loved. That's what I really wanted – an open marriage. I'll admit, I really liked sex with Kelly, and Angie, she was someone I'd love to explore. Maybe a threesome with the two of them, maybe get Robin involved. The opportunities were endless.

That would be the best of all possible worlds, my utopia. I'd settle for going back to our life pre-Vegas, pre-Scott.

“Peter, I need more time.”

I was frustrated with the answer and I was relieved by it as well. I wanted an answer, but as long as Robin didn't make one, I knew it wasn't Scott. I was Schrödinger's cuckold. I didn't know what to say. I wanted to know her choice but I didn't want that answer to be my rival.

Luckily, I didn't have time to demand an answer. My phone buzzed with another call; it was work related.

“Robin, I need an answer.”

“I don't have one, yet.”

“I've got another call- hold on.” I switched over to the other line. It was Alex Spenser, from Glossman Pharma, our main drug supplier.

“Hey, Peter, you got a minute?”

“Alex. I'm on the other line, let me end that, then I'm free.”

I switched back over to Robin. I had decided to give her two more weeks. I was angry and glad, worried and relieved, in limbo yet weirdly calm. I was a mishmash of emotions.

“I need to take this,” I said to my wife. “Tell you what, I've got a three day weekend coming up at the end of the month. I'll come up to Sedona and we can talk. Either work things out or make plans for our separation.”

“God, Peter. I don't want it to come to that.”

I wanted to scream, but I didn't. “That's up to you, I guess. Gotta go.”

“I love you, Peter.”

“I know,” I said. I wanted to hang up with that, be like Han Solo at the end of Empire Strikes Back. I'm not that cool. “I love you, too, Robin. Bye.”

I ended the call and took a few seconds to collect myself before opening the line to Alex.

“Thanks for holding, what has you calling on the weekend?”

“Just doing some scheduling. I'll make this quick,” my drug rep said. They were good words to hear, I wasn't in the mood for a lengthy conversation right now. “I'm putting together my calendar for September and I want to stop by your clinic.”

“Sounds good. Have you talked to Brian?” Brian Dawson was the owner of the veterinary office I worked at. There were three other doctors that had input on business decisions, including me, but Brian had the final say.

“Not yet,” Alex said. “I wanted to talk to you first, make sure you'd be there. I wouldn't have this contract without you.”

I wanted to brush off Alex so bad, but I couldn't. I owed him so much. He was the one who let me use his room in Vegas. That was how I caught my wife cheating. I might have never known she had fucked Scott if I hadn't been able to hide in Alex's spare room and sneak through the adjoining door.

Then again. If I didn't know, I'd never have asked her to let me watch them have sex and I never would have participated. And Scott might have become a one-off affair, his encounter with my wife in Vegas might have stayed in Vegas.

Lots of if's, I needed to focus on reality.

“Okay, what's your calendar look like?” I asked.

“I got the first week of September and the last. What looks good to you?”

My confrontation with Robin was set for the beginning of the month. I wasn't so sure I'd be up to discussing serious business shit with anyone right after that.

“Let's make it the end of September.”

“Cool. I'll call your office later next week, after I work out the details.”

“Okay. Looking forward to seeing you again, Alex.”

“Same here. Maybe I can buy you a drink, after talking shop first of course.”

“Count me in.”

“Sorry for interrupting your weekend.”

“No problem. Not much going on anyway.” It was so true, yet still so false.

We said our goodbyes and hung up. I decided it would be a good time to finish the Lee Child novel that had been sitting on my nightstand for the last three weeks. There is nothing like a mindless thriller to help you forget how much your own life sucks.

Chapter 2

Robin

She wakes up. The light from the sun's rays, reflecting off the red rock formations, streams through the window and bathes the bedroom in a bloody glow. Or is it a dream?

Robin rubs her eyes and the light regains its healthy yellow hue. She sits up and immediately regrets it. Her head is spinning. Odd, she doesn't remember drinking too much the night before. She had a couple of glasses of wine with the one skillet meal she made for herself. The idea of food sends her stomach churning.

She hasn't been eating well, living alone, it's not worth the effort it takes to cook a proper meal. Instead, it's lots of pre-packaged and take-out food.

Robin remembers, it's Saturday, Peter is coming today. Her stomach lurches and she races off to dry heave into the toilet. Nothing comes out but a few strings of saliva. Today is not the day to be sick. Her future happiness is hanging on the line and she still hasn't made up her mind how she is going to answer her husband's ultimatum.

She loves him, no doubt, but he's made her so mad, forcing her to chose. She's thinking about telling him to fuck off. She coughs up another mouthful of spit at the thought of living her life without him. Now, there's a few small bits of last night's meal floating in the bowl.

She thinks about calling Scott. He's always good for a jolt of emotional energy. He'll say how much he loves spending time with her, how beautiful she is, and how confident he is in her ability to get the spa up and running.

She's starting to feel better thinking about his low, sexy voice coming through her smartphone speaker.

Maybe she'll make a video call and get to see his handsome face, his lovely mess of wavy blond hair, his proudly chiseled nose and his delicious lips. She aches for her lover and his encouraging words. His wit and powerful hands can put any problem to right. She's getting wet remembering what it feels like to let Scott take control of her willing body. She lays back on the cold tile floor and recalls the first time she opened her body to him.

Vegas, Last April

Robin hesitated before sending the text. She had just said goodbye to her husband. She could still taste him in her mouth.

She felt a chill run up her back, her skin was still dripping wet from her shower and flushed from pink to red at the thought of fucking another man. For the first time in eight years a strange cock was going to invade her, fill her in ways she wasn't used to.

She didn't even bother to get dressed. Instead she brushed her teeth, hoping to wash away any hint of her husband from her mouth. She wanted to be clean for her lover. A light breeze of guilt wafted over her at the thought, but it quickly passed. Even though it felt wrong, Robin was intoxicated with erotic thoughts and she let it slide.

She had left Peter satisfied; she let him cum in her mouth for the first time. For him, that was. She had let Scott do it the night before, when she sucked him off, instead of fucking him.

Maybe saying she let him do it was too kind. Scott hadn't asked if it was okay; he took her mouth and claimed it. She was proud she was able to swallow it all. Her whole life she believed a proper woman didn't let men

come in her mouth; it was base and dirty. Funny, how having a cock erupt on your tongue can change your whole perspective. The sudden salty load felt slimy against the back of her throat, but looking up at the glow of satisfaction on her man's face was worth it.

She was sorry she had denied Peter all these years. Giving Scott a blow job wasn't what made Robin feel bad, feel guilty, it was knowing she should have been doing this with Peter all along.

After rinsing her mouth, she sent the text, letting Scott know Peter was back at the conference. She got a quick reply.

- Be up in 5.

Robin grabbed a silk robe and threw it on. It didn't cover much. Her hard nipples were easily visible through the semi-transparent material, although the Japanese floral pattern did hide them somewhat. In the back it barely covered half her ass cheeks. The robe was mostly for adding a hint of modesty when walking to the pool in her bikini. Right now it would serve as a little bit of wrapping for Scott to remove.

She sat down on the couch and fidgeted. She tried a sensual pose, laying sideways with her legs stretched out. She quickly moved to an eager pose, back straight, knees tucked under her body. Lastly, she took a wanton pose, sitting back, feet on the floor, knees split wide exposing her dripping pussy.

She realized she was getting carried away – being silly. Scott didn't have a key to the room. She was going to have to meet him at the door.

The anticipation made her giddy, like a kid waiting for Christmas or the end of school. She looked over at the kitchen area and saw the mess she had made setting up her lunch date with Peter. The cutting board and knife she used to cut the vegetables and cheeses she laid on her naked body was sitting on the counter, as was the jar of cherries.

Suddenly all the eagerness fled and for the first time, Robin really thought about what she was doing. She had spent more time with a stranger on this trip than with Peter, and she hadn't noticed the affect the man had on her. Scott made Robin feel desired in a way her husband couldn't.

Peter was comfortable and loving and a perfect mate for her. Why was she willing to risk that for one sexual encounter? Robin couldn't come up with an answer for that question. She only knew she was going to do it. She was going to have her affair - sew her oats - then go back to Phoenix, with only memories and a willingness to be more adventurous in bed with her husband.

So, even he was getting a benefit out of her infidelity, and he'd never have to know the source.

Robin was rationalizing her cheating away when Scott knocked on the door. At that moment all thoughts of Peter and her marriage and her life back in Phoenix left her.

She answered the door in her robe and a smile and nothing else. Her heart was racing, sending a mix of hormones throughout her body. Butterflies fluttered in her stomach as she thought about how naughty she was being. She was nervous, stepping out of her comfort zone, but so anxious to do it. Her fingers fumbled with the door handle and her pussy throbbed in anticipation. She could feel a few drops of wetness trickle down her thigh as her body prepared to receive her lover.

Scott entered the room and stepped into Robin's awaiting arms. They kissed, their lips consuming the passion that radiated from their bodies. Her hands were around his torso, her fingers digging into the silk fabric of the shirt he wore. He took her face in his hands as his tongue explored her mouth. The aroma of her arousal - musky and loud - filled the small space between them.

They moved to the bedroom, never separating, but somehow removing their clothes as they went.

Robin lay naked on the bed pinned beneath Scott's larger, stronger body. She basked in the feeling of his smooth skin pressed against her breasts, her nipples hardened by the contact. Goosebumps dotted the skin across her chest.

She could feel his erection rubbing against her wet and aching opening. She was ready to be filled. She reached for his cock and pulled her hands across its taut surface. A moan escaped Scott's lips. His head was next to hers and he whispered, "Put it in." It was a command, one she was eager to comply with, but she hadn't lost all control.

"Did you bring them?" she said, speaking of the condoms he bought last night. She wasn't sure she had the strength to call off their coupling if he had forgotten them. Luckily, he hadn't.

Scott momentarily parted from Robin and reached for his pants. She sighed as his body moved away from her, already missing the contact.

The brief separation made her remember that what she was doing was wrong. She knew Peter would be devastated if he ever found out. She didn't want that. She would make sure her affair was never discovered. It was a wild fling, a time-out, one that would end and only live on in her memories and dreams. She was sure Peter would never find out and would never be hurt.

The sound of ripping foil brought her wandering mind back to the moment. She watched in fascination as Scott deftly rolled the latex condom over his beautiful shaft. It was a good sized cock. Not much longer than Peter's, an inch or so maybe, it was definitely thicker and would fill her in ways she hadn't experienced before – ever. When he was fully sheathed,

Scott returned to bear down on Robin, his cock poised at her awaiting entrance.

She looked up into his eyes, ignoring everything else: his strong chest, tight abs and intriguing dragon tattoo around his left nipple. She was totally under his control, she would do anything he asked.

“Put it in.” Again, the demand was eagerly received.

Robin reached down and grasped his cock, guiding it to her dripping wet slit. She rubbed the tip against her engorged clitoris and sparks of lust and desire shot through her. She slipped it past her puffy lips and let it go – allowing her lover to take control. With three or four slow steady thrusts he was in – to the hilt – and Robin was filled with sexual bliss. Her vaginal muscles clenched tight as Scott pumped his cock in and out.

“Oh, Scott. That feels. So. Good,” Robin said. She was just able to get the words out between each hard push. Each time he bottomed out she could feel his pelvic bone rub her clit and she sensed her climax quickly approaching.

“Oh, God.. Scott. I'm cumming.” And she did, hard and completely. Her eyes snapped shut and her entire existence was the tiny bundle of nerves between her legs that were sending wild and crazy signals to her brain. She let out a scream, or at least she thought she did. Her climax was her world. She was vaguely aware that Scott kept pumping – riding her through her orgasm. When she was finished, he leaned down and kissed her gently on the lips.

“Was it good for you?” he asked. A sweet smile shone on his face.

She tensed her pussy walls around his still hard member.

“I guess that means yes,” her lover said. “Ready for more?”

Robin's eyes bulged in surprised when she realized Scott hadn't come yet. She nodded.

Scott withdrew and flipped her over, pulling her up to her knees and entered her from behind. He drove his cock into her for a good five minutes until she felt it pulse inside her. Scott let out a few deep grunts as he filled the condom.

The couple rested for a bit and then got a new condom for another round. This time Scott went slower. Robin came three more times before her lover had his release. They lay back together spread out on the bed.

Robin was the first to regain her senses. She got off the bed and gathered up the stray wrappers and used condoms. While she was doing this, Scott kept groping her and kissing her neck and generally slowing her down.

“You gotta leave, Scott,” she said. “I have to meet my husband for dinner.”

“Make an excuse. Come have dinner with me.” Scott's face was nestled on her shoulder. His warm breath excited the hairs on her neck as he spoke.

“Tempting, but no.” she said and firmly pushed him away. She loved Peter, nothing would change that. She needed to make sure he never found out about this affair.

She tucked the evidence of their debauchery into a plastic bag and handed it to Scott as she pushed him out the door.

“Could you get rid of this please?” she said.

“Gladly,” he said. “It's a small price to pay for the privilege of making love to you. Will I see you again?”

She wasn't sure. She wanted to, and maybe even planned to, but she wasn't willing to lose Peter. “Maybe,” she said. “I'll call you.”

With a quick kiss he was gone.

Robin slumped against the door as it closed and looked into the room. Like a rubber band stretched past the point of breaking, the guilt hit her. The pain and regret of giving her body over to another man slammed into her heart, causing her stomach to churn and making her slightly nauseous.

Scott was a temptation she had to resist. She decided to stick close to Peter for the rest of the trip. It was her third anniversary, after all. She didn't want it to be her last.

Peter

It was around four in the afternoon when I rounded the last curve and saw Cathedral Rock glowing red-orange in the evening sun.

Sedona is a unique place – a town tucked away next to the Verde River in North Central Arizona. It's surrounded by national forest and is accessible by just three two-lane roads. It's known mainly for its red-rock formations – buttes and mesas with obvious names like Bell Rock and Castle Rock and the aforementioned Cathedral Rock. They're formed from red sandstone found nowhere else.

Because of this uniqueness, Sedona is a magnet for an amazing assortment of tourists. Some are drawn for the beauty: artists, photographers and nature lovers. Some come to visit the historic native sites. Others come for the mystical atmosphere created by the one-of-a-kind geography. You can't take five steps through downtown without passing an art gallery, new age shop or native craft store. Often, one shop will cater to all three types of visitors.

Where there are tourists there'll be a massive hospitality industry close behind: restaurants, gas stations, many hotels and resorts and, of course, my wife's new spa.

The Spirt Spa (that's what I'm calling it from now on) was located on the site of one those resorts. I passed it on the way to Robin's house - the house Scott, her boss and lover, bought her. It didn't occur to me until that moment, that this might be the last time I visited her here.

I turned up one of the steep roads that branched off the main highway through town. Her house, their house, was located on a high plot that afforded a beautiful view of the river basin below. Since my mind was pre-occupied with the discussion I knew was coming, the beauty was lost on me.

During the two hour drive from Phoenix, I ran over all the arguments I thought she might have. I couldn't think of any that would convince me to leave Sedona content with how our relationship – how our marriage – had changed. Bottom line was, I wanted to be the only man she loved and that meant Scott had to go.

I pulled up to the house. Robin's SUV was in the drive so I parked on the road. There were no other cars nearby, that, at least, was a good sign.

I walked up to the front door and knocked. It wasn't my house; I didn't have a key. There was no answer right away. After a moment, I knocked again and tried the door handle. It was unlocked so I entered.

This was the first time I'd been in the house. When I dropped off Robin the last time, I stayed in the car. The house was small and sparsely furnished. A couch and coffee table facing a small television on a roll-away cart made up most of the living room décor. The attached dining room had a small round table with four chairs around it. A bookcase sat against the far wall next to a doorway I assumed led to the kitchen. A hallway went off to the right.

There appeared to be no one home, but I knew my wife had to be here. I called out to her, “Robin?” There was no answer. Maybe Scott was here,

maybe she was out with him checking out the spa, or having dinner at some local restaurant, or maybe pulled over in some forest clearing, fucking away like teenagers in the back of his rental car.

That was stupid. They had a bed here – I assumed – why sneak away. It's not like they have to hide from me.

I pulled out my phone and called Robin's number. After a short pause, I heard a familiar tune coming from down the hall. It was the opening bars to Reminiscing by the Little River Band. It was our song. It was also the ringtone Robin attached to my number. I disconnected and the tune stopped.

“I'm coming back,” I said as I went down the hall. “Hope you're decent,” I added, half joking.

I found Robin in the largest of the two bedrooms. She was laying, fully-clothed, face down on the bed, her head in her hands. There was a half-empty glass of red wine on the nightstand and what looked like a fully-empty bottle in the trash can next to it. The only other things in the room were a couple of my wife's suitcases.

“Honey, are you alright?” I said. She wasn't moving, but she appeared to be breathing. I gave her a tap on the shoulder and she jumped, pushing her torso up off the mattress.

“Wha?” she said. She saw me and relaxed a bit. “You got here. Good.”

Robin's face was a mess. Her eye's were bloodshot, she had lines of dried tears down her cheeks, and what little mascara she had on was badly smudged.

“You okay?” I asked.

“Sure, sure. I just need a drink.” She reached for the glass, but I grabbed it before she did. I drained it myself. It was a cabernet, very fruit

forward. “What the hell, you do that for?” Robin pulled her eyes tight.

“I needed a drink, too,” I said. I looked down at the empty bottle in the trash. “I’ll go get you some water.”

I went to the kitchen and got us both a glass of water. As I passed the kitchen table I noticed a small drugstore bag. I didn’t look inside.

Robin was in the bathroom when I returned. I heard the faucet running.

“I got your water.”

“Thanks.”

I sat down on the bed and took a sip. The water had a mineral taste that I didn’t like. I had been spoiled with treated city water. I grimaced and took another sip while I waited for my wife to re-appear.

Robin looked much better when she came out of the bathroom, at least physically. Her brown hair was brushed back and held out of her face with a hair band. It had been almost six months since she had cut it short and she was allowing it to grow back, a decision I greatly approved of, if it mattered. Her eyes were a little clearer and the errant make-up had been removed.

She sat down next to me and took a couple gulps of water, draining half the glass.

“You okay?” I asked.

“No,” she said. It was an answer I was expecting, but still shocked to actually hear. When most people are asked that question, the immediate response is some variation of ‘I’m fine,’ even if they’re not. Saying no just begs for the follow-up.

“What’s wrong?”

Robin stared ahead. I waited, hoping she was just trying to formulate the right answer. She took another drink – this time only a sip. She turned

to look at me; her eyes were unsure. Her lips parted as if she was going to say something, but she didn't.

I was getting nervous. "Robin, what's the matter?"

She looked at me and shook her head.

"Is it the spa?"

She kept shaking her head, but with more vigor. She meant no. It was good to get an actual response. This was progress.

"Is it about us?"

She still moved her head back and forth, but with less emphasis.

"Is it about Scott?"

Still shaking, but her speed slowed until it was almost imperceptible.

I was feeling a bit queasy. I thought she might be trying to work up the courage to tell me she had chosen Scott. I didn't want to ask any more questions, but I had to know. It was why I was in Sedona to begin with. This was no time to given in.

"So it does have something to do with Scott?" I tried to keep the tinge of anger out of my voice, but I wasn't sure I succeeded.

Robin's eyes opened a little bit wider and her expression turned hesitant – not like she had been very forthcoming up to this point anyway. Eventually she started nodding.

"Yes," she said. Her voice was cracking, she took another sip of water. "And it does kinda concern you, too."

This is it, I thought. She's going to tell me to call a lawyer.

"I'm pregnant." Robin said.

I dropped my glass. That was not what I was expecting at all.

The water spilled on the floor, but luckily the glass didn't break; it hit the padded carpet.

“How?” It was all I could say. She was on birth control, we'd been using condoms for the last month and I assumed she was doing the same with Scott. Scott. He was the... He impregnated my wife.

I wanted to be so mad, a primal fury was building in me and I knew I couldn't let it blow up on Robin, even if she was partly to blame.

“I've been so careful,” she said. Her head was bowed, her eyes boring holes in the floor.

“We used condoms.” I was stating the obvious, but I had to say something. Remaining silent would just allow the anger to build.

“Yes. I don't think you're...” she couldn't finish the sentence.

“Did you and Scott stop using them?” I asked. I couldn't keep the venom out of my voice. I saw Robin's face scrunch up as the angry words hit their target.

“We had been,” she said. “But in Seattle. We ran out.”

“They don't sell them there?”

Nothing. My cynical barbs weren't encouraging Robin to open up. I needed to calm myself down.

“I'm sorry,” I said. “I shouldn't say that. I just. I just need to know.”

“We were fooling around. It was late. Scott went to get one and. Well, the box was empty.”

I wanted to interrogate her. Ask her if he said anything when he used the last one. I kept my mouth shut.

She continued, “we could have stopped. We should have stopped. But, we didn't. I was on my new birth control and near the end of the safety period. I thought it would be safe.”

You were wrong, I screamed in my head.

“I guess I was wrong,” she said, giving a voice to my thoughts.

My mind went to what we would do next. In the early years of our marriage we thought about having kids, but Robin's gynecologist strongly recommended against it. My wife had treatable high blood pressure that made carrying a pregnancy to term life-threatening to both her and the baby. I didn't need to spell it out to her, but I had to ask the question.

“What are you going to do?” I didn't want to assume anything. I couldn't force her to get an abortion, but it would be my preferred course of action, for many reasons.

I wasn't going to raise another man's child. I loved Robin, but if she chose to keep the child with all the risks that incurred, we would have to divorce.

My top reason, though, was I didn't want anything to happen to Robin. I loved her and would never want any harm to come to her.

“I don't know,” she said.

“But you do know it could kill you. Having a child.”

“Yes, Peter. I know that.”

“Don't get mad at me for bringing that up,” I said. I was raising my voice to match hers. “You and Scott are to blame for this mess.” I felt like a heel the moment the words left my mouth. Here was Robin, facing a life or death situation and I was letting petty anger and jealousy get the better of me.

My wife looked at me. I could see a small tear in the corner of her eye. The longer I looked the larger it became.

“I'm sorry,” I said, lower my voice. “I shouldn't have said that.”

Then Robin said something I wasn't expecting, “I don't blame you.”

Now it was my turn to be speechless.

“I've been treating you like shit, I know,” she continued. “I love you, Peter. I will always love you, no matter what.”

They were nice words to hear, but deep down they rang hollow. I wanted to argue the point but the current pregnancy crisis (and it was a crisis, as in life-threatening) caused me to hold my tongue. Instead of being a cynical bastard, I put my arm around my wife and pulled her in for a hug. My heart ached for her, and for myself.

“I don't want to lose you like this, Robin.”

“What do you think I should do?” My wife looked up at me, her eyes were pleading for answers

“The only logical thing would be to have an abortion.” My motivation was pure. Maybe part of me was pissed because Scott was the one who knocked her up, but I was one hundred percent sure I would have suggested the same thing, even if I had been the father. Robin's well-being was my top priority.

“I figured you'd say that,” she said. My wife bent her head down and stared into my chest. I so wanted to call her on the bullshit, but I didn't.

“Then, what are you going to do?” I asked again.

“I told you. I don't know.”

“The sooner you make a decision, the better.”

“Lay off me!”

I shut up. Nothing I could say right now would make the situation any better. If I could, I would go back in time and buy them the damn condoms. But then, if I could do that, I'd go back and agree to play slots in Vegas like Robin had suggested, thus avoiding our run in with Scott at the roulette table.

“I don't know what to do,” she said again. It had become a mantra. Like she did know what she should do, but couldn't actually make the

move. I didn't say anything. It was a decision she would have to make herself.

I was cradling Robin against my body when she said something else that felt like a punch in the gut. "I wish Scott was here."

What. The. Fuck. I wanted to scream. I was trying to comfort her, all the while dealing with my own roiling emotions.

"Have you told him yet?" My voice was as flat and dry as the desert highway.

"No. I took a home test today. You're the first to know."

"So, you haven't been to the doctor?"

"No."

"Then you can't be sure,"

"Peter. I took two tests. I've got the symptoms. I'm sure."

I wanted to try to calm her, tell her she might be wrong, but I didn't feel it. She was sure, so I was sure.

"Do you want to call him and tell him?"

"This isn't something I can say over the phone."

"You need him here?"

"Yes."

"Okay. Call him and tell him to come out."

"He's busy. He's got other business to deal with."

"Dammit Robin. Wake the fuck up. This is your life."

"Peter..."

"Don't Peter me." I felt stupid trying to convince Robin to call her lover, but I did it anyway. "If you need to tell him anything, and I'd argue you don't, call him and tell him to get his ass out here."

"But..."

“Robin, you're a stronger woman than this. You've got a husband and a lover and you're building a new business from scratch. Don't tell me you don't have the ovaries to deal with an un-intended pregnancy.” Something I said must have hit the right chord.

“You're right, Peter. I'll call him.”

While she tried to reach Scott, I drove down into town to pick us up some fast food – burgers and fries. When I got back, Robin was sitting on the couch sipping wine, a newly opened bottle of white sat on the coffee table.

I thought that wasn't a wise thing for a pregnant woman to do, but since I really didn't see her carrying it to term, I kept my mouth shut. Instead, I poured myself a glass and plated out dinner.

“Did you get hold of Scott?” I said, just before taking a bite of my burger.

“Yeah,” Robin said. “I told him it was urgent he come out here. He said he's getting the next flight out to Phoenix. He should be here tomorrow evening.”

We ate in silence for a little while.

“You don't have to stay,” my wife said. She was swirling a french fry around in her ketchup. “Not if you don't want to. This is my problem. Not yours.” Her words said one thing, but her eyes – they implored me to stay.

“Robin, any issue you have to face involves me. I'm staying, unless you kick me out.”

A soft sigh blew past her lips.

“I'm here for you, love,” I said. “And I always will be.”

We drank some wine, ate our burgers and watched a movie on cable. We went to bed early; the drive and the emotional turmoil had me exhausted and I'm sure Robin wasn't feeling any better. We both slept in

her bed, but we didn't make love. We were still not in the right space. I couldn't say how she felt, but until I knew I was her only true love I didn't think I'd be able to have sex with her.

I went to sleep, fearing what tomorrow would bring. That morning, I just wanted to know if my wife wanted to remain married to me. Now that seemed like the least of our worries.

As I drifted off to sleep, I knew one thing for sure. I would support any choice she made. Whether it was as her husband or a very close friend.

Scott wasn't suppose to be in Sedona until six, but I guess he broke a few traffic laws because around four o'clock he came barging into the living room like he owned the place; he did own the place.

Robin and I hadn't discussed her condition any further. We had gone over it pretty well the previous day and she wasn't going to make a decision one way or the other without Scott's input. I understood that, I accepted that, but I didn't like that. Accepting the unacceptable seemed to have become a skill I was honing to a razor's edge.

"Where is she?" were the first words out of his mouth, followed closely by, "And what are you doing here?"

"She's my wife and I'm allowed to be here," I said, wanting to add *asshole*. "She's in the bedroom," I said instead.

Scott went back down the hall and I followed. Robin was wearing just a towel wrapped round her slim figure; she had finished taking a shower. My wife was blow drying her hair and was startled when Scott came up from behind and put his arms around her.

“You okay, Bunny?” He turned her around and kissed her on the lips. That was a new one, Bunny. Seemed like a pretty condescending pet name to me, but I guess it was better than Sugar or Dollface. Robin didn't seem to mind it. Scott held her for a moment; she didn't pull away.

“Scott, you're early,” my wife said once he released her. I really would have liked to know what her term of endearment for him was.

“You sounded upset when you called, so I got here as fast as I could.” He turned to look at me. “Why didn't you tell me Peter was going to be here?”

“Then you might not have rushed or you might have asked why I wanted to see you.”

“So, you're okay.” It was a statement of fact and a question.

“Kinda.”

Scott's eyebrows furrowed. “What does that mean?” He wasn't very bright, but that was just my opinion.

“I'll tell you in a sec. Let me get dressed. You and Peter go have a drink.”

Reluctantly Scott joined me in the dining room for a glass of wine.

“Sorry we don't have any scotch,” I said. “Will a chilled Pinot Grigio do?”

Scott took the glass and said, “what's with the 'we', this is my house, not yours.”

“Just trying to be polite.”

“We'll you can stop. I'd really like you to leave now. Robin and I can deal with whatever's bothering her.”

“I won't leave til she tells me to.”

Scott couldn't come up with a retort that didn't include punching me in the face, so he took a sip of wine instead. It seemed to calm him. He knew

Robin still loved me, despite his best efforts to come between us. I wondered if he knew about my ultimatum. I didn't think he did. As little about Scott that I knew, one thing I was positive of, he would have found a way to use that against me. I figured my wife was playing that decision close to her chest. If Scott did know, I'm sure he'd be doing more lobbying on his own behalf.

So we stood on either side of the table, staring at each other like a couple of elk bucks sizing up the competition for the doe's affection. I promised myself I wasn't going to antagonize Scott. Robin was going to have to make her own mind up about him and riling up her lover wasn't going to endear her to me.

The tension between us was finally broken when Robin came down the hall. She was radiant – did pregnancy really do that? Her hair was pulled back in a small ponytail. She was wearing a green Spirit Spa T-shirt and a pair of beige capri pants.

Her breasts caught my attention; I'm sure they had the same affect on Scott. My wife had no bra on; her pert nipples were clearly visible through the thin fabric of the shirt. Were they a little bit bigger? Certainly not this early. My expectations were playing havoc on my perception.

“Okay, lovers,” Robin said, trying to bring a bit of levity to the situation. “Come join me in the living room.” Scott followed and sat next to her on the couch. I poured her a glass of Pinot and pulled out a dining room chair to sit on. I handed Robin her drink. “Thanks,” she said and took a gulp, downing half the glass. I wanted to believe I knew what choice she was going to make by how much alcohol she was drinking, but I wasn't going to take anything for granted. I would never again take anything for granted. Ever.

“Okay, Robin. What's up? Your call sounded urgent. I'm here, Peter's here – god knows why. What's wrong?”

“I'm pregnant.” Leave it to Robin to be blunt with Scott, she sure wasn't with me.

To his credit, Scott didn't drop his glass, instead he took a drink. “You're pregnant.” A look of concern spread across his face – followed close with a big stupid grin. “Congratulations.” He leaned over to kiss Robin, she didn't turn to meet him, so his lips landed on her cheeks. He looked over at me with about half the enthusiasm. “Guess I should say grats to you, too.” He reached his hand out for a shake.

“It's not mine,” I said trying hard to remain calm.

Scott's eye's bulged. “But... but we used... condoms.” Then the realization dawned on his simple little mind. “Except for that one time.” Neither Robin nor I said anything. We wanted to let him work it out.

“I'm going to be a dad!” Scott jumped up and pulled my wife up with him. He gave her a big bear hug. She put in enough effort for a weak hug in return. Her lover didn't seem to notice. “Oh, God, Robin. You're going to be a great mom,” he said.

Robin stayed silent, so it was up to me to clue the idiot in. “You're assuming she plans to keep it.”

Scott looked at me like I was speaking Chinese. “Of course, she's keeping it.”

“Don't you think you should ask her?”

He turned to Robin and said, “You're keeping it. Right.” It was a statement, not a question. Robin didn't say anything, but I did notice a small tear trickle down her cheek. Scott noticed, too. “Why are you crying, Bunny? This is great news.”

God that nickname was grating.

“Don't you know why we don't have kids?” I finally said.

“No. Never thought it was my business. Until now, I guess.”

“Giving birth could kill Robin.”

Scott turned to my wife with a genuine look of concern on his face and asked, “Is this true?”

Robin silently nodded her head. I really wished she would speak up, instead of leaving it all to me. “I wouldn't lie about this.”

“Is it a hundred percent certain? Having a kid will kill you?”

“Close,” she said. Finally.

“What's close?” Scott asked. He grabbed Robin by the shoulders. Her eyes popped open. I moved to step between them, but Scott easily pushed me aside. He saw it coming.

“Scott. Peter. Behave, both of you.”

“How close,” Scott asked again, looking at my wife then at me.

“Eighty percent,” I said. “Which is eighty percent too much.” I knew that wasn't literally what I meant, but he got the message.

“There must be something. Medicine.”

“It's her high blood pressure, Scott. Meds would hurt the fetus.”

“But.” Scott let go of Robin, his face turned ashen. “I'm going to be...”

“No, Scott. You're not,” I said.

He scowled at me, his eye's burning. “I guess you want her to kill the kid.” Hatred dripped from his words.

“I don't want my wife to die. She's more important than any bundle of cells in her body.”

“It's a baby - not a bundle of cells.”

I didn't want to get into a political or philosophical debate at the moment. Our personal feelings on abortion didn't matter.

“Robin's life is the most important thing,” I said. “Above all else.”

“Yeah. Right,” Scott said. Both Robin and I looked at him in disbelief. “No, no. That came out wrong,” he said, realizing how he sounded. “I'm just saying Peter wants the abortion because it's not his kid.”

“Fuck you, Scott,” I wanted to punch him, but I didn't. My fist would never get near his face, and he'd kick my ass. Robin would get upset and it would do me no good at all. I took a deep breath and continued. “It's not my abortion or your abortion. It's up to Robin.”

“Yes, Robin,” Scott said. “I'm sorry. I'm being an ass. I'll do anything to help. We'll get the best doctors. You'll be taken good care of.”

“I'm not sure what to do, Scott.”

“Easy. Have the baby. We'll raise it together. You and me,” Scott looked over at me. “And I guess Peter, too.”

Now I was certain Robin hadn't told him about my ultimatum. He was still trying to talk her into going through with the pregnancy – even pulling me into his pitch. He talked about how we all would raise the kid – three loving parents. The child would have the best schools and never want for anything. He didn't touch on the fact the kid – if it was lucky enough to survive delivery – would most likely not have a mother; she'd die in childbirth.

I was still fuming about his accusation I wanted Robin to abort for my own selfish reasons. I knew that if the chance of Robin surviving the nine-month ordeal was better and she still wanted to have the child, I would have stepped aside and let her start a family with Scott. I would die a little inside, but I still wanted what was best for my wife, even if that meant she wasn't going to be my wife any longer.

Now, the thought of that, my wife having Scott's baby, ignited a burning feeling in the pit of my stomach and I have to admit I was madly

jealous that another man had impregnated Robin. The primal fury returned and was feeding on that emotion.

I looked at Scott, calmly trying to talk my wife into the extremely dangerous decision to have his baby. He was unaware of the green rage that was burning in me.

If I was fair and called him out to fight, he'd beat me for sure. He was bigger, stronger and probably faster, as well. Surprise would be my only route to victory. The chance came and I took it. I did what I promised myself I would not do. I attacked Scott.

If I had been watching from a distance, I'm sure I would have loved the look of shock on Scott's face as I rushed him. I launched myself over the coffee table that was between us and drove my shoulder into his chest. I knocked the wind out of him. I followed that with some mostly ineffectual punches to his stomach and head. Scott easily brushed them off, all the while trying to catch his breath.

Robin was screaming for us to stop as we wrestled on the ground. After the surprise wore off, Scott quickly gained the upper hand and landed a few sharp blows to my face before Robin pulled him off me.

"Peter," she said, "what the fuck! And Scott, you didn't need to punch him so hard."

I had the taste of iron in my mouth. I put my hand to my nose and saw stars. I pulled it away – blood covered my palm. Luckily the pain wasn't too bad and I'm sure Scott did pull his punches. I got up and excused myself to go use the bathroom to clean up.

I looked in the mirror. My lower face was scarlet. My left eye was a faint purple and starting to swell. This was just wonderful.

I stuffed some cotton in my nose, to stop the bleeding, and took a wash rag and ran it under some warm water.

As I was washing the blood off my face, a deep dread passed over me. I was sure I had screwed things up and I was going to lose my wife, forever. I threw up in the sink – mostly a thin pinkish liquid with a few small particles of breakfast. My throat burned from the acid. I cupped my hand and took a few sips from the faucet. The warm water didn't help much, but it was better than the taste of vomit.

Eventually, I calmed down and a kind of cool peace descended on me. I had accepted that it was out of my hands. It was up to Robin.

I wiped the blood and bile from my mouth. I then turned on the cold water and ran a clean cloth under it. I pressed the new cloth to my tender eye. I'd have to get ice for it. I figured I'd keep the physical reminders of today's events with me for at least a few days, maybe a week. Scott hadn't broken anything, so I was lucky there. The only scar would be on my pride, and that had been through the wringer so many times since April that one more mark wouldn't be noticeable.

When I rejoined my wife and Scott they were finishing up a heated, but low volume, argument. He looked over at me when I entered, his lip curled up in a sneer.

“Looks like I got you good,” he said.

“Scott!” Robin said with a force even I could feel.

“Looks can be deceiving,” I said.

“Serves him right for attacking me,” Scott wouldn't let up.

“You two are acting like kids. I don't need your immature antics right now. We have an adult situation, that needs adult thinking.”

“Sorry,” Scott said, as meekly as I've ever heard him say anything.

I snickered.

“Peter - you should have known better.”

I shut up.

“Yeah, Peter. Listen to your wife. Though she may not be for long.” I guess she finally told him.

“I want both of you out! Now.” There was no hesitation in her voice. “I don't want to be around either of you right now.”

I wish I could take back what I had done. Robin needed me right now. She need someone to lean on and I had acted like a fool and now she didn't want to have anything to do with me. I felt bad for myself, and bad for her. Now she'd have to deal with her decision on her own.

Scott was still trying to get Robin to forgive his inexcusable actions. I was resigned to my fate. I knew my wife and she wasn't going to have her mind changed by us. She would have to come to it herself, in her own time.

There was really only one question I needed an answer to – well two, if you counted her pregnancy. “Do you still want to be married?”

Sorrow, anger, guilt and fear played across her hazel eyes. “I don't know. There's too much going on in my head and you can't expect me to decide. If you do, you probably won't like the answer.”

Scott didn't say anything but I saw his mouth tremble into a small smile. He counted that as a win for him. I didn't. Even though I had planned to have an answer from Robin this weekend, once again, forces beyond my control had denied me. I wasn't going to push my wife at the moment. She needed to deal with other issues and I was going to let her. My own needs could wait. The fact I could find comfort in other arms didn't hurt, and I felt a little guilty thinking about it.

Robin herded both of us to the door and for his part Scott behaved. She gave him a hug and a peck on the cheek. There was no passion in the kiss, only a kindness and genuine warmth. I felt a little sorry for him, just a little though.

“What about the...” He didn't finish his thought. He reached out and touched Robin's belly.

“It's my decision. I'll take care of it.”

“Nothing I can say?” he asked.

“No,” was Robin's firm reply.

He kissed her again, this time on the lips and she kissed him back and I wanted to cry. I saw a tenderness that I hadn't seen before. I saw the love Robin felt for Scott and I cringed. A sour taste filled my mouth. I went to the kitchen to get a drink of water; Robin didn't stop me.

When I got back, Scott was gone.

Now it was my turn for a hug and a kiss.

“Take all the time you need,” I said as she laid her head lightly on my shoulder. It was really the least I could offer after the scene I had caused.

“Thanks.”

I turned to go, but she pulled me back and kissed me on the mouth. I know she could taste the bile on my breath but she kissed me anyway. I hugged her back and vowed to myself I would never let her go.

I broke that vow about thirty seconds later.

“You should see a doctor about that eye when you get back to Phoenix.”

“I'm a doctor.” I was joking, but Robin didn't laugh.

“I mean a real one.” I grimaced when she lightly touched my nose.

“I will,” I said. Her implying I wasn't a real doctor kinda sucked.

“And I'll be coming down to the city next weekend.”

I knew why. “Do you want me to go with you?” I asked hoping the answer would be yes.

It was.

Chapter 3

Peter

Robin picked me up at my office the following Friday at one o'clock. I had cleared my appointment calendar and told our receptionist I was starting my weekend early.

"You look much better," she said to me as I climbed into the passenger seat of her SUV.

"Thanks," I said. Luckily, Scott hadn't broken my nose. The only sign of our fight was a light blue tinge around my eye. I buckled up and Robin headed out to the woman's health clinic where she would be getting her abortion.

"What did your co-workers say when you showed up with that shiner?"

"Not much. Told them I hit my head on a cupboard door."

"They believe you?"

"Maybe."

"Hope they don't think you're a battered husband. What'd your doctor say?"

I didn't answer right away. I hadn't gone to the doctor. Instead, I took a couple leftover prescription pain killers."

"Peter?"

"I didn't go. I don't like doctor's offices." It was true. Nothing good happened in a doctor's office. At least not for me. "My nose wasn't broken so I figured there wasn't much call for a trip to the doctor. Saved the insurance company a few bucks."

"Sure they're grateful for that. They gonna split the savings with you?"

I knew I should have gone to see someone. I might have had a concussion or internal bleeding.

“You can be so silly sometimes, Peter.”

“You have lunch yet?” I asked.

“My appointment's in half an hour, we don't have time.

I found it uncomfortable talking about where we were going. I was accompanying my wife to her abortion appointment and her demeanor was more like she was getting a cavity filled.

My opinion has always been, the fewer abortions the better, but it was always a woman's choice. Having your body used as an incubator for nine months without consent was slavery, no matter what the ultra-religious thought. The bottom line for me was, a woman's body is her own, not her husband's, not her pastor's and not the state's.

“I'm glad you're with me Peter. You didn't have to come.” I appreciated that she didn't add how it wasn't my fault she was knocked up.

“You know there's nothing I wouldn't do for you.”

“Do I have to tell you that's a lie?”

“No.” It was a lie. I wouldn't let her live with Scott and stay married to me. “But anything else.”

“I know.” She put her right hand on my knee. “Thanks.”

“How'd your consultation go?” I was talking about the mandatory visit every woman seeking an abortion in Arizona had to go through.

“Pretty routine. I went to the Planned Parenthood clinic in Flagstaff on Monday. Confirmed I actually was pregnant. I had to have an ultrasound. That was a waste of time. And they set up my appointment here in Tempe since they don't do the surgical procedures there.”

“I wish you didn't have to go through all this.”

“My fault. I let my pussy do my thinking for me.”

I laughed. “You have no excuse. At least us guys can say our erections take blood from our brain.”

Robin punched my leg. “Do NOT mock the power of the pussy. She's impossible to ignore when she wants to be filled.”

Looking over at Robin and seeing her laugh in the face of such a tough decision reminded me why I loved her so much.

Nothing ever seemed to keep her down. I remembered when I first saw her, sitting in the exam room at my clinic with a dying Bassett hound in her lap. Her hands and clothes were covered in blood, but still, a strong confident attitude that her pet would survive shone through. I think her confidence was infectious, because when I first looked at the dog I thought for sure we'd have to put him down. But the more I talked to this vibrant young woman, the more sure I became that I could save it. And I did.

Six Years Prior

Peter had just finished Beasley's checkup. Physically, the dog was fine. The stitches had been removed weeks ago and there was no scarring. He had no infections and no permanent affects to his motor skills.

Robin, the dog's owner, reported Beasley had returned to his friendly, affectionate self and had even enjoyed a frolic in the park, near where the pick-up had hit him. It was a near perfect recovery after a rainy night hit-and-run, thanks mainly to Peter's deft hands and some excellent medication.

The down side to this swift healing – no more excuses to see the lovely Robin.

For the past three months, Peter had looked forward to every visit from Beasley and his brown-haired owner. He loved looking into her deep hazel eyes when explaining how well her dog's health was improving. And no matter how hard he tried to remain professional, he couldn't help but be

distracted when she wore a scoop-neck or V-cut top, something she was prone to do as her dog got better and the need for the vet visits diminished.

“Miss Weston,” Peter said to Robin, “there's nothing else for me to do. Little Beasley's in perfect health.”

Robin extended her hand and said, “thanks.” Peter took her hand and shook it.

“You're welcome,” he said and continued to move his arm up and down until that became too tiring and he just held it. Robin's hand felt warm and soft and he could sense a whiff of the lavender hand lotion she used.

Is this really it? he asked himself. *Is this the last time I'd get to see her?* Peter became lost, swirling in all the possible futures of life with and without this beautiful, intelligent woman in them.

“Doctor Wilkenson?” Robin said.

“Call me Peter.” That was a stupid thing to say.

“Peter, can I have my hand back?” But not a stupid as holding on so long after they'd stopped shaking hands.

“Sorry. I just,” Peter was stammering. “I just. Got distracted.”

“No problem at all,” Robin said. She paused for a second before adding, “can I have my hand back now?”

“Yeah. Yeah,” he said and released her grip. “Sorry, I'm usually not like this. I'd say it's because I'm new here, but that's not entirely true.”

Robin blushed a bit, but didn't ask him to explain why. For that, he was disappointed. Peter would have loved to tell her how much he looked forward to her visits and maybe ask her out for a cup of coffee. Or dinner. Or anything, really. He just wanted the opportunity to get to know her better.

Peter didn't lack for things to say. He just didn't have the courage to say them. He needed coaxing. He needed Robin to make the first move –

to let him know she was interested, but she didn't seem to be doing that.

So instead, he apologized and completed entering Beasley's vitals into his computer terminal. While he was doing that he advised Robin to schedule a regular six-month checkup. He told this to all his patient's owners but only about ten percent ever did. He mostly only got to see animals that were sick or needed fixing.

When he was done, Peter scratched playfully behind Beasley's floppy brown ears for a bit before shaking Robin's hand again.

“Guess this is goodbye, then,” he said. This time he was quick to release her hand.

“I really want to thank you again, Doctor Hender – Peter – for saving Beasley's life. I don't know what I'd do without him.

“It's nothing anyone else here wouldn't have done.” That was true, but it was always nice to hear he was appreciated.

“I'm glad it was you,” Robin said.

Peter didn't know what to say to that. If he had a smidgen more confidence he might have said something like, “I'm glad it was me as well.” And then ask her out on a date. But he didn't do that.

“Call us, if anything else comes up,” is what he said instead, and escorted Robin and Beasley to the reception area where they paid for the little dog's last visit. Peter waved as they walked out the door, and a little void opened up in his heart, one he thought he'd never fill.

Peter was mentally kicking himself in the ass for being such a wimp. He figured he didn't deserve a woman like Robin if he couldn't even get up the nerve to talk to her.

He was in the exam room, shutting down the terminal and sterilizing the exam table when he spotted a little yellow umbrella folded up and leaning against the wall in the corner.

It had been drizzling earlier in the day as it often did in the spring, but the rain quickly stopped and dried up and was soon forgotten, just like the umbrella. Peter didn't have to think too hard about whose it was. He knew it belonged to Robin.

His heart started pounding. He now had an excuse to call her. He'd get her number from her file and ring her up. He'd tell her she left her umbrella at the clinic and that he'd hold it for her to pick up. He thrilled at the chance to see her again, even if only for a quick exchange.

His heart sank a bit when he saw it was a cheap little thing – five dollars at Target; she might tell him to keep it. A cloud of pessimism drifted over the tiny patch of sunlight that umbrella represented. Peter could feel her drifting further away. It was going to be Jaime all over again.

Jamie was his lab partner for a year in Veterinary school. She dropped lots of hints he never picked up. The last week of class she told him she had started dating a guy who played basketball at the gym she frequented.

As the last mote of light threatened to go out, Peter made a bold decision; it was bold for him. He would call Miss Weston and tell her he had her umbrella. If she told him to keep it that meant she really wasn't interested in him. But if she said she'd come and get it, that would mean she left it on purpose hoping he'd call her.

It was a stupid proposition, but that was the kickstart Peter needed. He called her that evening as he was getting ready to leave. He was overjoyed when she said she'd love to get her umbrella back. His heart skipped a beat and he almost hung up the phone.

After he calmed down, Peter asked if she'd like to meet him at a nearby coffee shop. She said yes without hesitating.

It wasn't really a date, but it was better than her meeting him at his office. So much better.

They sat in a Starbucks and chatted. They drank coffee and shared a danish and chatted some more. They talked into the evening until the staff kicked them out at closing time.

Robin and Peter moved their conversation to a nearby bar where they had a drink – two gin and sodas – and talked some more. They could have gone until last-call, but Peter did have to go to work in the morning. So he settled the bill; they split the tab since it wasn't a real date.

Peter walked Robin to her car and wondered if he should kiss her. If he had, they might have ended up going back to her place – or his – and making love. He didn't.

“I had a wonderful time tonight,” he said as they reached her Dodge Neon.

“You're a very interesting man, Peter Wilkenson. When you actually open up.”

Peter stared at her silently. No one had ever called him that before. While he didn't have the nerve to lean in for a kiss, he was able to say, “will I be able to see you again?” It was a weak invite, but it did put a smile on Robin's face.

“Maybe,” she said.

It was good enough of Peter. “Good night, Robin.”

Robin didn't say anything. She didn't start the car and she didn't drive away. Did she expect him to say something else? Peter wasn't sure. Should he try to kiss her? That might ruin everything.

She looked up at him through the open window of her car. Peter didn't know what to say, dealing with women had always been a weak area for him. He was much better with animals. So he watched her smile turn into a silly grin until she eventually started laughing.

“You really don't know what I'm waiting for do you?”

Peter thought for a moment then said, “a kiss?”

Robin kept laughing, not in a mocking way, but kindly. “Peter, you're a great guy, but I think it's too early for a kiss.”

“Of course it is,” Peter said not believing that at all.

Robin shook her head and started the car. “But I'll tell you what. Maybe I'll kiss you on our first date.”

“You want to see me again?”

Robin rolled her eyes. “Yeah, silly. I want to see you again. You still haven't given me back my umbrella.”

Robin laughed again and Peter couldn't help but join her. He had been so shocked when she agreed to meet him he's forgotten the whole pretense of the call; the umbrella was back in the office.

“Call me,” she shouted back at him as she drove off into the cool Phoenix night.

The clinic waiting room looked exactly like any other. There were uncomfortable fabric chairs lining the walls. A TV was tuned to some generic channel that ran lots of medical clips on a loop, and in the corner there was a plastic child-sized playhouse with plenty of toys, none being used at the moment. The purpose of all this detritus was to create a welcoming atmosphere; I wasn't feeling it.

Right or wrong, I, as a man, was kind of an intruder. I felt that way despite the fact the clinic did offer services for men; a couple posters on the wall told me this. I couldn't stop fidgeting under the judgmental eye of some unseen watcher.

I suffered my paranoia in silence. This visit wasn't about me, not in any sense. It was about Robin. A receptionist behind a glass partition handed her a clipboard of forms when we arrived. My wife filled them out with a cheap pen attached to a weak chain, like banks use.

She was quickly escorted past a set of double doors into the bowels of the clinic, where the procedure would be done. I was asked to wait out in the lobby, so I did.

I sat and read a few of the magazines scattered on the low end tables. Most were women's health related but a few were geared toward masculine tastes: a Sports Illustrated from three months past and a Car and Driver. I perused an article about the Diamondbacks written back before the All-Star break, when they appeared to be making a run for the pennant. Unfortunately they petered out shortly after this issue hit the newsstands and were now firmly ensconced in the basement of their division.

When I'd finished the article, I sat and stared at the posters of happy faced people encouraging me to ask my doctor if I had any of the listed symptoms of one aberrant condition or another. Veritex B was just not for me, I decided, despite what the smiling blond man sitting on a boat in the middle of a lake said.

Robin re-emerged from the double doors. I glanced at my phone; she had only been gone an hour. Her hair was a little tussled and she wore a little white wrist band on her left arm, Other than that, you would never have been able to tell she had just had a medical procedure. Unless you knew her and looked her in the eyes and saw the blank void behind her pupils.

I don't think she regretted the abortion. She wouldn't have gone through with it if she didn't want to end the pregnancy. I think she regretted having to make that choice in the first place. Or maybe she regretted not

having the willpower to make Scott go out and get more condoms instead of fucking her bareback. She may have been mad at Scott for not keeping up on how many fucking condoms were in the box. I was sure she was mad at me about something, most likely the ultimatum.

Whatever the case, she had the abortion, it was over, and the future lay ahead – her future, my future, Scott's future, our future.

I gave her a hug as she came out. I was trying to absorb any of the bad feelings into myself. She hugged me back and whispered into my ear, “I'm really glad you came.”

“I'm here for you.”

I drove home. We stopped at a CVS on the way back to our house – it was still our house – to pick up some ibuprofen and pads.

Robin would stay with me overnight and drive back to Sedona the next morning.

We shared a bottle of wine that night, sitting out on the patio.

“You want to relax in the hot tub?” I asked. I wasn't interested in starting anything sexual; I wanted to comfort her.

“Doctor says I shouldn't submerge my lady parts in water for at least 24 hours, so let's skip that.”

Instead we sat silently and watched the stars.

I didn't really want to bring up our marital situation, but I felt I had to.

“You given any thought to us?” I asked, trying to keep my voice calm and civil.

Robin rolled her eyes. “I figured you'd bring that up.”

“Sorry. We don't have to talk about it if you'd rather not.”

“No, No. Let's get it over with.”

I felt relieved and apprehensive, not knowing what was going to come out of my wife's mouth. I waited with my own mouth shut. I said my piece

already, many times. Robin knew how I felt. She knew what I wanted. We'd have to see if we shared the same feelings and desires.

Robin took a sip of wine. She set her glass down and leaned forward in her chair. "I've thought a lot about this, Peter. More than I've let you know. You're important to me. You're my husband and I love you."

I felt my heart pounding in my ears. She was saying good things, but I feared she was just lifting my spirits in preparation for the verdict. I wasn't looking forward to the fall.

"But." She paused. She knew I didn't like that word. "But with Scott." Her eyes shifted off into the night. I imagined she was trying to find the right words. To say what; I couldn't know.

"Scott's complicated. I have feelings for him, deep feelings. I won't deny them."

I felt a storm brewing in my stomach. I fought the urge to scream.

Robin continued. "They're different then the feelings I have for you. And I need to work them out."

"But, Robin."

"Don't talk, Peter. I need to say this."

I shut up and tried to listen. I tried not to put words into her mouth, tried not to formulate my response. I needed to hear what she said before I leapt off the deep end. I knew all this, but it was hard.

"I can't make a decision right now, Peter. Please, understand that. But I am going to make some changes. I need to be alone for a little while. No Scott."

That was nice to hear.

"But no you, either."

My chest caved in, like I'd been hit by a fastball.

“I need to concentrate on my life and my work. The spa is set to open in a couple months and there are still so many things to do. I haven't even hired any staff yet.”

“So what are you going to do?” I finally got up the strength to interrupt. “Leave us both?”

“Kinda.”

That didn't sound good.

“I'm cutting you both out of my life for now, as much as I can. I still need to deal with Scott as my boss, but it will only be on a professional level.”

“So you're not going to see me or talk to me? I don't see how that's fucking fair.”

“Peter, I'll still talk to you. We can call each other, if we need to, but we should keep it to a minimum. At least until the spa opens.”

“You're going to live in his house, work with him personally and keep me at arm's length.” I had to stop talking. I was starting to shake and I had to settle down before I could continue. Robin started to say something, but I interrupted. “Guess that means you've made up your mind. I'll call the lawyer on Monday.”

Robin's eyes opened wide, “No, please don't.” Her panic was audible. “I'm moving back to my apartment. I'm not going to live in his house. I'm not going to sleep with him.”

“I won't be around, so I guess I'll have to trust you.” I was lashing out. I wasn't proud, but that's how I felt.

“Peter,” Robin said. Her voice was stern, a look of sadness crept over her face. “If you don't trust me, then yes, call a lawyer. But I wish you would. Trust me.”

I took a breath and decided I did trust her. I had to trust her or I had lost, everything. And so, once again I put off my ultimatum. I felt like a doormat, being stepped on and ignored, but on the bright side she still said she loved me and I couldn't think of any reason she would pretend that. Not since she had Scott to fall back on.

Scott, the handsome, Italian business owner who could offer her the world.

I had love and a partnership to give. Was that enough? I still didn't know and wasn't going to find out anytime soon.

Robin slept in our bed. I decided it would be too painful to sleep next to her, yet so far away. So I took the couch.

In the morning, she drove me to my office to pick up my car, then she headed back up to Sedona.

I needed a diversion, something to focus on other than my dissolving marriage. Robin may have said she wasn't sleeping with Scott, or anyone else, but I didn't make any promise. I thought about calling Kelly Cho, my Korean sex therapist. (She was really a veterinarian, like me, but she did wonders for my own sexual confidence.) She helped me get over the pain of Robin's cheating and guided me into the wonderful world of open marriages. I came to accept the idea of both Robin and I exploring new sexual experiences. I wanted to do it together, as a couple. My wife had done the unforgivable; she had fallen in love.

Unfortunately, Kelly was over a thousand miles away in Seattle. So, instead, I decided to explore the next best option. I went to see my red-head bartender.

Chapter 4

Robin

It's Monday, ten days have past since her trip down to Phoenix. That side trip is the furthest thing from her mind. She's back at her Camp Verde apartment, trying to get some work done away from the chaos of the construction going on at the spa.

She's talking on the phone to a woman whose past five years of life are summarized on a piece of paper she stares at.

“So, Marylyn, you've been working at the Long Beach Gym for three years now, how's that going?”

She listens as the young woman on the other end of the phone responds. She tells her what it's like to work as a full-time employee of one of Scott's other fitness clubs. Robin wonders if Scott fucked Marylyn? Oddly, that thought doesn't stir any jealousy at all. It's not that she doesn't still long for Scott, she does. It's that she's learned to see the world through Peter's eyes. She sees sex as a natural urge, one that can be fed and indulged and not allowed to rule her life. Now if Scott ever said he loved Marylyn – the thought alone is enough to tempt Robin to hang up the phone and move on to the next resumé. Imaging this woman's lips wrapped around Scott's erection arouses her; she shifts in her seat and tugs at her panties. When her mind wonders further and she hears her lover whisper those three special words into the woman's ear, her heart implodes and she's filled with a void of longing and despair.

Robin tries hard to push all thoughts of Scott and Peter out of her mind. She looks again at Marylyn's CV. Robin's boss, not Scott, no, her boss, mentioned Marylyn as a good candidate for managing the Long Beach

location, but the current muscle-head who runs it refuses to retire and he's too good to fire.

Robin likes what she's hearing. The woman sounds perky and experienced and knows the business. These are all traits her future boss – being Robin – lacks. After about an hour – with her phone battery in the red – Robin makes her offer.

Marylyn tells her she needs time to think about it, time to talk to her boyfriend. She tries hard not to laugh. Of course the boyfriend is going to say no. He's probably enjoying a life on the beach, surfing and laying out; maybe he has a part-time job, maybe not. He definitely won't want his meal ticket running off to the mountains of northern Arizona. She hopes Marylyn will be smart and take the job. She gives the young woman two days to decide and says goodbye.

And with that, the Sedona Spirit Rejuvenation Spa and Fitness Center has its first employee. Robin is so proud. She wishes Peter were here to share it with her.

Peter

It took a few weeks, but I was finally able to schedule a date with my favorite bartender. Angie wore a tight black dress with a high neckline in front and plunged down her back. It was cut short, barely covering her ass, which she was shaking like a polaroid picture, her curves so inviting, covered with a thin layer of fabric. What little part of her body the dress did leave to the imagination was presented in such a way as to cover all faults and shortcomings.

Wearing that little black dress, Angie was a goddess, perfect in every way and a muse, filling men's (and some women's) minds with deliciously

nasty ideas.

Currently, my attention was held fixed by her bouncing breasts. They were two buoys riding storm tossed waves moving to the steady beats some DJ I'd never heard of, was laying down; there weren't any DJ's I'd heard of if you don't count Derek Jeter.

We were dancing at a ritzy club in Scottsdale. I was the oldest person there, besides one of the bartenders; he might have been in his forties. I felt awkward and out of place but Angie did her best to make me feel included. We drank and we danced. I moved as best I could. Angie's body was liquid heat, gyrating in ways that no human body should be able to. She threw her hands around my neck, grinding her hips against my cock. It was a public dry hump – but no one was watching. At least I didn't think anyone was. I found out I was wrong a little later.

“I'm getting too old for this,” I said. I had to shout into Angie's ear to be heard over the music.

“You're not too bad,” she said. I smiled at her attempts to humor me. It felt good to know she didn't want my feelings hurt. “Let's get you some water, old man. I can't have you passing out on me. I have plans for you.”

My cock had started settling down after the dry hump on the dance floor, now it sprang back to life. She was talking about sex, I hoped she was talking about sex, and I was hungry for her. It had been two months since I'd had sex of any kind. I hadn't even masturbated since our fuck in the back office of the bar.

We got a couple bottles of water – paid four bucks a piece for them – and sat at one of the few empty tables.

“You having fun?” Angie asked. It was obvious she was.

I nodded my head, but not for the reason my date thought. I really didn't like to dance. I wasn't any good at it. Luckily, Angie made up for my

lack of skill. What I was enjoying was spending time with her, and thinking about fucking her later that night.

“Wanna get out of here?” I said.

Now it was my date's turn to nod her head. I hoped it was because she, too, was looking forward to getting to the sex.

“Let me go use the rest room first.”

I went to the washroom and pissed out two beers and a gin and tonic. I was washing my hands and looking into the mirror when it hit me, how much older I was than Angie. I was nearing puberty when she was born. That thought deflated my erection in a hurry. I should be with someone my age, or at least closer to my age; Robin was only five years younger than I was.

I figured I should just enjoy the ride. Angie and I weren't serious, we were having fun. I liked her, I didn't love her.

When I came back out of the restroom, I spotted Angie at our table, and she wasn't alone. Two young guys, probably her age, were chatting her up.

I immediately got jealous and moved quickly toward them. I was concerned that they were bothering her, but I'd be lying if I said I didn't want to hit them for flirting with my girl. Me and my silly lizard brain.

As I got close I noted Angie didn't seem to be in any distress, and, in fact, seemed to be enjoying their attention. I stood off a ways and tried to listen in on the conversation. It wasn't easy, luckily the DJ was taking a break and the pre-recorded music wasn't as loud as the live stuff.

“Saw you dancing with the old man,” one of the guy's said. He was a little shorter than me, about as tall as Angie. He had short blond hair and wore a black shirt, opened halfway down his chest, and black denim jeans. “He your dad?”

Angie noticed me and smiled. “No.”

The other guy, dark haired and wearing a loud Hawaiian print shirt chimed in, “Then what are you doing here with him. A hot chick like you. What's up with that?”

“He's my friend,” the red-head said. Hawaiian print guy puffed himself a bit, like he thought he had a shot at her. “And we're going to go home and screw. Here he is now.”

Angie got up and sauntered over to me. She put her arm around my waist, I put mine over her shoulder.

“See yah later, boys,” I said, with a little bit too much cockiness. Not my proudest moment, but I loved having Angie brush those two clowns off and head home with me.

As we headed toward the parking lot I wondered again about how I felt about those guys. I really shouldn't have been jealous. Angie wasn't my girlfriend, she was my fuck buddy and I shouldn't have been so attached to her that I would see green when other guys approached her. But at the same time, she may not be with me tomorrow, but she was tonight and that did give me some claim to her affections, at least for the evening.

The early October air hit us like a blast from a walk-in freezer when we opened the exit door and walked out into the parking lot. It was really only in the low 60's, but the difference from the furnace that was the dance club, with all it's hot lights and hotter bodies generating heat, made it feel much chillier outside.

I thought about how, since Vegas, I'd developed a taste for watching my women fuck. It was an odd fetish, and one that was on the edge of reason. I enjoyed seeing a woman's face overcome with ecstasy. Up close was nice, but getting to see it from a distance, and not take part in the actual act, was intoxicating. It was also addictive and could lead to unwanted side effects – like love and other bullshit. I had never mentioned to Angie any desire to

see her – to watch her – fuck other guys. I didn't know how she'd feel about that, so I kept it to myself. She knew I was married and that this was a temporary fling, that was good enough for me. Why ruin something so rare, an actual no-strings-attached physical relationship.

“I'm still surprised you haven't found a new boyfriend,” What the hell was I doing, trying to kill the unicorn?

“Who says I haven't?” I really liked how casual the joke rolled off her tongue. I also had to be careful, because if I wasn't, I might follow the missteps my wife made.

“I know you're not talking about me. I'm taken.” It was a joke, but was I really taken? Robin could easily call me up any moment and tell me it was over between us. *Keep the joke going, Peter*, I thought to myself. “And I doubt there are many men, like me, who appreciate their girls stepping out on them.”

“You're so old-fashioned. Any man who wants to spend time with me has to put up with my peccadillos.”

“Angie,” I said, pulling her into a hug. “You are so worth it.”

“Peter, you are so getting a good fucking tonight.”

We got in my car and headed back to her place. When we arrived she opened a bottle of wine, a white Zinfandel; for a bartender she had horrid tastes in vino.

We toasted. “To a fun evening,” I said.

Angie looked at me and raised her eyebrow. “You have no idea,” she said. A shiver ran up my spine. Angie took a sip of wine, I took a gulp.

“Slow down, you gotta be able to get it up.”

“I'm not that old,” I said. The age jokes really needed to stop. I set my drink down and pulled Angie in for a kiss. She returned the kiss. I worked my tongue between her lips; she tasted of sweet wine. I ran my hands down

her back and cupped her ass. She moaned into my mouth as I squeezed and eased my fingertips between her cheeks. I was pulling her body hard against mine when she pulled away.

“Stop, Peter.”

I did. “Is something wrong?”

“No, everything's perfect. I just need to establish two things tonight.”

I was confused, so I just listened.

“After our last,” Angie paused. “encounter, I thought I needed to up my game, push the boundaries. Don't look at me like that.”

“Like what?” I guess I had been making a face.

“Like you don't know what I'm talking about.”

“I'll admit I did treat you kinda, rough. Sorry bout that.”

“Yeah, you did, but don't you dare apologize. I didn't do anything I didn't want to. It's kinda hot to let someone else take control every now and then.”

I nodded my head.

“I'm glad you agree,” Angie said, her mouth lit into a wicked grin, “because tonight, it's my turn.”

All of a sudden, I was hard and I was scared. I had no idea what was in store for me, but I was weirdly looking forward to finding out.

“Like I was saying,” my red-headed lover said, “we need to get two things established.”

“Shoot.”

“First. We need a safe word.”

Fuck, I thought. This was going to get serious. “Okay,” I said, drawing out the word while wondering where this was heading.

“And, you do as I say. You give me absolute control.”

“Yeah.” I was shaking my head vigorously.

“Absolute. Control.”

The way she said the phrase, emphasizing each word, made my cock pulse. I was already hard and I was surprised I didn't cum in my pants.

“Unless I say the safe word, right?”

“Oh, yeah. If you say the safe word, we're done for the night. I'll stop and that's it.”

“But, can't we, uh, do something else.”

Angie smiled and shook her head. “Peter, Peter, Peter. I owe you for our last fuck. You used me. I won't say I didn't enjoy it, but you did use me. Now it's my turn.”

“But you said you enjoyed it.”

“I did. And I think you'll enjoy what I have planned, but it's all or nothing. You say the safe word and it's over. We're done for the evening and you can go home and jerk yourself off.”

I thought about what she said, but there was never a doubt that I would agree to it. “Okay, what's the safe word?” I asked.

Angie smiled. A lock of her hair fell across her face obscuring one eye. I felt a tremor roll through my body. I knew I would do what ever this beautiful woman said. I was hers to control. “How about, Robin.”

I thought it was rather rude to pick my wife's name for our safe word, but it's not like I was going to shout it out accidentally in the throes of passion, so I guess it would do.

Angie lead me through her small apartment – past the southwest themed art work and down the short narrow hall to her bedroom. It was a little cleaner this time, like she was expecting me. The bed was made, no

clothes tossed on the floor and there was a fresh fluffy brown towel spread out on the side of the bed.

“First,” she said, “we take a shower.”

We quickly undressed each other and got into the tub that doubled as a shower. There wasn't a lot of room behind the curtain that kept water from spraying onto the tile floor, but that made it much more intimate. Angie had a couple colorful scrunchies she lathered up and used to clean our bodies. She paid special attention to my cock, balls, and ass. We rinsed and dried ourselves off.

When we were nice and clean and dry, Angie grabbed my hand and dragged me back to the bedroom. She backed me up to the bed, my thighs touching the mattress. My ginger lover was no more than an inch away from me.

“You ready for me to rock your world?” My dick was at attention, so I took the question as rhetorical.

I answered it anyway. “Yeah.”

Angie began running her hands over my bare chest and abdomen. No one would ever describe my body as 'sculpted' but I kept my weight down and Robin never complained. Neither did Angie or Kelly for that matter. If I could attract those types of women with a healthy diet and light exercise, no telling who I might be able to attract if I actually worked out.

I was really enjoying the attention my voluptuous friend was paying to my body, especially when she started massaging my cock.

“That feel good?” she asked.

I closed my eyes and moaned my approval.

“Good. Hold that thought.”

She stopped stroking and I opened my eyes to see she had moved to the far side of her bed and was rummaging through a small suitcase. She threw

me a black blindfold – like you'd use when trying to sleep on a plane.

“Put it on,” she said.

“Really?”

“Do you trust me, Peter?”

Angie was using my words against me. I knew if I didn't do what she said our little fun time would be over. So far, everything was fine. My cock was hard and I was game for anything. I decided to put it on, but I didn't act fast enough.

“You trying to remember the safe word, Peter? Already?”

“I know what it is. It's Rob-”

“No!” Angie abruptly cut me off. “Don't say it unless you mean it.”

“I won't.”

Angie was taking our little domination game seriously. Although I couldn't blame her, after what I did to her at the bar. And I didn't even offer her a verbal escape hatch.

“Put the blindfold on, Peter. I won't ask again.”

I pulled the black mask over my head.

“How many fingers am I hold up?”

I could have lied, but I didn't have to. I could see nothing but blackness. “I don't know,” I said.

“Good. Now listen up. I don't want you to say anything else tonight until I tell you to take off the blindfold. The only exception is your safe word, or an answer to a direct question.”

She stopped talking and I had a hundred questions for her, but I knew better than to ask them. I heard her digging around inside the case and then her footsteps moving toward me.

“You understand what I'm asking?”

I didn't have a clue. “Kinda.”

“Do as I say and I promise you'll experience sensations you've only dreamed of.”

I didn't doubt that. My sex life up until recently had been vanilla. It was rainbow sherbert now. And I was loving it.

“Turn around and face the bed.” Angie's voice was coming from right in front of me. I did as instructed and she gave me a sharp slap on the ass. I wanted to yelp, but I didn't know if that was allowed. I was surprised at how easily I'd fallen into the submissive role with Angie. I must have been primed by Kelly.

“You can vocalize your pain if you need to,” Angie said.

Her words were followed by another smack, giving me a chance to say, “Ouch!”

“There you go.”

I was facing the bed, my arms at my side, my cock sticking straight out and bumping into the mattress. I heard a squishy sound and felt a chill as Angie reached around and started stroking my erection. Her hand was cold and slick. I could only assume she had applied a dollop of lube.

“You like that?”

It felt good. I said, “Yes.”

“Bend over.”

I complied and she stopped her hand-job. I moaned my displeasure.

“Don't you go whining.” I felt another slap on my ass. This time Angie rubbed her lubed up hand across my back side and between my cheeks. My cock spasmed as she began circling her finger around my ass. The nerves fired in rapid succession sending pulses of pleasure to my brain.

I had experienced several new sensations over the past few months and I've mentioned how my cock had obtained new levels of hardness that I wasn't aware I could achieve. Nothing before could compare to now. The

erection I had as Angie massaged my rosebud was diamond hard. And I swear, I didn't move an inch, but I could feel my penis press into the mattress in front of me, like it grew an extra inch. Whatever she was doing to me, I didn't want her to ever stop.

Then she pushed her well-lubed finger into my ass and stars exploded before my eyes.

“Oh, God,” I said.

Angie didn't stop. She continued working her finger deeper. “You like that?” she asked.

“Oh, God,” was all I could say. It was painful, in a way I never knew pain could be, but also a pleasure I didn't want to stop.

“That's not an answer,” Angie said as she started thrusting in and out. She was fucking my ass with her finger.

“Yes,” I said, panting. “And, no.”

“You want me to stop?” As she asked I could feel her add another finger and I couldn't believe how painful it became but I also felt my erection pulse without a climax.

“Answer me!” Angie thrust her two fingers into my anus and a million impulses raced through my brain and I couldn't speak. I thought I wanted to say my safe word, but I couldn't remember it and half my brain, the part ruled by my penis, didn't want me to say it, so maybe that's why I couldn't remember.

“Your cock says you like this, Petey. Is it lying?”

Bitch was using the nickname. “No!” I screamed. “God!”

“No you don't like it or no your cock isn't lying?”

Angie seemed to be loving this game. I was out of my mind with passion and lust. My erection needed attention, but my hands were spread out on the bed and I didn't dare move them.

Angie removed her fingers and I screamed again. It felt so wonderful yet, “No!” Exhaustion overtook me and I slumped down on the bed. I could feel a wet spot on the towel I was laying on. I might have come and not even realized it.

“Don't worry, dear. We're not done yet.”

I lay there for a moment, my eyes closed behind the black mask.

“I really wanted to give you an experience like you gave me.” From the sound of her voice I could tell Angie had moved back to her suitcase. “Something that you'd enjoy, in a way, but something you'd never ask for. Turn around and sit on the bed.”

I did as I was told. My ass felt a little sore, but not too bad.

“Now, lay back.” Angie was near me again. I could smell her sweat. I could smell her arousal. Angie was getting off dominating me. “Pull your legs up. Good.” She pushed the backs of my thighs up and away from each other. My cock was sticking straight up and I could feel a slight breeze against my exposed anus.

“Now, hold your legs like that. Don't let them drop, and most important, relax. The less you fight it, the better it'll feel.”

As she said this, Angie gave my cock a couple of good long strokes. I wondered what else she was going to do. I prayed to all the gods I could think of, that she wasn't taking any pictures. It didn't take too long for me to find out what she had planned.

I felt her fingers again rimming my anus. I relaxed and she slipped one in. I felt a chill as she directly applied a generous amount of lube and then it felt like a baseball bat was shoved against my butt and Angie applied pressure.

“Relax,” she said, her voice calm and soothing.

I tried, oh did I try. Slowly but surely that bat went past my ring and into my body and it had nothing to do with how relaxed I was. I was filled with a sense of completeness. My cock was hard, my balls tight and my ass stuffed. It was painful in the best way possible.

And then Angie started pulling out whatever she had stuck up my ass and I gave a sigh of relief and regret, but then she pushed it back in and I cried out, “Oh, God. Don't.”

But she did. Again. She pulled out and pushed in; Angie was fucking me with what felt like a baseball bat. I wanted her to stop but I didn't want her to stop. I was crazy with the pleasure and the pain. My judgement was clouded and, god, did I want to come.

“Wow,” Angie said. “I've never seen a dick so – rigid. It's so red and hard. I'd love to suck it.”

My cock throbbed again, in anticipation of her mouth approaching.

“But, I won't.”

“Oh, God, Angie. Please.”

“I told you not to talk.”

I didn't answer, I just groaned under the constant push and pull of the object in my ass.

“I'll tell you what. I told you this would be an experience you'd never forget.”

I don't think she used those words, but I didn't argue.

“Don't worry, dear, I'm gonna let you cum. But, like I had to do. You're going to have to bring yourself to completion.”

I knew that night at the Oasis was going to come back to bite me on the ass. I didn't know it would fuck me there, too.

I felt a cool liquid drop onto the tip of my dick and flow down my shaft.

“All lubed up, Peter,” Angie said. “If you can keep your legs up with only one hand you're free to jack off with the other.”

Somehow, I did it. I wasn't proud and it wasn't easy. It could not have looked sexy, but I did it.

With my right hand, I gripped my shaft and tugged up and down. I appreciated the silky smooth lube, but I would have masturbated with just my sweat and pre-cum. My cock and balls were on fire and I needed release.

It didn't take long, about a dozen strokes and I launched several jets of semen into the air. I couldn't see them but I could feel them land on my chest.

After I was spent and my cock started to deflate, Angie pulled the club out of my ass. I was relieved and a little disappointed.

“You can take off the blindfold.”

I did, and with that I was able to talk freely again.

“I can't believe you stuck a bat up my ass.”

Angie laughed and showed me the butt plug she used. It was larger than her finger but bout half the size of my dick.

“How the hell do people - do people...” I couldn't complete my question.

“You'd be amazed at what the human body is capable of.”

“You've had that up your ass, too?”

“Oh, no, Peter. I bought that one for you. You can take it home and play anytime you want, now.”

After we cleaned up the bedroom we took another shower. Angie offered to blow me for letting her have her way with my ass. I told her I was quite sated. Instead I offered to eat her out. She eagerly accepted.

Her pussy was extremely wet. Having me folded in half, at her mercy, really aroused the woman. She tasted especially tangy. She came two times. The first was quick and loud, the second, deep and long.

There is nothing on earth more beautiful than a woman's face when she comes. And to view her from between her heaving breasts, while you're lapping at her clitoris, is to catch a glimpse of heaven.

“Thanks for an extremely – interesting – evening,” I said as Angie walked me out to my car.

“We still good?” she asked. I think she was worried I'd be pissed.

“Yes. We're good. I didn't bring up my wife's name did I?”

“Guess not.” The red-head reached up and kissed me on the cheek.

“We gonna do this again?”

I laughed and held up the bag with my personal butt plug and bottle of K-Y jelly. “Never know,” I said.

We exchanged goodbyes and I drove home, my ass, a little bit sore, but I was so glad I trusted Angie like she trusted me.

Chapter 5

Robin

The flow of people marks time for her, construction workers construct, delivery drivers deliver, inspectors inspect and all the while she and her staff try to stay out of the way. She thinks of Scott rarely, just when he calls to check on her progress. She's polite and concise. Everything's fine she tells him. They'll be ready for a soft open in two weeks.

When he asks how she's doing, personally, she's guarded with her response. She wants to tell him how she feels. She wants him to know how she longs for him, longs to be taken in his arms and ravished. She gets wet near the end of these phone calls and often locks the doors and furiously masturbates in her office after she's hung up.

Robin wishes so hard she could keep both men in her life. It's a selfish thought, she feels, but an honest one. Love, for her, is not easily contained. She deeply loves both men; Peter for his soft kindness and giving nature, his humble good looks and his winning smile, Scott for his rugged handsome features, his brutal steadfast courage and the way he takes what he wants. Two, totally different men, each has taken her heart in his own way. Scott brazenly stole her affections. Peter won them over. Was one man better than the other? Robin thought not.

Later, at night, she'll lie awake in bed and long to snuggle up in Peter's warm embrace. She'll fall asleep imagining his breath passing across her neck.

She dreams. Peter is thrusting himself into her sloppy wet pussy. He takes her with long, slow strokes. She turns her head to kiss him. She

enjoys the feeling of their tongues mingling, warm and wet, tastes of wine and chocolate. She closes her eyes and savors the flavors.

When she re-opens her eyes the man inside her is now Scott. He smiles and she smiles back. Scott pushes her back down and grabs her hips in his strong solid grip and increases the pace. He savagely fucks her, like it's the end of the world and she's driving towards an epic climax, her pussy walls pulse and grip as her lover's cock pistons to and fro. The friction burns and she is consumed by the passion until she feels Scott's shaft throb and Robin is filled by his hot potent seed. She comes again and the darkness takes her.

Peter

Around halfway through October, things got hectic around the clinic. Construction of the expansion wing was almost complete and most of the other vets were busy setting up the operating rooms, making sure all the equipment was operational, and writing protocols for all the different procedures we would offer.

I would have been doing the same, but I was tasked with hiring new staff. We expected at least a thirty percent increase in business within the next six months and four full-time doctors weren't going to be able to handle it. I'd already hired three assistants and one fellow who was going to run our in-office drug dispensary. The only position left to fill was for a staff veterinarian.

My first thought was to call Kelly Cho in Seattle. I already knew she was a stickler for detail when it came to her work. I saw that first hand at a seminar in Las Vegas, earlier in the year. I knew she'd make a top notch addition to our team. Plus, there was the added bonus of her being gorgeous and wonderful in bed. She was the first woman I'd slept with,

other than Robin, since our marriage. We hooked up and she showed me how much fun sex could be. She helped me find my confidence and, for that, I'd be eternally grateful.

My dreams of having an office fuck-buddy were dashed within moments of me calling her. She told me, in no uncertain terms, that there was no way in hell she was leaving her low stress, non-profit job. Her husband, Tom, made enough money for the both of them to continue in their hedonistic lifestyle. Plus, Phoenix was too fucking hot.

She told me how much she enjoyed her visit and was looking forward to a time when Robin and I could travel to the Pacific Northwest to see her. I didn't tell her about my ultimatum and my doubts about being married for very much longer. Instead we exchanged a few more pleasantries and said our goodbyes.

That's how I found myself sitting across from a tall handsome brunette, wearing a practical navy blue pants suit with a frilly pink blouse buttoned all the way up to her neck. Her name was Nancy Sloan and, according to her CV she graduated from Ohio State in the top quarter percentile.

"I see you were working part-time at the Humane Society in Columbus," I said, trying to gauge why a highly skilled doctor would work for such low wages and then up and move away. "What brings you to Phoenix?"

"My husband," Nancy said, her voice was stern and professional. "He's in sports medicine and got hired by the Cardinals. We couldn't pass it up."

"Can't argue with that," I said. "What drew you to veterinary medicine?"

Nancy explained how much she enjoyed working with animals and how little she thought about health insurance companies. Her ultimate goal

was to, one day, open her own practice or maybe specialize in horses and larger animals; maybe she would even do both.

“There are lots of horse owners here, in Phoenix, so that doesn't seem too far fetched.”

“I did my research. Bob, that's my husband, also got offered a spot up in Seattle with the Seahawk's organization. He let me pick.”

“A very wise man, your husband. Nice to see you're happy where you landed.”

As we talked I couldn't help but become intrigued by this woman. She was bright and witty, despite her serious exterior, and the more I looked at her the more I noticed how lovely she was.

At first glance her long straight brown hair and brown eyes made her seem plain, ordinary, especially since she wore her hair in a ponytail and hid her eyes behind a pair of stylish but sensible glasses. As I sat and interviewed her, I imagined taking her out to a bar. She'd let down her hair, remove her glasses and unleash her stunning beauty. With her almond eyes, her graceful nose and her adorable chin, she brought to mind a slightly older Natalie Portman.

As she talked, I was spellbound by her lips, perfect lips. She picked just the right shade of lipstick to draw attention to them, without being overly obvious. I, so much, wanted to kiss those lips. I felt myself getting hard and I was suddenly glad I had chosen to remain behind my desk and not conduct the interview from the seat next to her. That would have been awkward and unprofessional.

About as unprofessional as walking around my desk and kneeling in front of her, unbuttoning her blouse and running my hand inside to cup her modest breasts. I imagined her sigh, her perfect lips parting. I was being a very bad man, groping this woman, this doctor. I imagined leaning in to

kiss her and that's when she slaps me. It stings and I pull my hand out of her blouse and touch my sore cheek.

That's when she slaps me again, on the other side.

“Did I tell you to stop?” she says. Her face is frozen, stern, with no hint of frivolity.

I return to groping her and she grabs my face and pulls me in for a kiss. My tongue tentatively explores her mouth, but hers is urgent, forcing its way into me.

How had I become so submissive in my own fantasies.

As we kiss, I undo her pants and pull them down past her knees. She lifts her butt up off the seat to make it easier. She's wearing a thong, a red lacy thong, that clashes with her pants suit. I pay no mind. I push the material aside and begin exploring her wet folds with my fingers.

It had been three weeks since I had sex with Angie – if you call what we did, sex, which I did – and I was exceedingly horny.

In my mind, we were kissing and I was finger-fucking her, when I felt her gently push down on my shoulders. I resisted at first, wanting to continue my digital ministrations, but soon her pressure increased and I submitted. I placed my head between her thighs and greedily lapped at her pussy. Her musky scent drove me wild with desire. I imagined having to impress her with my oral skills so she would except the job we offered, instead of the other way around.

I licked around her engorged labia, bold dark folds, wets with her arousal and my saliva. My tongue lapped at her pebbly skin. Then I moved to her slit, delving deep, thrusting my rolled up tongue in and out as far as I could.

I heard her moans, high pitched and loud. I knew at that moment she was screaming and everyone in the office was going to know she came.

“Oh... OH... That's right, Doctor Wilkenson, lick my cunt. Just like that.”

I licked and flicked and slurped.

“Oh yeah! Oh yeahhh!” Her grip on my hair increased as her moans grew louder.

I twirled my tongue round her clitoris and sucked on it, rubbing my tongue along the smooth skin underneath.

“Oh! OH!” Louder and louder, her juices flowing, the walls of her vagina pulsed as the climax overtook her and I felt a blast of clear fluid in my face.

“Yes! Yes! Yes!” she screamed.

“Yes, Doctor Wilkenson,” Dr. Sloan said to me. She was looking across the desk at me, her blouse buttoned up, her pants still on. “I accept your offer.”

“When can you start?” I asked.

As we worked out the details, I hoped to God my erection would go down before I had to stand up.

I was getting into a bad habit. I had an open arrangement with Robin. I could date whoever I wanted, sleep with whoever I wanted and I kept going back to Angie. My next date with the beautiful red-head was on Halloween. Angie had been invited to a party a bunch of her friends were throwing and she asked me if I wanted to go. Although I knew the crowd would be much younger than me, I decided to say yes.

“We have to wear costumes?” I asked.

“It's a Halloween party, of course you have to wear a costume.”

“Fine,” I said. “Don't tell me you're going as Lucille Ball.”

“Very funny, no. I did that last year. This time I'm gonna be a sexy Ginny Weasley.”

“Huh?” The reference went right over my head.

“Ron's sister.”

“Still no clue.” But I was getting a faint feeling I should know what she was talking about.

“Harry's girlfriend,” Angie said.

“Harry, as in Harry Potter?”

“Yeah, brilliant, ain't it?”

“Uhm.” I didn't like what that meant for me. “So you want me to dress as Harry Potter? Harry Potter, the boy wizard.” I emphasized the word boy.

“Don't be a spoil sport.” Angie was pouting. She looked so cute with her pushed up lip and flared nose. “You'd be Harry, as an adult.” When it didn't seem her childish act was working she quickly shifted gears. “I'll make it worth your while.” Angie's pout turned into a grin, her eyebrows raised, her eyes became hooded. She winked at me and I caught her drift. Ginny was going to get nasty with Harry.

So we rented a wizard's robe and scarf from one of the many costume stores that pop up this time of year. Angie used a little black eyeliner to make a lightning shaped scar on my forehead and I found a suitable sturdy twig to use as my wand and, Presto Chango, or whatever, I was Harry Potter, the boy who lived.

The party should have been fun. A group of young adults, playing dress-up and drinking beer, dancing and flirting, how could it not be? I looked around me and saw a vast assortment of costumes. Sexy nurses, sexy vampires, sexy nuns, and that was just the guys. The women got

really creative. I saw Aphrodite, Wonder Woman and one red-head, not Angie, obviously, dressed in a tight black leather suit and mask doing her best Black Widow, as portrayed by Scarlett Johansson in the Avengers movies. In fact, Angie, voluptuous Angie, had the most modest costume there.

Overall, lots of eye candy. Unfortunately the conversations were all pretty shallow and the music; fuck, was it awful. I was a child of the late eighties, early nineties. I liked Pearl Jam and Nirvana, hell I'd even take Guns 'N Roses over what these kids were listening to: Katy Perry, Taylor Swift and Lady Gaga. My ears wanted to detach from my head and wait for me out in the car. Despite the free booze and Angie's presences and the promise of carnal treats after the party, I was not having a good time.

Instead, I was reminded of my first Halloween after Robin and I got married. She had moved into my small house in Glendale while we waited for our new house to be built. We decided to stay home that night and get dressed up and hand out candy to the kids.

There was no booze (maybe a little wine), no music (fuck it, yes, we had the jazz station playing in the background), and no sexy costumes (oh for three), but we had a great time anyway.

Three Years Prior

“I vant, to suck, your blood,” Peter said in his best, worst, Bela Lugosi impression.

Robin shrieked like a little girl as he playfully lunged for her from behind the bedroom closet door.

It was their first Halloween as a married couple and they wanted it to be special.

Peter had rented a fairly expensive black cape with a red velvet lining. He wore it over a black tuxedo he had acquired a few years before. Robin had sewn in an exaggerated collar for him. His finishing touches were white pancake makeup, bold black eyeliner, blood red contact lenses and realistic plastic fangs with a little red food coloring.

They weren't going out, but the couple planned to give any kids who stopped at their house to trick-or-treat a moment to remember.

“You're going to give a few kids nightmares with that get-up,” Robin said as she pulled away and inspected her husband's handiwork. “Nicely, done.”

“Isn't scaring kids the reason for the season?”

“Okay, I'll direct all the angry parents in your direction.”

“Look who's talking. Your costume isn't exactly warm and fuzzy.”

Robin was dressed like a witch, straight out of a Brothers Grimm nightmare. She wore a frumpy black dress with lots of tears in it; she got it from a thrift store so she didn't mind destroying it for her art. She stuffed it with crumpled newspaper to give some heft to her thin frame.

“The breasts look good on you,” Peter said.

Robin smacked him with her straw broom. She had stuffed the bosom of the dress to add two cup sizes – for realism. She made up her face with sickly green foundation and added a few moles and warts using tips she found on a theatre make-up website. She wore ratty sandals with a pair of gaudy multi-color socks. She topped the whole thing off with a tall pointy witch's hat.

Her costume was the opposite of sexy.

“No one's gonna want to suckle from these puppies,” she said, groping her stuffed breasts with her free hand.

“I might,” Peter said, re-affecting a Transylvanian accent.

“You're funny, Peter,” his wife said. “You go get the candy ready. I need to finish teasing my hair.”

When she joined him in the kitchen, Peter was amazed at how scary and different, she looked, specially with her hair ratted up and shooting out in all directions. She wasn't his petit gorgeous wife this evening, she was a real fairy-tale witch, getting ready to hand out enough candy to give every Hansel and Gretel who knocked on her gingerbread house diabetes.

“Don't stand there gawking,” she said. “Pour me a glass of wine before I turn you into a frog.” She screeched out the last bit trying to sound like the wicked witch, but Peter was reminded more of Golem. It didn't matter. They were going to have a fun night.

They were carefully sipping wine, so as not to ruin their make-up, when the doorbell rang.

“Let's go scare the shit out of some little kids,” Peter said, as he grabbed the bowl of miniature Snickers, Mounds, and Milky Way bars.

“Right behind ya, Count.”

Robin and Peter, or more accurately, the wicked witch and her royal vampire sidekick spent the next few hours spooking and then calming down dozens of neighborhood kids, out enjoying the Halloween tradition of asking for bribes of candy in exchange for not TP'ing or egging one's home. They were visited by superheroes, cowboys and indians, princesses and princes. There was even one pair of kids, no more than five or six, dressed like Hansel and Gretel. The children's mother wanted a picture with the witch and Robin was more than happy to oblige. She gave the woman her e-mail address, so she could get a copy of the picture.

The kids kept coming and the monstrous couple kept handing out the candy and no one threw any toilet paper or eggs at their home and all was well.

“That was so much fun,” Peter said, as he closed the door on the last visitor of the evening, a seven year old boy who had dressed up as Chewbacca but had taken off his mask because it was so hot. “Now, it's my turn for a treat.” Peter took the last of the little mounds bars out of the bowl. “You want one,” he said as he passed the bowl to his witchy wife. “Still a couple Snickers left.”

“No, I've got an idea for a better treat,” Robin said. She turned to head into the bedroom. Her overstuffed bustle swishing back and forth. “You finish locking up, Count, and meet me in our bed chamber.” She did a half turn and blew him a kiss.

Dissonant thoughts fought for control of his body. Peter knew his beautiful wife was somewhere underneath all that ripped fabric and green and black facepaint. He was aroused and repulsed at the same time.

He let Beasley out into the backyard to do his business and put away what little candy was left over. Like every night, Peter checked to make sure all the doors were locked and all the lights were out. He let the dog back in and made sure he had plenty of food and water before rejoining his wife.

When Peter opened the bedroom door, the sight that greeted him left him immobile. He wasn't sure what he had expected, but it wasn't the vision that appeared before him.

“I've been waiting for you, my pretty,” Robin said, her voice crackling. She was laying on the bed on her side, her bottom leg stretched out the other bent at the knee. One arm supported her head, the other was akimbo.

She wore a green and black corset, one Peter was unfamiliar with, that pushed her modest breasts into mouthwatering cleavage. She also wore the tiniest pair of dark green panties over suspenders and sheer black stockings.

Her extremely sexy outfit complimented and contrasted with her face, still made up with warts and moles and sickly tones, and her hair, still teased out and ratty. Robin had turned from a wicked witch to a sexy witch, and her husband's libido was doing cartwheels.

Peter looked at his wife's body, lean and curvy with just enough skin showing to tantalize. he got hard imagining himself lost in his wife's treasures. Then he looked up at her face and shivered. His mind trying to dig through the layers of facepaint but unable to. He thought about closing his eyes, but he couldn't.

He wanted to fuck this witch, warts and all.

“I want to suck your boobies” Peter said, returning to his horrible accent.

“Come and get them, my Count,” Robin said as she lay back spread eagle on the bed. “I'm your treat this evening.”

Peter quickly shed his shoes and cape and vest and dived into the bed. It creaked in protest from the extra weight. He buried his face into the fleshy mounds created by his wife's corset. He rubbed his face back and forth in the valley between her breasts, reveling in the feeling of her flesh against his.

He pulled back to admire his handiwork, a Pollock painting of white and black and red makeup smeared on her pale pink skin.

“You're so beautiful,” Peter said, looking up into his wife's sickly green face. No accent this time. He was serious.

“Liar,” Robin said, picking at a loose wart.

Her husband moved up until the couple were face to face, his body pushed against her. She could feel his growing erection through her fine silk panties and his tuxedo trousers.

“Beauty is in the eye of the beholder,” Peter said. He kissed her neck.

“Then you must be blind.”

Peter pushed himself up, his hand planted on either side of Robin's shoulders, his cock pushed even harder against her mound. For him, her beauty burned through the makeup. “Robin, I can see fine. When I look at you, my heart melts. I see love and joy and fun. I see adventure. I see your inquisitive nature. I see the woman I want to spend the rest of my life with.”

Peter took a finger and ran it across her face. “I see your beauty on the outside,” he pointed to her chest, “and the inside.”

Robin felt her heart beat with passion for this man looking down on her. When they first met, that fateful rainy night, her emotions were awash in agony and pain over her injured dog, but she still had room inside her to crush on the cute vet taking care of it. That crush grew to infatuation and lust and finally love.

As she lay in that bed, all those feelings mashed together, like their bodies. Robin knew she had made the right choice in marrying Peter, and that she would go to her grave loving him.

She reached up and pulled her husband down for a kiss. She put her lips to his ear and whispered, “I want you inside me.”

If there were any five words a man would want to hear more, Peter didn't know them.

“No place I'd rather be,” he said, reaching down to unzip his pants and free his cock. He tried to remove Robin's panties but was having no luck.

“Rip the fuckers off,” she said.

Peter was stunned by his wife's language, but not so much he wasn't able to heed her command and rip the fabric away.

Robin felt a little sharp pain as the silk tore away, but it was lost among the sensations of lust and desire. She reached for Peter's cock and help guide him in to her.

Peter slid in with ease. He was hard for her, she was wet for him and the Count and the witch fucked the night away.

Robin closed her eyes and focused on the feeling of being totally filled. Her pussy pulsed around her husband's turgid penis as it thrust in and out of her. She had never felt so consumed in all her life. She had given herself fully to this man, Peter, and he had gladly taken her. Several small tremors of pleasure rolled through Robin before she felt the warmth of her husband's release. She heard him grunt as his cock twitched and shot string after hot sticky sting of semen into her womb.

It felt comforting.

As they lay together, a greasy sweaty mess, spooning in bed, Robin thought about the seed that Peter left inside her, knowing it would never, could never, find an egg to fertilize. She was melancholy, cursed by God or nature never to have children of her own, but as long as she had Peter, her life would never be barren.

For his part, Peter lay spent. He had made love to his wonderful wife, dressed up as an ugly witch, and had enjoyed every thrust and withdrawal. The complex interplay of lust and revulsion added a spice to their coupling. In his mind, he knew he should be horrified by her green warty face and frizzy hair, or at least turned off. His body reacted differently showing him how desire and distaste – pain and pleasure – could combine to form an experience like no other.

It was a lesson Peter tucked away and never really explored again, until a trip to Vegas two and half years later forced him to.

Peter

After the Halloween party, I dropped Angie off at her apartment.

“You coming up for a nightcap?” she said.

“I’ve had enough to...”

“You know that means sex.”

“Yes,” I said smiling. “I know that means sex.” For some reason I wasn’t feeling it. I liked Angie. I really did. I just didn’t feel like sleeping with her that night. I felt guilty about it, but I couldn’t help it.

I didn’t love her, that emotion reserved for Robin, and I absolutely didn’t want her becoming attached to me.

“How about some other night?” I said. I always liked to keep my options open.

“Sure.” Angie looked a little disappointed, like a kid not getting the candy she asked for, but not too distraught. I think I was over-thinking our friends-with-benefits relationship.

We kissed goodnight. A deep wet kiss that almost had me change my mind. Angie broke it off before I could though. We said goodnight and I went home.

The next morning I got a surprise call from my wife.

“Robin, it’s nice to hear from you.” I was totally being honest. Despite being pissed at her, I still loved my wife and loved talking to her. Plus I knew – prayed – that one day she would call and tell me she was dumping Scott. This wasn’t that day.

“Peter, I’m so glad you took the call. I was afraid you might ignore me.”

“That's stupid.”

“Never mind. I can't talk long. Too much shit happening here.”

I could hear the din of movement through the line. “You guys aren't open yet, are you?” I asked.

“No. That's why I called. We're having a soft open in two weeks. I'd like you to come up for it.”

“Soft open?”

“Yeah. We open the doors to customers but don't advertise. It's a way to get the kinks out of the system before our grand opening, the day after Thanksgiving. I'll make it worth your while to come.”

“Will you now?” My mind turned to nasty thoughts.

“Free massage,” she added.

More nasty thoughts.

“I've got this great guy. He's from Hong Kong and his hands are magical.”

My thoughts got less nasty, until I thought about him giving Robin a rubdown, complete with a very happy ending. I started to get hard.

Man was I a mess.

“I'll be there.” I said.

Chapter 6

Robin

It's Monday morning and Robin's alarm clock buzzes on the nightstand next to her bed. It's four a.m. and she's up with a start.

She has a quick shower followed by a bowl of instant oatmeal. Two thoughts sit at the front of her mind. Today the doors of her spa open for the first time to real paying customers and she'll see Peter again. She has missed him these past six weeks. Luckily for her, the needs of her job have occupied most of her time. That's not the case anymore. The work is done, the staff is hired and now it's just taking care of the clients.

The doors open at six. No one is waiting. The staff is idle. Robin expected as much. The only people who know the joint is open are the concierges at the local resorts she talked to and the few people who follow the Spa's Facebook page.

Robin is not worried. Today is about quality of service not quantity of patrons. That will come later.

At noon, Robin checks with her front desk staff. So far there have been five walk-ins; two paid for one-day passes to use the fitness equipment, two were locals who signed up for a six-month membership and one got a massage. Two people staying at the Sedona Hilton Resort scheduled massages for tomorrow and two people called about the yoga classes which will start in December.

Robin is fine with how the business is running, but she's concerned because there's still no sign of Peter. She walks through the fitness room, looking at the patrons sweating and grunting, lifting weights and walking on treadmills. Sometimes that's how she envisions herself, futility pushing

against the weight of the day, and moving for hours at a time, but getting nowhere. She hadn't been expecting Peter right at opening, but had hoped he'd be there by noon. She reaches for her phone to call her husband but realizes she's left it at home.

By five o'clock the fitness room is full, as are all four massage rooms. One of the four private sauna rooms is free. Peter is still not among the people using the Spirit Spa. Robin starts to pace, she snaps at Marylyn, her assistant manager, when she suggests Robin go home for the day. She's mad at Peter and is taking it out on herself and her staff. *Maybe I should go home*, she thinks.

A menagerie of emotions swirl through Robin's mind. Peter should be here, he promised he would be. This is a big day for her, she built this spa from scratch and was it really too much to ask to celebrate all the work and dedication with her husband? She is proud of her work and her staff; they'd achieved so much. She is both excited and worried about the future of her business and her marriage. But most of all, she is angry and sad that Peter chose to abandon her.

Sure she hasn't been the best wife, maybe she was the worst. But she loves him and he loves her, she thinks; a lot had happened since Vegas. She's not sure how she feels about Scott, those emotions are more, complex. If pushed she will call it love, definitely lust.

Robin surveys the spa. All is running well so she goes home at seven. She instructs her staff to call her if there are any emergencies. She doesn't mention Peter; they'll figure it out.

At home, her apartment in Camp Verde, she sits in the dark, a glass of wine in hand, her second of the evening. She takes a sip and stares off out the window into the darkness of the high forest. Her cell phone sits on the end-table next to her. Peter had called once in the morning, when she was

in the shower and once in the afternoon. He didn't leave a message. If he wasn't coming why didn't he leave a fucking message.

She briefly worries he might have been in an accident, but she was sure someone, a family member or public official, would have notified her. Plus, he did try to call, she just wasn't able to answer.

She's mulling over calling him, she should. Give him a piece of her mind. She reaches for the phone, but stops. She doesn't want Peter to think she's anxious, although she is. That would be admitting weakness and that wasn't acceptable. Instead she takes another sip of wine.

The alcohol is going to her head. She's been too busy to eat. She's buzzing and stumbles a little when she gets up to head to the fridge.

The door bell rings and she almost drops her wine glass.

It's him, she thinks – she hopes. Her excitement builds. She rushes to the door and throws it open. Her heart skips a beat when she sees him standing there, in his black slacks, his silver and blue silk shirt shimmering in the moonlight, the top three buttons undone, his dragon tattoo peaking out from behind the fabric.

“Scott,” she says, breathless and a little slurred. “I wasn't expecting you.”

“I like you that way,” he says. “Surprised.” Scott leans in for a kiss. Robin hesitates but relents. She wants her husband's support but wasn't going to pass any comfort offered, especially when it came in such a handsome package. She parts her lips and allows Scott's tongue to enter her. Her mind is reeling. She's mad at Peter for not showing up. He should have come. He should have called. But he didn't.

“Come in,” Robin tells Scott. She grabs her lover's hand and pulls him inside. “You want something to drink?”

“I'll have whatever I tasted on your lips.”

She really wanted to see Peter, spend time with him, talk some sense into him, but he didn't show up. Anything that happened tonight would be his fault.

The couple sits on the couch, his arm around her shoulder, her head leaning against his chest. For the first time, Robin feels guilty, like she's hiding something from Peter, from her husband. She hadn't planned to sleep with Scott, hadn't even expected him to show up. But he did.

Robin's anger flares again.

"Your staff seems very competent," Scott says as he strokes her hair. "You did well."

"Thanks, boss," Robin says. She tilts her head, their eyes lock. "But let's not talk about work. Not now. Not when we're like this."

"Like what?" Scott says, feigning ignorance.

"Like this." Robin leans up and kisses her lover. Now it's her tongue invading. She reaches down and slips her hand into Scott's pants. She grasps his hardening cock and slowly strokes it.

When she awoke this morning all she thought about was work and Peter. The spa was fine. Peter pissed her off. She planned to enjoy fucking her husband, re-bonding with him. He chose to ignore her.

Robin's hands are slick with sweat and pre-cum. She hungers. She longs to be filled. Peter's cock would have been preferred, Scott's will substitute nicely. She'll never tell either of them. She licks her lips, frees Scott's erection and devours him.

Later, when she's on the bed, her ass in the air, Scott's wonderful cock thrusting in and out of her drenched pussy, she thinks of Peter, sitting at home, alone. She closes her eyes and imagines it's her husband fucking her, filling her completely. She shudders as another orgasm takes her.

“That's your fifth of the night, I think,” Scott says, feeling his lover's pussy grip and pulse around his member.

Robin's reminded who she's really with and is a little sad. But just a little, like settling for a Coke when you really want a Dr. Pepper.

“It's been a while,” she says. Her head is down, her mind is focused on the pleasure.

“Peter not doing it for you?”

Why does he have to be a dick, she thinks?

“Shut up and fuck me.”

Scott picks up speed. “You're the boss,” he says, with a hint of irony.

A few moments later she feels his cock pulse and expand. Scott grunts a few times as he fills the condom with semen. Robin comes again, for the sixth and final time that evening.

The couple collapse on the bed, satisfied and spent.

Peter

My phone buzzed and woke me up. I looked at the screen. It was my partner and head vet at the clinic, using his personal phone. I wiped the junk out of my eyes and took a sip of water before answering.

“Brian, this better be good,” I said. “It's four in the morning.”

“Sorry, but it's not good, Peter. We need you to work today.”

“I took the day off. I've got plans.”

“Got a call from Animal Control. We've got a house full of sick and dying cats out past Apache Junction. We need everyone today.”

I knew then, that any plans I had for today were blown up. I dialed Robin to let her know I wouldn't be dropping by, no matter how much I was looking forward to it. She didn't answer her phone, probably too early or too busy. I hung up, expecting to call her back later.

I took a quick shower, put on a pair of old jeans and a thick long sleeve cotton shirt. I pulled on my heavy duty work boots, grabbed my medical bag and headed out the door. I was doing field work today.

I was driving out State Route 60 when my partner called back with more details. It was an animal lover's worst nightmare. The Arizona Highway Patrol had been called to a ranch house full of half-feral cats. No total count yet, that would come later. The owner was dead, had been for a few days. Most of the cats were sick, some worse than others; a few were already dead.

I had always known Brian, our managing partner, had a friend in the Department of Public Safety. Today that friend called in a favor. There were too many animals for them to handle, so they were subcontracting our clinic. I hoped the money was worth the headache ahead of us.

It was around six in the morning when I pulled up the long dusty gravel road to the compound in question. The sky was an orangish-pink, as the sun was starting to peek out from the mountains in the distance. The flashing red and blue lights of the emergency vehicles in the early dawn made me think of a rave I had been dragged to in my college days, except there was no music and most of the people milling around wore guns and badges.

I found Brian talking to one of the officers.

“Hey, partner,” I said, “What's going on?”

“Peter, thanks for helping out.” Not like I had a choice. “Diane should be here in another half-hour. She had to pick up supplies at the office.” That would be body disposal bags and plenty of drugs. I had never been called out on anything like this, but I'd heard stories. Horrible stories.

Brian introduced me to his friend, Steve, the guy who gave him the tip. Then he took me into the house.

“Here, you better put this on,” my partner said as he handed me a disposable mask to cover my nose and mouth. “It's pretty rank in there.”

He wasn't kidding. The home was a chaotic mess, a feline tragedy. I couldn't believe anyone could live like this, in a home overrun by animals. A sickly ammonia odor permeated everything, the walls, the carpet, the furniture. Luckily the deceased owner was a smoker so that helped cover some of the more nausea-inducing smells. I was glad I had skipped breakfast. My clothing would have to be burned.

There were cats everywhere I looked. Some were milling around across the floor, over and under the tables and chairs. Some were lying down on the couch, on the floor or high up on bookcases and kitchen cabinets. Some of the prone animals were having a hard time breathing, more than a few were already dead. In the kitchen, some adventurous feline had knocked over the industrial sized bag of cat food and had torn it open. A few cats were nibbling on the crumbs that remained. If the Highway Patrol hadn't found them when they did, I was sure the survivors would soon be feasting on their fallen fellows.

When Diane showed up, the three of us got to work. The next nine hours went by in a blur of action. We rounded up the healthy cats with the Animal Control officers who took them to any shelter that would have them. They promised no-kill shelters would be their primary choice, but we knew a few might not avoid their deceased brother's and sister's fates. Then we decided which of the remaining cats could be saved and which were too far gone and would have to be put to sleep. Euthanizing an animal is my least favorite part of being a vet – worse than actually telling the owner it was necessary.

In the end we saved about half the felines left in the house, thirty-one animals in all. It was tiring work, but good work.

Around four in the afternoon we were ready to leave, the investigation into the owner's death was still on-going, but that wasn't our problem. I changed cloths in a DPS van, put my dirty jeans and shirt in a thick plastic bag and headed home.

I tried to call Robin, tell her I was sorry for missing her big day, but she didn't answer. I didn't feel like leaving a message, maybe I was pissed she didn't answer, like she was scanning my calls. Petty things like this seemed to set me off in recent days. I wanted life to get back to normal for us, or at least as normal as it could be. I tried to text her, but I was driving and I gave up after three aborted attempts.

I was exhausted when I got home and too tired to do much of anything. I threw my urine and blood soaked clothes in the trash, tossed my phone, wallet and keys into a basket on my dresser, slipped my shoes off and fell face first on the bed.

The last thoughts I had were about Robin and how much I wanted to see her, to feel her arms around me. I should have called again, I knew that. I'd call in the morning, I thought. Go up and see her. What difference could one day make.

At seven, the next morning, the first thing I did after I woke up, was call Robin. Before I took a shower, before I had a cup of coffee, before I took a piss. I called Robin.

I knew she'd be disappointed, but shit happens. I'd apologize. She's forgive me. Life would go on.

I pressed the icon on my smartphone that dialed my wife's number, I knew I had. The picture on my phone was her bright smiling face, a

twinkle in her hazel eyes. That's why I was shocked when Scott answered the phone.

“Hey, Peter,” he said. “What's up?”

“What the hell are you doing with Robin's phone?”

“Come on, Peter. Calm down. I didn't want her to miss an important call.”

“Where is she?”

“In the shower.”

“Why are you there?”

There was a pause on the line. “Do you want to know?”

No. I didn't want to know, but I already did. “Did you spend the night?”

“Yes, Peter. Something wrong with that?”

God he was being a dick. Rubbing my nose in it. I wanted to say yes, but it wasn't my decision to make, and Scott knew that. I thought Robin had taken a break from screwing him, from screwing me, too.

I guess Scott beat me to her.

“You're pretty quiet, Peter. Everything okay?”

I wasn't going to give the asshole the satisfaction of knowing how mad he made me.

“It's fine, Scott.” I guess I could have waited for Robin to finish her shower. I could have called back. I kept imagining her, naked in front of him, water dripping off her pale pink skin, her breasts exposed to his gaze, maybe his touch.

I was getting annoyed and aroused. “Tell her, I'll call her back later,” I lied.

“Sure thing, Petey.”

“Fuck you, Scott,” I said just before hanging up.

I was really lost in a whirlwind of my emotions, buffeted about like a kitten's plaything. I thought Robin and I were on a path to reconciliation, I really did. She invited me up for her 'soft open.' I had hoped it would be me and her, getting reacquainted after so many weeks and miles apart.

Guess I assumed too much. She didn't even have the courtesy of telling me Scott was going to be there, too. I was hurt and confused and about to call my lawyer, when I realized I didn't have a lawyer. It was time I looked into getting one.

I was scheduled to work today, but I told Brian I was taking the day off to compensate for the work I did at the cat ranch. I jumped into the shower with the full intention of researching divorce lawyers when I was done. I scrubbed away the grime and debris and odor of yesterday and decided today was the first day of the post-Robin era.

And I was happy.

I thought about all the things I could do without worrying about what Robin wanted. I could date whomever I wanted. Go to a strip club, even. As I thought about it more, I realized there wasn't all that much I could do with Robin out of my life that I couldn't do with her in it. My life wasn't going to be that much different. I just wouldn't have anyone to share it with, now.

At one time, that might have deterred me, but now I knew better. Sure, I'd be alone for a while, but was that a bad thing? And if I wanted to date, then I would. There are plenty of women interested in a smart, nice man like myself. It was a matter of going out and finding them.

First, I had to end my marriage. If Robin wasn't willing to make that decision, I guessed it would be up to me.

I went to my closet in the master bedroom and pulled down our box of important documents: deed to the house, birth certificates and of course our

marriage certificate. I was pulling it down, confident I was making the right move, when I glimpsed it, tucked in the back corner of the closet, forgotten in the dry desert clime.

The little yellow umbrella.

And a flood of emotions were unleashed all because of that fucking umbrella.

I started to cry, imaging life without Robin. Sure I'd be able to date again, but I really didn't want to live with anyone else. I wanted Robin.

That silly little yellow thing was the first move in our personal relationship. Robin had left it at the clinic, fully aware I would see it and contact her. Now it was my turn. I had to call her and let her know I did love her and I did want her to be my wife. If that meant swallowing my pride and making the first move, then so be it.

I hadn't planned on calling Robin back, but I did it anyway.

"Peter?" She answered on the first ring. Her voice was soft and sweet. "I'm glad you called back. Where were you, yesterday?"

"It's a long story," I said. "One I'd love to tell you over a cup of coffee, or glass of wine."

"I was waiting for you, all day."

We talked for half an hour. Her telling me about the spa, me apologizing for missing her big day, but not telling her what kept me away; the story was too graphic to describe over the phone.

I didn't want to talk about Scott and ruin the moment we were sharing, but I had to.

"Scott still there?" I asked.

"No." Robin's voice was decisive and a bit harsh. "He's gone back to L.A."

"Did you know he was going to show up?" I had to know.

“No,” she said. And I believed her. “I thought he might be. He is the owner and it's not like I could tell him to stay away.” I didn't ask her if she would have asked him to stay away if she could. “I was really looking forward to seeing you.”

That felt nice to hear. It gave me the confidence to ask the next question.

“Did you sleep with him?”

I knew she did, or strongly felt it. I wanted to know if she was woman enough to tell the truth.

Robin paused. I could imagine her face, twisting with indecision, sure she'd feel guilty but would she be willing to face the consequences of her actions?

“Yes,” my wife said.

“Do you still...”

“I'm not done answering,” she said, cutting me off. “Yes, I slept with him. You didn't come, like you said you would. And, you didn't call.”

“I told you...”

“Let me finish, Peter. You didn't call. I was upset. I was vulnerable. And Scott was here and you weren't. If it makes you feel any better, I thought of you several times last night.”

It didn't make me feel any better – maybe a little. God, was I fucked up.

“Okay,” I said. “I'll forgive you.”

Another pause.

“I didn't apologize. Why should I apologize? We've both been fucking other people. I thought we agreed on an open arrangement?”

She was technically right, we had. I thought that was on hold while our marriage was in doubt.

“Peter?”

“Yes, you're right. You're always right.”

“Don't be a dick, Peter. Be a man.”

“Would a man let another man fuck his wife?”

“I'm not your possession, Peter.”

“We made a vow.”

“You fucked other women.”

“But, only after you fucked Scott.”

This conversation was getting out of control. We were both getting mad and emotional and I was sure we'd soon be saying things we didn't mean and would both soon regret.

“Do you want a divorce, Peter?” Robin's voice was calm, but I knew her heart was trembling. I knew, for sure, she still loved me.

“Do you still love Scott, Robin?”

These questions would end up killing us, killing our marriage. Neither of us spoke, right away.

“I really want to see you, Peter.” Robin was the first to break the silence. “I want to hug you, kiss you, feel you, inside me.” It was as if she was reading my mind. “Come up here, on Black Friday, the day after Thanksgiving. It's our grand opening.”

That was a wonderful idea, but, “Will Scott be there?” I didn't really care, I was going to go either way. I just wanted to be prepared.

“No, Peter. Only you and me and about a hundred patrons and employees.”

“Sounds like a date,” I said. “And I do expect a free massage. You do owe me that.”

Robin laughed. “Sure thing, Peter.”

“And I want it from the manager, not the hired help.”

“And you'll want a happy ending, I'm sure.”

“Yep. For both of us.” I hung up the phone before our conversation got any dirtier and I'd have to take another shower, a cold one.

Chapter 7

Peter

A little over two weeks later, I was driving north to Sedona. While most people were crowding the malls and department stores, trying to find super deals for themselves or someone on their Christmas list, I was on the road. Once I passed the Mogollon Rim, the beige desert landscape gave way to wintery white and green. The ponderosa pines of the Cocconino National Forest were dusted with snowflakes from an overnight flurry. The roads were clear and I rolled down the windows so I could breathe in the cool crisp air.

I was happy.

The drive through the canyons leading into Sedona was especially breathtaking, the red and yellow rock formations blanketed with snow, with scattered green and blue pines poking through. As I got closer to the spa, traffic started to accumulate. Even in this out of the way location, deep in the national forest, people were drawn to the shops and restaurants.

I pulled into the Sedona Spirit Rejuvenation Spa and Fitness Center around two in the afternoon. There were no open parking spaces, so I had to pull up to the valet stand. I traded my keys and a ten dollar bill for a green ticket stub. The nice young woman in the red blazer smiled as I handed them over.

“Enjoy yourself,” she said as she got into my car and drove away.

“Hope to,” I said to no one.

I walked into the spa and was overwhelmed. Immediately to the left of the entrance was a reception desk where two cheerful young women, one Korean and one who looked either Hispanic or Native American, were busy

trying to take care of a line of people, most of whom looked like they needed more than a little exercise.

I moved further inside. The lobby opened up into a large gym area with treadmills, stationary bikes and various weight machines. On the far side, I saw a doorway covered with a privacy curtain. A sign above it indicated the massage and aromatherapy rooms lay beyond. The entrance to the changing rooms were on the wall to the left, next to a glass double door that lead to the pool, saunas and hot tubs.

The atmosphere was festive. Holiday music played over the sound system, although it was barely audible over the grunts of patrons and the clanks of weights. Occasionally the sounds of splashing could be heard when someone opened the door to the pool area.

Looking around, I estimated that about half the equipment was in use. If the spa could keep even half this initial business it would thrive. I was really impressed with what Robin had accomplished. It wasn't that I didn't think she could do it – one of Robin's finest qualities is her ability to start a project and see it to completion – I was surprised she had the desire. I was sure Scott had no small part to play in that.

I started to head over to the massage area, intending to explore and try to find Robin, when I was stopped by a tall young man, maybe twenty-five, with deep brown skin, wearing black sweatpants and a lavender polo shirt with the spa's logo on it. His name tag identified him as Bradley, a fitness trainer. His shirt fit like a second skin, his muscles barely contained by the cotton material.

“Can I help you, sir?” he said, his voice stern, yet polite.

“I'm just looking,” I said. I wanted to surprise Robin so I was avoiding identifying myself.

“You should check in first.”

I turned to the desk. The line was three deep and didn't seem to be moving very fast. I'd have to give up my anonymity if I wanted to get in before dinner time.

“Actually, I'm looking for my wife,” I said, scanning the room.

“Is she working out?” Bradley asked. “Or getting a massage?”

“Oh, she's not a customer. She's the manager.”

Bradley's eyes grew big, the white glowing in contrast to his dark skin. “You're Ms. Wilkenson's husband,” he said. I didn't like the Ms., but at least he wasn't surprised to learn she was married.

“Yes. I'm Peter.”

“I'm Brad.” The well-muscled employee extended his hand out. We shook. “Nice to meet you. Heard a lot about you.” He spoke fast, like he was a little nervous about meeting the boss's mate.

“Only good things, I hope.” I smiled, trying to soothe his anxiousness. I prayed he didn't know his boss had a lover on the side.

“Oh, yes, sir. Only good things.” I didn't want to take up any more of Bradley's time. I looked around and saw plenty of plump sweaty bodies that needed his attention. Luckily, one of those bodies, a short stout man in his late forties walked by. He had a membership badge clipped to his gym shorts and he looked lost.

Brad pointed further off into the spa and said Robin was back in the pool area, then he excused himself and went to help the man.

The doors to the pool area were frosted glass and slick with condensation. When I opened them a wave of humidity spilled out and almost took my breath away. The smell of chlorine stung my nose as I entered. I looked around and didn't immediately spot my wife.

I did see a modest sized pool in the far corner of the room with about half a dozen people taking a water aerobics class. A couple of jacuzzis sat

along the far wall; one was occupied. The wall to my left had four doors leading to private saunas. The lockers and changing rooms were off to my right. They could be accessed from both the gym and pool areas. Overall, I was impressed with the layout. Functional and compact.

As I looked closer I saw that Robin was leading the water exercises. Her hair was tucked into a pink cap and she wore a modest lavender one-piece swimsuit. I sat down on a bench and watched her work. She exuded confidence. We liked swimming, but I never figured her for an instructor. I could only imagine the stress she must be under. Juggling a start-up business while sleeping with the owner and having a husband. Somehow she managed. Leading an aqua-aerobics class was probably the easiest thing she did all day.

None of the stress showed. Her focus was on the six people in front of her. She demonstrated what she wanted them to do then encouraged them as they tried to copy the moves they had been shown and corrected them when necessary.

I was in love with this woman. I always knew she was smart and beautiful, but I was seeing a side of her I never knew existed. She displayed a competence and confidence that had been buried. She had blossomed over the past few months, and I had missed most of it. I always felt lucky to be her husband, I was just blind to what she was capable of.

I started wondering if I had been smothering her all this time, keeping her from achieving her full potential. I really didn't like Scott and thought he was an asshole, but he did seem to bring out the best in her. He sparked her sexuality, got her to explore new experiences, like threesomes and swallowing, not to mention affairs, but he also trusted her enough to build this business with little interference.

For a second, I thought about leaving. I thought about giving up, letting Robin continue with her love affair. She seemed to have achieved a level of satisfaction that I couldn't give her. For a brief moment all the angst and sorrow I had pushed aside after discovering the affair came crashing over me. I was buried in doubt and self-loathing.

Robin turned to me and smiled and washed all that hate away. I saw joy in Robin's face and that made all the trials we had undergone worth it. Her eyes sparkled, her voice sang as she called my name. "Peter."

My heart leapt.

"You're here."

"I told you I would be," I said. Robin didn't bring up what happened the last time I promised that.

She turned to the group. "Class, this is my husband, Peter."

The group of middle aged women smiled at me, some mumbled a hello.

"I hope you don't mind if we end a little early today," Robin said to the group. "I haven't seen him in over two months."

No one objected.

I watched in fascination as my wife climbed out of the pool. She looked perfect, beads of water sliding down her pink skin, her nipples clearly visible, pushing hard against the neoprene fabric of her suit. She removed her cap and shook out her hair. It was growing out quite well and she had even added a few red highlights to her chocolate brown.

"Mind handing me that towel?" she said, breaking the spell I was under.

I handed her the towel that was laying on the bench next to where I was sitting. She quickly dried herself off and wrapped the towel around her waist like a skirt.

“Want a quick tour?” she asked.

“Maybe later,” I said. “There are lots of things I’d like to do first.” Oh, boy, were there. “How about dinner?”

“Sounds good. There’s a fancy pizza place on the main strip in town. I know the manager, he’ll get us seated quick.”

“He will, will he? And what does one have to do to get that kind of service here?”

“Normally, nothing.” Robin paused and gave me a smile, one eyebrow raised. “For you, we’ll have to think of something.”

She let that comment sit for a few seconds before saying she was going to get dressed and asked me to wait out front.

“But what if I want to watch you change?”

“Funny, Peter. I’m at work. No messing around.”

“What if I want to take you in the jacuzzi?” I whispered into her ear, ignoring what happened the last time we fooled around in a hot tub.

“Maybe sometime, after we close,” she said. “For now, let me change.”

I sat near the front desk and waited. It was the happiest I’d felt in a long time. Sure, Robin hadn’t dumped Scott, yet, but I was sure she would make the right decision in the end. If not, then at least I should enjoy the time I had left with her.

I stood up when I saw her exit the changing room and head my way. She was wearing a pair of form fitting black jeans, sexy and casual, and a lavender polo shirt that was one size too big for her. She was the boss and she looked it, crossing the room towards me, her arms swinging, her back straight. She was in control. She answered a few staff questions as she made her way over, pointing out an issue with one of the TVs mounted over

the exercise equipment. It was showing an infomercial, instead of sports or news.

When she got to me, Robin leaned up and gave me a kiss on the lips, discrete – no tongue. It was a nice kiss, a firm kiss and it reminded me of our first kiss, the night of our first date. The kiss that convinced me, she was the woman I was going to marry.

Six-years prior

The sommelier brought the bottle to their table, not a waiter, a sommelier, a staff member whose sole job was to know wine. He showed the bottle to Peter. It was an '04 Sterling Vineyards Cabernet Sauvignon. Peter had read 2004 was a good year for California Cabs due to weather conditions in the Napa Valley. He had tried a few and agreed and at \$150 a bottle, it better be good.

“Good choice, sir,” the wine steward said. He stood tall and erect, dressed all in black - slacks, shirt and jacket, with a thin white tie for contrast.

“Thank you,” Peter said, acknowledging this was the wine he wanted.

The sommelier pulled his wine opener from his jacket pocket. With a few twists and a pull, the cork came out with an audible pop. He handed the cork to Peter, who inspected it. It was a good solid cork, no hint of rot. Peter nodded his head and the man poured a little into his wine glass.

Peter took the glass and tilted it. The wine had a deep red color, no hint of cork particles. Peter swirled the glass and watched the liquid cling to the side of the glass leaving clear tear drops running down showing a high alcohol content. He stuck his nose into the bowl of the glass and inhaled. He could detect a rich fruity aroma like plum and blackberry, with a hint of

chocolate. He took a sip and smiled. Peter wasn't a wine connoisseur, but he could tell a good one.

Peter finished his taste while the sommelier poured some into Robin's glass.

"I think you'll like this," he said to his date. He really hoped she did.

"I don't drink much wine," Robin said. "an occasional white wine spritzer."

The sommelier filled Peter's glass and left the bottle at the table.

"A toast," Peter said. The couple raised their glasses. "To health. May little Beasley live a long and happy life."

"To the doctor who saved him," Robin said. Peter hadn't been fishing for a compliment but he smiled at her words.

"And to his owner." Peter paused. He couldn't think of anything else to say that didn't sound too forward. He was still in that awkward phase of trying to impress her.

They touched glasses and drank. Robin smiled, her eyes lighting up with enjoyment; the complexity of the wine was winning her over.

"This is good," she said, as if she doubted it would be. She took another sip.

"It'll really go well with our steaks." Peter had taken Robin to Cristobal's, a four star steak bistro halfway up South Mountain. They were seated near a large plate glass window with an amazing view of the city. Phoenix lay sprawled out on the valley floor, orange and red in the setting sun. There were a few high-rises, but unlike most big cities, Phoenix had grown outward, not upward.

Over dinner the two got to know each other better. Peter felt so comfortable chatting with this woman. He never talked much about his early years, always being the smartest kid in his class and getting

mercilessly mocked for it. With her, it was different. With Robin, he wanted to open up. Peter told her about his father leaving when he was in middle school and how he helped his mother raise his younger sister. He also talked about some of his more embarrassing encounters with women, although he avoided mentioning the time he accused his girlfriend of cheating on him.

Robin was also open about her past relationships.

“I dated a bit in high school,” she said between bites of her salad. “but I was still technically a virgin when I left New Jersey to study at A.S.U. In fact, the first guy I ever slept with was on the swim team.

“How was he? Performance-wise.”

“Average. We only lasted about six months. He ended up dumping me for a teammate.”

“What a dick. Hope she broke his heart.”

“Actually...” Robin paused as the waiter took their empty salad plates away and delivered the steaks. She waited until he left before she continued. “It was a he, and I think they're still together. He mentioned a wedding on his Facebook page.”

“Nice. So you still keep in touch with him?”

“Sure, why not. He was a nice guy. We just weren't the right match.” She leaned across the table and lowered her voice. “Because I didn't have a dick.”

They both laughed.

The steaks were good, tender and juicy.

“You're so right, Peter,” Robin said after taking a sip of her wine.

“This cabernet goes great with the steaks.”

“You'll also love it with chocolate cake.”

Robin smiled as she drank and imagined biting into a moist slice.

After dinner they sat in silence, enjoying the last of the wine and looking down at the lights of the city, twinkling in the desert heat rising from the valley floor. It was a little after nine when they left. Robin tried to grab the check, but Peter beat her to it.

“Peter, you have to let me at least split the bill.”

“So, you want more work for Sven?” He was their waiter.

“Splitting the bill is not that hard. I used to do it all the time when I was waiting tables back in college.”

“How about you pay next time?”

Robin smiled. “You asking me out for a second date?”

“Only if you pay.”

Robin snickered.

On the ride back to her apartment Peter tuned in the local, light rock station, they played mostly pop hits from the seventies and eighties, nothing too hard. As they drove they firmed up plans for their next date, the following weekend. Robin suggested a movie. Peter countered with putt-putt golf.

“I'd love to,” Robin said. She absentmindedly set her hand down on Peter's thigh. “I haven't played miniature golf since I was in high school back in Jersey.” She squeezed his leg hard. “It's a really great idea.”

Peter was surprised at how forward Robin was. He enjoyed her touch and held still, afraid any movement would give her cause to move her hand away. He tried his best to keep his dick limp, but that was a lost cause. Peter could feel his penis expanding and he was sure Robin would feel it too, any moment.

Luckily – or unluckily – he pulled up to Robin's building and she did finally lift her hand. Peter noticed a slight smile on her lips and her eyes

quickly dart down toward his crotch and back up. Neither said a word about it.

Robin had noticed Peter's erection. She thought about asking him up to her apartment, for a coffee or a nightcap or maybe a quick fuck. She began to open her mouth to speak but thought better. She liked Peter, found him charming and handsome and she really wanted to get to know him better. She thought a long term relationship was a real possibility and she didn't want to ruin it with sex, not right away.

Peter mistook the parting of her lips as an invitation for a kiss. He leaned over and planted one, right on her mouth. Robin was startled and began to pull back, but she continued the kiss, enjoying the taste of this man's tongue, a hint of alcohol and mint. She could feel herself become aroused.

As they sat and kissed a song came on the radio that Robin totally loved. It was Reminiscing by the Little River Band. Her mother must have played it a lot when she was pregnant because Robin could remember getting so excited when it came on the radio when she was a child.

She listened to the song as she melted into Peter's kiss. She imagined growing old with this man, a man she hardly knew. He made her feel warm and safe.

Robin started returning the kiss with a passion that surprised the both of them. She drove her tongue against his, flicking and delving through and around his lips. Their first kiss lasted almost ten minutes, well past the song that drove Robin wild, a two-fer by Fleetwood Mac, and Logical Song by Supertramp. A commercial finally came on, ending their marathon tongue wrestling.

Robin wanted to continue upstairs. Peter would not have turned her down. Robin knew if she and Peter went inside they would end up in bed

together, not that that would be a bad thing, she didn't want to chance ruining their relationship in these early stages. Maybe she was being paranoid, maybe everything would be fine if they ended up fucking. It didn't matter, Robin wasn't taking any chances.

“Peter, I've had a wonderful time.” *Why'd I say that*, Robin thought.

“Me, too.” *Smooth*, Peter said to himself.

Silence filled the Toyota Camry. Silence and a used car commercial on the radio. The couple stared into each other's eyes. Neither wanted to be the one to end the evening, break the connection. They both would have preferred to make the night last forever.

Peter was waiting for Robin to either invite him in or say goodnight. Robin wasn't sure what she was waiting for. The stalemate was broken by a rap on the window next to Robin. They both jumped. It took Robin a few seconds to recognize her neighbor.

“Roll down the window, Peter,” she said.

“Everything okay, Miss Weston?” said the man. He was medium height with dark hair and light brown skin. He looked to Peter to be in his fifties.

“Everything's fine, Mr. Sanchez.” Robin smiled as she spoke. “We're just saying goodnight.”

“Okay.” The man turned and headed back towards the apartment building. “You should ask him in.” Neither could see the smirk on his face as he went inside.

It was another chance for Robin to extend the date, but she didn't take it. She would regret it later that evening, when she was alone, in the dark, listening to Miles Davis and masturbating.

Robin got out of the car. So did Peter. He walked around the front of the Camry to join her. They kissed again. Their lips met briefly, parted and

then pulled away.

“Good night, Peter.”

“Good night, Robin. Can't wait til next Saturday.”

“You don't have to wait that long to call me.”

“I will. I mean, I won't.”

And he did, call her, every night that week.

Peter watched as his date walked up the path and entered her building. He was slightly disappointed she didn't invite him inside, as any man would be, but he was glad she agreed to a second date.

He got back in his car and headed home, making a mental note to ask Robin if she knew the name of that song, the one playing when they started kissing, the one he was humming right now. It had quickly become his new favorite.

On the drive it started raining. A light sprinkle, nothing severe. Peter was glad he still had that little yellow umbrella.

Peter

“In a perfect world,” I said, “what would our relationship be like?”

Robin and I had finished having dinner and drinks and were on our way back to her apartment in Camp Verde. We had finished all the small talk we could handle, stalled as long as we could and now we had to discuss the issue before us.

My wife didn't say anything at first. Either she didn't know or she didn't think I would like her answer. I decided to narrow it down.

“This is a free answer, Robin. I swear, no matter what you say, I won't get upset. I really want to know.”

I glanced over and saw her looking at me. “What?” I said. I turned my attention back to the road.

“Promise?” she asked.

“Promise.” A vow I would quickly regret.

“In a perfect world. I guess I'd want to have two husbands.”

That stung me but I did my best to hide it. There was that promise I made. In the calmest voice I could muster I asked, “so, you'd want to be a bigamist?”

“In a perfect world it wouldn't be called that.”

“Fine, fine.”

“I knew I should have kept my mouth shut,” Robin said. My feelings were showing.

“No!” I spat out the word. “This is important. Honesty is important.”

Neither of us spoke for a little while. The car radio was off and the only noise was the hum of the engine and the steady drone of rubber on concrete.

“What about you?” Robin asked, finally breaking the silence between us. “What would your perfect scenario be?”

“Not sure.”

“You want to go back to us, before Vegas?”

I really didn't know. The thought of life without Scott was tempting, but.

“No,” I said. I really enjoyed my own sexual exploration and I also enjoyed watching another man pleasure my wife. I liked the look she got when she came, her eyes squeezed shut, her mouth opened wide. It was a vision I couldn't get up close and in the midst of my own gratification.

“What do you mean?” my wife asked.

“We've come to far. I've come to far. I have to admit, I've enjoyed my own sexual freedom. I've, learned a lot.”

“Then what's the problem?”

I said the only thing I could think of, "Scott."

"What about him?"

"You love him."

"What about Kim, or this Angie girl?"

"I don't love them."

"You use them for sex?"

"Maybe, maybe I do. But I think it's mutual."

"I can't control my feelings for Scott, any more than I could stop loving you. It's complicated."

"Why did you sleep with him. During the soft open?"

"I wanted it to be you," Robin said. "I was expecting you to show up. But you didn't. I was upset and horny and Scott took advantage of that. I told you this already."

"I know," I said. "I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry, too. I'm not sorry about sleeping with Scott, anymore than you're sorry about sleeping with Kim. I wished it had been you. That is my regret."

I wasn't able to explore this new thread of discussion because we were at her place. I pulled into her driveway and turned off the ignition.

"Here we are," I said, sounding like an idiot. Yes, here we were at Robin's home, her sanctuary from work and the two men vying for her affection. I couldn't assume she wanted to invite me in and I wasn't going to ask. So we sat in silence, both of us looking straight out the windshield at the closed garage door. I started tapping my fingers against the steering wheel. Occasionally the cooling engine would emit a few ticks. Robin's right hand rested on the door handle.

Why couldn't she say something? Why didn't she invite me inside or tell me to go home.

“Well,” she said. Her voice detonated the stillness. I turned toward her. My wife was looking at me.

“Well,” I said.

Was this it? Was this where we parted ways? If she wasn't willing to ask me in, if she was too proud, I guess there was no reason to go any further. I still loved my wife, I couldn't help it. The heart wants what it wants, damn the world. But I'd had enough. I was about to tell her I was going to go home when a hint of yellow caught my eye. It was that goddamn umbrella. I had taken it out of the closet and put it in the back seat. For what reason? I'll never know.

My love for Robin broke through the dam of pride and hatred I had built and flooded through me. I gripped her left hand and felt the ring on her finger. Her wedding band – our wedding band. She still wore it. She still wanted the world to know, she was married. To me.

More pieces of the dam fell away. I grabbed her face with my hands and kissed her hard. Robin willingly melted into my embrace. Our mouths open, our tongues dueling for dominance neither of us were willing to relinquish. I ran my fingers through her soft hair. My wife moaned into my mouth.

I wanted to take this woman and ravish her. It had been so long, so fucking long. My ego made one last stand. It would not allow me to ask about taking our embrace inside. My pride was going to leave it up to her.

If she doesn't want you, it said, she doesn't want you. Live with it.

Fuck you, I said. To my pride, not out loud. Out loud I said, “can we take this inside?”

“I thought you'd never ask.” Robin said.

We quickly made our way to the bedroom. I don't even remember if I bothered to lock the car.

I sat on the bed, Robin was silhouetted by the moonlight coming through the window. Her hair, a dark shimmering halo, as beams of light shot through her shoulder-length locks. She rocked her hips as she loosened her tight jeans and slowly slid them down her thighs. Her pale skin glowed. I wanted to reach out and touch her, but she was too far away so I had to make do with watching her striptease. And I didn't mind at all, since I'd recently learned how much pleasure I got out of watching my wife.

Robin tossed her jeans in the corner. She stood there, swaying her hips back and forth in time with the music in her head. Whatever the tune, it spoke of lust and sex and passion. My wife ran her hands up the side of her body, following each blessed curve God had granted her. At this moment, I believed God was real and God was a woman.

My wife crossed her arms over her chest and gripped the bottom of her polo shirt and slowly, oh so slowly, lifted it. Her hair cascaded down as she pulled it over her head. Robin now stood before me dressed in only a black sports bra and dark cotton panties.

She walked toward me, her dark form growing until we touched. She took my hands and placed them on the waistband of her undies. I took the not-so-subtle hint and pulled them down her legs. She put her hands on my shoulders for support as she stepped out of them. I boldly continued undressing my wife, pulling her bra off, over her head, and tossing it in the heap with the other clothing.

I reached to pull her to me, my mouth watering to suck on her nipples, but she pulled back.

“No, you naughty boy,” Robin said. “Now it's my turn. You need to put on a show for me.”

I was sure Scott never had to do this, but so what. I love entertaining my wife. So we swapped places; it was hard passing her body in the dark without groping her.

I stood a few feet away from the bed and looked down on my wife, naked, leaning back on her elbows, her pussy glistening with dew. I licked my lips and began unbuttoning my shirt. I moved my hips back and forth. Robin smiled.

“Shake that money maker,” she said.

I finished removing my shirt and threw it at her. I took my time, unlatching my belt and sliding it out of my pant loops, one at a time. When the belt was free, I folded it in two and pulled the ends apart with a quick snap. Robin jumped at the loud crack of leather against leather. Her eyes went wide.

“Maybe a little spanking is in order.” I said.

“Have I been naughty?” Robin had bowed her head but her eyes were staring up at me. My cock was rigid. She looked innocent and demure, despite being naked.

“Yes. You have been.” I snapped the belt again. I tossed it to the bed and it landed a couple of inches to my wife's left. I unzipped my pants and let them fall to the floor, bunched at my feet. I stepped out of them, toward my wife. My cock straining against the blue Jockey boxer briefs I wore.

I stood before Robin, who was now sitting up on the edge of the bed. Only a thin layer of cloth and a couple of inches of space separated me from my wife's warm inviting mouth. She licked her lips and my penis twitched.

“May I?” she said, her eyes darting down toward my groin and back up.

“I insist,” I said.

Robin reached out and freed me. She took a finger and dipped it in the drop of pre-cum forming on the tip of my erection. She reached down to her pussy and smeared it against her lips, mixing our juices.

My turgid penis bobbed between us. My wife began stroking it with her left hand while pleasuring herself with her right. I watched as her small hand ran the length of my shaft. It felt so nice, the long slow strokes, especially when her wedding ring bumped against the sensitive rim around the tip. I could feel my climax build.

I looked into my wife's face, her gaze held mine. Her eyes were open wide, burning with an intensity I'd never witnessed before. Deep within my core, the pleasure collected, building tension. I tried my best to hold back, to make it last. I watched as Robin's eye's closed and her head tipped back. Her lips parted and a low moan issued forth.

"I'm close," I said, wanting to warn my wife.

"I know." Robin's voice was little more than a hoarse whisper. "I can feel your cock growing. I want to feel it pulse in my hand. Let it come."

I had never released on my wife's face, I'd never think of asking. It felt too degrading. But how could I turn her down? I threw my head back and grunted. Semen spurted in long ropes. The first shot landed on Robin's chin. A second hit her breast. My wife cried out as her own wave of pleasure crested. My third and fourth spurts landed on her tongue. A few more weak pulses dribbled down her hand.

I was spent. I fell forward onto Robin, forcing her back. We kissed, hard, our tongues swirled. I could taste myself, salty and tacky. We devoured my cum, together.

My wife and I rolled around on the bed, kissing and groping. I grew hard again and Robin mounted me. It felt like home. My hands grasping her perfect ass, my cock enveloped in her hot pussy. I held her close for a

moment. My erection twitching, buried deep within her womb. Robin giggled.

“That tickle?” I asked. My lips were mere inches from her ear.

“A little. In a good way.”

Robin began to slowly grind her hips against me. Her clitoris rubbed my pelvic bone. I laid there and enjoyed my wife's ride.

“God, that feels so good,” she whispered to me. “I love the feel of you. Your arms. Your hair. Your cock.”

“Better than Scott?” I asked, like an idiot.

I expected her to freeze up and snap at me. I didn't expect her to say what she did.

“Yes,” she sighed.

My cock pulsed again.

“Oh,” she said.

We held each other tight. Robin continued to grind. Her sighs building in depth and volume.

“Oh, Peter. Oh. OH!”

Several oh's later I felt the wall's of Robin's pussy constrict around me. She let out a final wail as she came. I hoped the neighbors weren't home. They might think she was dying.

As Robin's climax faded, my own was building. I flipped her over without withdrawing and started thrusting.

The room reeked of sex. The intoxicating aroma of fluids – semen, sweat and vaginal emissions, filled my nose. The sounds of our mating – the slap of wet flesh against wet flesh – drove me on.

When I couldn't hold out any longer, I came, filling my wife with my seed. I felt Robin experience another orgasm – a lesser one – as I came.

We held each other tight.

“I love you, Peter,” Robin said, her voice dry and low.

I had just enough energy to reply back, “I know,” before I fell asleep.

We would wake up, crusty and stinky but I could not have cared less at the moment. I had my wife back. That's all that mattered.

We could burn the sheets later.

Chapter 8

Peter

My life returned to the new normal. The following Monday I went back to my job in Phoenix, living alone, occasionally stopping by the Oasis to see my favorite red-head bartender. We flirted a lot, but didn't go on any more dates. She said she was seeing a guy who worked at one of Scottsdale's fancy Country Clubs; I think it was called Windwalker Ranch. I never met the guy.

Although I believed I could keep 'dating' other women, since Robin and I hadn't finalized any changes in our relationship status, I didn't really feel like it. I didn't think about her fucking Scott. I was too busy with the clinic expansion and his name never came up when I visited my wife on the weekends.

Robin would work a couple hours on Saturday and take Sunday off, so we had a day and a half to spend together. The long distance marriage wasn't ideal, but it worked for us.

On Christmas Eve, I got a surprise. I had finished a six-hour shift in our emergency care clinic and I was looking forward to a nice quiet night at home, then an early morning drive up north to spend the holiday with Robin. I was surprised to find a bright yellow Mazda Miata two-seat convertible parked in my driveway. The top was down.

I had never seen the car before and didn't know who it could belong to. All I did know was that no one was in the car and no one was knocking at my door.

When I got inside, all my questions were answered.

“Robin?” I said, my voice a bit dry with surprise.

My wife was laying stretched out on the couch reading the newest Falcon Tempest novel, a half-full glass of wine on the end table next to her.

“Peter?” she said. Her voice mocking my surprise.

“Wasn't expecting you here. I thought we were spending Christmas at your place?”

“Peter, it's our place.”

“I know, you keep saying that. I just don't feel it.” I really didn't want to get into an argument over our living arrangement so I walked over and gave Robin a kiss on the forehead.

“Never the less,” I said, “it's great to see you here.”

I went into the kitchen to pour myself a glass of wine and almost bumped into my wife when I turned around.

“You don't get off that easily, mister,” she said. Robin took the glass out of my hand and set it down on the counter. She wrapped her arms around me for a big hug and a real kiss on the lips, with lots of tongue and squishing sounds.

I approved and my penis started to respond, as it often did when I kissed her.

“Merry Christmas, dear,” my wife whispered into my ear.

“Best. Gift. Ever.”

We took our wine and ourselves to the bedroom and made love. It was a simple and gentle affair. We undressed each other; our bodies were our gifts. We rolled around on the bed, kissing and exploring. I made my way between her thighs and feasted on her dew. She was tangy and salty and oh so delicious.

After she came, I worked my way back up her body, nibbling on her nipples and up to her neck. As I bit softly at her ear lobe, I slid my erection between her open labia and into her warm pussy. She was silky and

inviting. I slowly stroked in and out. Several moans issued from Robin's lips.

“Peter, you're so good at this.”

“I know.” I wished I really had that much confidence. “Nothing pleases me more than pleasing you.” It was a corny line and I was sure Robin would have laughed if she wasn't half way to another orgasm.

“Oh, God. Peter!” I felt her vaginal walls clamp down around my shaft and that sent me over the edge. My cock pulsed as I shot several blasts of semen into my wife.

We were both sated.

After a short rest, I got up to fix us a light dinner of Italian salad with strips of ham and salami. We ate in bed and watched a little TV, then took a quick nap. We woke up around eleven and got ready for midnight mass. After church, it was back to bed where we both fell into a deep and restful sleep. Everything seemed to be settling into place. Our lives, while far from conventional, were coming into balance.

“Wake up, sleepy head!” I felt a pressure on my shoulder. It was Robin.

“What time is it?” I said, swatting her hand away.

“Six o'clock.”

“In the morning?” My voice was sluggish. We had about four hours of sleep.

“Yes. In the morning. Come on, it's time to open presents!” She sounded as eager as a little girl expecting a pony under the tree.

“Ugh.” I always thought getting up early for Christmas was for parents with eager kids. “Can't it wait?” I turned my back to Robin and covered my head with a pillow.

“No!” Robin punctuated her answer by pulling the covers and pillow off me. I lay there, curled up in a fetal position, my naked body tense in the cool dry air.

“Robin. Please.” I wanted to cry like a little boy, but I didn't.

“No,” she said again. This time she was walking away. “I'm going to go make you some coffee. Be in the living room when it's done.”

I slowly drug my tired body up and into the bathroom, where I splashed some cold water on my face. I threw on a pair of pajama pants and sloughed into the living room, like the walking dead. Robin was waiting there with a steaming cup of coffee. There were also two packages sitting on the table that weren't there last night.

“Robin, you shouldn't have.” I said, taking the coffee.

“Not get you a gift?” she said. “Don't be silly.”

“You got me two.”

“One's kinda for both of us.”

“Seems fair,” I said. “I only got you one.” I went back to our bedroom and retrieved the small box I had tucked in my underwear drawer.

“For the number one woman in my life,” I said as I handed it to her.

Robin looked at me from her perch on the couch and raised an eyebrow. “Number one woman, huh?”

I smiled.

“Whad'ya get your number two girl?”

My smile turned into a snicker and I shrugged my shoulders. Robin punched me in the knee.

“Sit down, mister,” she said and patted the seat next to her. “Time to see what Santa brought you.”

I complied. “Whose first?” I asked.

“You are, since you have two gifts to open.”

I reached for the largest package. It was a square box, about large enough to hold a soccer ball. Despite its size, it felt surprisingly light. Before I could rip off the winter wonderland wrapping paper, Robin pulled the package out of my hands.

“Open the other one first.”

“Fine.” I picked up the small box. It had the same wrapping paper, with snow-covered pine trees and holly leaves and comfy cottages with warm bright candles in the windows. Only, it was smaller.

Inside was a neon orange golf ball with my name and the date embossed on one side and Merry Christmas on the other.

“I was wondering if you'd keep the tradition,” I said.

Every year since we got married, Robin had given me a different colored golf ball, to commemorate our second date, the putt-putt golf outing. It was a special date for her. It was when she decided I was different than all the other guys she'd dated. Her habit of giving sappy gifts was one of Robin's many idiosyncrasies. It's why I love her so much. This ball would soon be joining the purple and light blue ones I had displayed on my desk at the clinic.

“Guess, I'll need to build a little display case for these,” I said.

“Unless, that's what's in the other box.”

“Not tellin’,” Robin said. She started opening her gift. She fussed with the glittery silver wrapping paper that had been professionally applied at the store. My hands were steady as a rock when I was snipping a tomcat's testicles, but when it came to wrapping paper I was all over the place.

For some reason, Robin always liked saving the paper to re-use, so it took her a bit longer to open her present. Her eyes bulged when she saw the jewelry box. She looked at me.

“Peter?”

“Just open it.”

Inside was a small ruby, her birthstone, on a thin gold chain.

“It's beautiful.” And it was, but it was also small. I make a decent living as a veterinarian, but that little rock was expensive.

I took the necklace and put it around Robin's neck.

“How's it look?” my wife asked as I stepped back. The little stone sparkled against her pink skin. My eyes were drawn from the ruby down to her modest breasts. Robin was wearing one of my button down shirts, and she hadn't bothered to fasten any of the buttons. I found it difficult to avoid looking when her movements exposed a nipple.

“Exquisite,” I said. “and the necklace is nice, too.”

Robin smiled and shook her head. “Funny. Now open your last gift.”

“So, this one is for the both of us?”

“Maybe. Kinda,” my wife said.

The box was larger, but light weight. It was also very well wrapped, with lots of ribbon and tape. I didn't care about the paper, so I just tore into it, stretching the ribbon til it snapped and tearing the paper wherever I could work my fingernail in. Under the wrapping paper was a plain brown cardboard box, well secured with packing tape.

“Something special in here, I guess.”

Robin looked on, smiling and I went back to work. After I got enough tape off to open the top I was greeted with a box full of styrofoam packing peanuts. I mean the box was empty except for the peanuts.

“Honey, It's what I always wanted.” My voice was playfully sarcastic.

“Funny. Keep looking.”

I dug through the white pellets and, on the bottom of the box, I found a small envelope. Inside was a note card. On it was a picture of a grey kitten, its eyes pleading for affection. In bold black printing, the card read

'Merry Christmas. This card grants the bearer, one full-body massage from Robin Wilkenson.' The words 'complete with a happy ending' were added in pencil.

“I'll get good use out of this one,” I said.

“Save it for a special occasion. It's a one time offer.”

“Really?” I said.

“Well, I can't refuse it.”

So many possibilities ran through my head.

Overall it was a fun morning. And no mention of Scott. Life was getting good.

After we cleaned up our mess. I made us breakfast – scrambled eggs and bacon – and we sat around watching streaming movies all day. We made love twice that evening and again the following morning, before Robin headed off to work the evening shift at the spa.

“So, you gonna tell me about the car?” I said.

Robin buckled in to her yellow Miata. It still had a new car smell despite having the top down. My wife looked like she belonged behind the wheel. She chose well.

“Bought it last weekend,” she said. She patted the empty seat next to her. “You want to come with?”

“Tempting,” I said. “But I have a rabies shot clinic this afternoon. And all those puppies and kittens Santa left under the Christmas tree need check-ups. I'll be busy this week.”

“You are coming for the party, right?” Robin looked a little concerned. She was having a New Year's Eve party for her employees and their partners.

“Don't worry. I won't miss it. Even if another crazy cat lady passes away.”

“Better not.” Robin looked behind her and started backing down the driveway.

“Love you.” I called out.

“I know.” she called back as she drove away. I watched as her brown hair took on a chestnut hue as the wind whipped it around in the early morning sunlight.

Our Christmas had been merry, made more so by the fact we hadn't been spending all that much time together. Robin and I were finally reconnecting.

It wasn't until I was in the shower that I realized we still hadn't settled our relationship issues. Namely, Robin's affections for Scott. Was she still planning to see him? To sleep with him?

These thoughts concerned me. I imagined Robin and her lover locked in a naked embrace and felt a deep pit open in my chest. At the same time my cock got hard and I found myself instinctively stroking it. Luckily I was lathered up with soap. When I realized what I was doing, I stop.

At work, barking dogs and ornery kittens monopolized my attention, but I did decide that Robin and I were going to resolve or relationship before the first day of the New Year was over.

We were close.

I didn't have much contact with Robin the week between Christmas and the party. I called her the next day and she told me she didn't have time to talk. I found that odd but not too unbelievable, after all, she was running a complicated business.

“I'll keep this quick,” I said on the phone. “Do you need me to bring anything to the party?”

“Just yourself, sweetie,” Robin said. “And maybe some swimwear. We're opening up the facilities for the party.”

I couldn't help but ask, “Is Scott going to be there?”

Silence on the line for a moment, then, “thought you said you'd keep it short?”

“Sorry.” I had to agree, talking about her lover was not going to be a quick conversation. “Just wondering.”

“I'll put it this way,” Robin said. “I didn't explicitly invite him and he does have three other locations having parties that night, but I can't tell him not to come.”

I laughed. “He's gonna be there. It's the best chance he has of starting out the New Year with a bang.”

My wife didn't say anything to that stupid statement, but I did hear a slight chuckle come down the line. It was nice that we could joke about this, although I still got a little queasy.

“You really like pushing buttons, Peter,” Robin said. Before I could respond my wife interrupted. “Sorry, sweetie, gotta go. Emergency in the aromatherapy room.”

I would have loved to hear that story. I'd have to ask about it later.

“Love ya, Bye,” she said. She cut off the connection before I could say 'bye' back.

I didn't talk to Robin again until I saw her at the spa. I arrived around five and was shown to the changing room by a very cute blond girl. She couldn't be more than twenty. She was wearing a tiny black skirt that barely covered her ass and the requisite lavender polo shirt that was at least two

sizes too small. It looked like her rather ample breasts were going to burst out if she took anything more than a shallow breath.

I tried not to stare too much, but I failed. She smiled every time she caught me glancing down at her rack.

“You can change in here, Mr. Wilkenson,” she said pointing into the men's locker room.

“Peter, Call me, Peter.” I didn't like being called Mr. Wilkenson. Made me feel old.

“Okay. Peter. I'm Misty. Robin's in one of the saunas.”

“Thanks, Misty,” I said and went to change into my swim trunks, simple blue shorts that went halfway down my thigh. I grabbed a towel from a shelf near the exit to the pool area.

It was packed. There must have been about forty people, all told, maybe two dozen in the pool, another dozen using the hot tubs with the rest milling around. Plus I knew there were more using the saunas.

There was pop music playing over the sound system and two employees were acting as lifeguards.

I went over to the doors leading to the sauna, where Misty said my wife was. There was a small card table with a clipboard and a list of names. Robin's name was written down next to room number three, as was the name, Bradley.

Interesting, I thought. He was the dark skinned personal trainer I met during the grand opening. For a split second, I thought of him and Robin, doing more than sitting and chatting. I pictured her naked and spread eagle on the wooden bench, her pale pink skin glistening with sweat. Between her knees knelt Brad, his dark skin even darker compared to hers. I felt a rush of blood to my penis and I had to stop thinking about it to avoid embarrassment. This was a health club, not a sex club.

On door number three, there was an occupied sign hanging from the handle. I knocked, but got no answer. Surely they weren't really having sex. I knocked again, and again, no answer. I slowly tried the door, it was unlocked. I pushed it open and found out why no one answered.

Beyond the door was a small anti-chamber with a water fountain and a small bench. Two towels were currently hanging from hooks on the wall. On the far wall was another door, this one with a small window. I went over and wiped the condensation away. I peeked in and saw my wife and her employee. Contrary to my wild imagination, they were sitting and chatting. Robin quickly noticed me and waved me in.

I opened the door and was hit by a blast of intense, wet, heat. It was like breathing water.

“Come in, Peter,” Robin said, “and close the door.”

I did as I was told.

The room was intimate, but not too crowded. There were two levels of wooden benches along three walls and a small control for adjusting the heat and steam levels next to the door. The sauna could probably hold about six people without anyone touching, unless they wanted to.

Robin was on the top bench, leaning against the far right corner. Bradley was sitting in the middle of the lower bench, to my left.

Robin was not naked, she wore a conservative red one-piece bathing suit. It complimented her figure, but wasn't too sexual. Bradley wore lavender board shorts. he was really taking brand loyalty seriously.

“Hope I'm not interrupting anything,” I said. I sat down on the step below my wife.

“No,” my wife said. “Brad was just telling me about how his boyfriend is thinking about moving to Portland.”

So much for my fantasy of this young man fucking my wife. I don't know if I was more relieved or disappointed.

I leaned up to kiss my wife. She turned her cheek to me, probably in deference to her employee in the room. "Happy New Year," I said.

"Same to you," Robin said. "Although we still have a few hours of this year left."

"I'm going to go have a swim to cool off," Brad said. "I've been in here long enough."

"I'll be right out, too," Robin said.

As soon as the door closed behind Brad, Robin slipped down and practically took me. Her hands moved up and down my bare back, occasionally grabbing my ass as she kissed me. Her tongue grappled with mine.

It was odd and arousing, seeing the way my wife could turn her sexual energy on and off, like a light switch. I guess it was hard enough getting her employees to respect her as a woman, without having them see her as a sexual being as well.

Robin reached into my shorts and started caressing my cock. "I've missed you, Peter," she said to me. I could feel the blood leaving my head.

"You've missed, little pete, I think," I said to her. I reluctantly pulled her hand away. "Think we should stop before I need a dunk in the pool."

"You're right," Robin said. She got up to readjust the temperature settings. "There'll be plenty of time for fun next year."

I had to think for a moment before I got the joke.

"Let's go out and meet the rest of my staff."

Robin and I spent the next two hours mingling. I was introduced to over two dozen people, only a few of whom, I'd remember their names, later. I already met Brad, I wasn't going to forget him. There was Misty.

She had changed into a bikini. It was neon pink and tiny. I could feel my cock start expanding again. I made it a point to look her straight in the eyes when Robin introduced us. It was hard, but I was able to keep my erection under control.

“I noticed there's no alcohol here.” I told Robin a little later in the evening while we were floating around in the pool.

“Safety issue,” she said. Seemed reasonable. “Near midnight we'll all go out in the gym and watch the live countdown from Phoenix. I've got some champagne we'll break out then. Luckily all my employees are over twenty-one.” That I found hard to believe.

“The party's more about having fun with co-workers and friends.”

“Robin, you are a great boss.”

“Thanks,” she said. My wife swam over and kissed me, on the lips this time, even in front of the staff. She also grabbed my balls under the water.

“Careful,” I whispered. “Gotta stay professional.”

“No one can see,” Robin said, keeping her voice as low as mine. She stroked me a few more times then playful leapt up, out of the water, arching her back, before re-entering. Her hard nipples strained against the slick fabric of her suit – the only visible hint of her arousal. If I tried that, my boner would have been a dead giveaway.

My wife looked sleek and sexy cutting through the water. I wanted to take her right then and there. I wanted to sit her up on the edge of the pool and lap away at her pussy, until she came, twice, and then impale her on my cock. I didn't care who saw. They weren't my employees.

I didn't do that.

Around ten-thirty, Robin and I got a chance to relax in the hot tub, by ourselves. She sat with her back toward the far wall. I sat across from her. We shared a bottle of water.

Everything had been going so well. We had re-connected and I felt I wanted to finally resolve the status of our relationship.

I decided to start vague. “Can I assume you've picked me over Scott.” I said. Okay, I wasn't that vague.

Robin had been sipping on the water and looking over at the pool when I spoke. She shot a look at me, her expression turned dark.

“Why bring that up, Peter?”

“We've been having such a good time,” I said. “I thought we could resolve this and move on.”

“Let's not get into this right now. Not here.”

“Why not? We've already waited, I've already waited five months for an answer.”

“A lot has happened since then, Peter.”

We looked at each other. No words, just the expression in our eyes passed as communication. I opened my mouth to speak, but stopped when I lost eye contact with my wife. She was looking over my shoulder when she said, “fuck.”

I turned around and saw Scott. He was wearing a pair of colorful swim shorts, a tropical print of greens and reds and oranges. The staff look at him with deference and respect as he passed. He smiled at them, patted a few on the back, chatted with one, all while making his way toward our location.

Robin stepped out of the water and shook his hand. He gave her a friendly hug and a peck on the cheek. Only the three of us knew he wanted to give her so much more.

I stood to get out but Scott stopped me. “No need to get up, Peter. Robin, may I join you?”

I wanted to say no, but didn't. I also didn't say yes. I left that up to my wife.

“Sure thing, Scott,” Robin said. Scott helped her re-enter the water. “You want some juice or water?” My wife moved a little closer to me.

“Water's good,” Scott said. He sat down across from the both of us. Here we were, the perfect triangle: wife, husband, lover.

“Didn't expect to see you here tonight, Peter,” Scott said as he settled back.

My anger started boiling, like the water in the tub. I needed to settle down. I needed to realize Scott was pushing my buttons. It wasn't easy.

“Scott,” Robin said. “Play nice.”

I didn't know what was more humiliating, Scott's insults or my wife having to come to my aid. At least I had her backing me. For a while Scott did behave. We chatted about the spa and how well business was.

“The numbers are fantastic,” Scott said, speaking to Robin. “I love the initiative you took getting contracts with the big resorts here.”

“It made sense. We get paid and the hotel rolls the cost into their rates. Everyone wins.”

Robin was in her element, talking shop, taking pride in her work. And Scott was there to urge her on, get her excited again. Scott offered her more than a relationship, he offered her a career and that was hard to compete with.

I put my arm around Robin and she leaned into me. It felt nice, but I also noticed a few times, after Scott would say something especially complimentary or charming, my wife would reach out and put her hand on his knee.

It was a subtle move, but I noticed and Scott noticed and he gave me a sneaky smile. I wanted to smile back. I knew my wife was going to end it

with him. I knew I had won out. It was just a matter of when Scott would find out. I would have loved to be the one to deliver the news, but it wasn't really my decision to make, it was Robin's, and she'd have to be the one to end it.

I wanted to be there to watch.

“You staying at one of the local resorts, Scott?” I said. Did I really want to start that now? I thought about the logic behind poking the beast. I couldn't blame it on alcohol. I guess it was time to get things out in the open. We'd spent five months, beating around the bush. Time to get the thing done.

Scott looked at me, his eyes hinted surprise that I would be so bold to bring that up. Robin nudged me in the ribs with her elbow.

“What?” I said, feigning innocence. “I'm just concerned about where he's staying.”

“Sure you are, Peter,” Robin said, although her voice hinted more exasperation than anger.

“It's okay, Robin,” Scott said. “Yes, Peter, I'm staying at the Hilton Resort. Great room, plus I get the use of Robin. I mean the facilities that Robin is the manager of.”

Robin kept a straight face, but I could tell she wanted to snicker at the comment. I was starting to feel like I shouldn't take anything for granted.

“I take it you'll be staying at your wife's place?” Scott said.

I nodded.

“Should I ask her where she's staying?” he added.

I wanted to punch him. Robin kicked him in the shin, but it was just a glancing blow.

Scott chuckled. “Sorry, I can't help myself sometimes.”

I didn't know if I should get upset over the lack of an answer from my wife. She didn't say she was coming back with me, but then, he really didn't ask the question either. The tension between the three of us was building. I wanted Robin to dump the jerk, but she wasn't taking the opportunities I was giving her, and it was pissing me off. Instead of ending her romantic relationship with her boss, she started talking shop again.

“Marylyn's been doing great. She gets along well with the staff and she really knows the business.”

“Not surprised,” Scott said. “I've been watching her for a few years. Glad you took my advice and made her your assistant.”

That went on for a few more minutes. I kept looking back at the large clock on the wall above the gym doors. It was eleven thirty and close to time to pop the champagne. I could really use a drink.

“Anyway, things are going so well here,” Scott said, “that I want to move you up in the organization,”

“What do you mean?” Robin said.

“I want you to come work for me in LA.”

I almost missed the ask. I was paying attention to the clock and my own needs and I almost missed it.

Robin was silent and the lull in the conversation was what drew my attention.

“I want you to help me scout out new locations. Maybe open up a few more gyms and then go public.”

Robin still wasn't saying much, and I was trying to wrap my mind around what he was saying.

“How about it, Robin? Come work for me in California. Double the salary, plus travel.”

I finally shook off the shock. “What about me?” Yes, it was all about me.

“What about you?” Scott said. “I’m not looking to hire a vet. I need a manager.”

“You think you can come here and lure my wife away? With a better job and better money?” My voice was starting to rise. A few people nearby noticed and looking our way. When they saw it was their boss's husband arguing with the owner, they thought it best to move along.

“I’ve got a bigger cock, too.” Scott said, under his breath so that only I and maybe Robin could hear.

I hit the surface of the tub with my palm, splashing water into Scott's face.

Scott laughed, “settle down, Peter. It's only a joke.”

“The answer is, no,” I said.

“And again, I’m not asking you, Petey. I’m asking Robin.”

“You don't care about Robin,” I said. I turned to my wife. “Tell him, sweetie. Tell him no.” I felt awkward pleading with my wife to turn down a great job opportunity. But I knew our marriage wouldn't survive it.

“Why won't you say no?” I said.

The more I pushed, the more the silence held.

“She can't say no because she knows she wants it.”

“Robin, tell him. Tell him he's wrong.”

Scott turned to my wife. “Robin, you don't have to answer tonight. Take your time and think about it. Be sure it's what you want.” He emphasized the word you.

We bickered back and forth, me trying to goad my wife into turning down the offer, Scott telling her not to rush a decision. All this time Robin was silent, staring off into the middle distance, her brain at work.

Why didn't she just say no? Was she really going to leave me? For this job? For Scott? Was I really that bad of a husband?

A tiny part of me said yes, I was. I was only thinking about myself and how this job would affect me and my relationship. That tiny part of introspection was crushed by my overpowering paranoia and self-loathing.

My decent into pity was broken when Robin got out of the hot tub.

"Robin, where are you going?" I called out. Scott said nothing.

A few employees approached my wife as she made her way to the changing room. I heard her tell one of them she was fine and to lock up before they left. She slipped around the corner and was gone.

"Hope you're satisfied," Scott said.

"What the fuck do you mean?" I said.

"Getting Robin so upset she had to leave."

"You started it." Thinking about it now, I sounded like a spoiled brat.

"That what you really think, Peter?" Scott was serious, no smirk, no belittling pet name.

"Yes," I said, with not much enthusiasm.

"Bullshit. All I ever wanted was whatever was best for Robin."

"Really? Not just an easy lay?"

Scott laughed at that. "I feel sorry for you if that's what you think of your wife. She may be a lot of things, but she's not an easy lay."

I couldn't deny what Scott was saying. It was all true and that's what made it so hard to hear.

"I see something in her personality that I like," Scott said. "She strives for the best and isn't one to settle for good enough."

"That's Robin," I said.

"Which is why, for the life of me, I don't understand what the hell she sees in you."

The words hit like a barrel of birdshot to the gut. I couldn't argue with him. I had no snappy comeback. I was only thinking about myself. I was selfish. Robin could do much better.

My pity had returned. All the progress made over the past months undone with a few words.

“You win, Scott,” I said. I started getting out of the water.

“That's right. I win. I win because I don't give up.”

I turned and glared at the handsome, confident man relaxing in the hot tub. “Doesn't it bother you, what you've done to our family.”

“Peter, I told you. I don't care about you. Only Robin. At any point she could end this with a word. She's smart enough to see the value in what I offer.”

I shook my head.

“You know I'm right.” Scott said.

I did know that, but I wasn't going to say it to him. I walked away and didn't look back. I got dressed and drove to Robin's apartment. I needed to apologize for being an obstinate pig. Tell her I was sorry for acting up in front of her staff.

When I arrived at her place it was dark and I didn't see her car anywhere nearby. I didn't have a key so I had to knock. No one answered. I sent her a text.

- You OK?

I waited a few minutes, but got no answer. I called her. After five rings it went to voice mail.

Fuck.

I left a message. “Robin. I'm sorry. I was a dunce. This isn't about me, it's about you. It's about us. I love you and I want the best for you. I'd

prefer you stay here, but if you'd rather, I'll support you either way.” The machine cut off halfway through the word support.”

While I'd back her decision, what I didn't say was that it would be as a close friend, not as her husband. It wouldn't work out. I could deal with the long distance romance, but not if she was working so close with Scott, living in the same city, taking trips together. Even if she broke off the love affair, I knew Scott would worm his way back into her heart. I felt horrible for not trusting my wife, and I buried that pain deep. Maybe I shouldn't be married to Robin if I couldn't trust her.

Then again, she did cheat on me first. There was no getting around that. But she apologized. And I pushed her further into his arms with my own desire to watch her make love.

What a twisted path I was treading on.

I decided to drive home, to Phoenix, to spend the first day of the New Year in bed, nursing a hangover.

I hoped I had enough Scotch at home to make that happen.

Chapter 9

Robin

Her mind is abuzz with uncertainty. She is close; so close to closure.

She drives south, past pines and cacti and distant mountain peaks, her mind, a battlefield of conflicting wants and desires. Two forces pulling in opposite directions.

She knows which way she should go. She knows which course of action to take. She knows what she wants.

She also knows she must be the one to decide. She can't be coerced or cajoled. She knows what to do.

He just makes it so hard.

Peter

I woke up late on New Year's Day, really late, like eight o'clock at night late. My head hurt, my throat was dry and I was so hungry. I took two aspirin with a glass of water to take care of my first two aches and went to the kitchen to find something to settle my third.

I emptied a can of chicken noodle soup into a sauce pan and contemplated the next step in resolving my marriage situation.

Situation seemed to be the best word to describe it. It wasn't a problem or an issue. I had no problem with being married to Robin. I enjoyed it and I wanted it to continue.

Our marriage may have been a problem for Robin; I wasn't going to assume anything. I did know it was a problem for Scott, since he appeared to want my wife to himself.

It wasn't a matter of sharing. He wanted her and was doing his best to seduce her over to his side, and he had plenty of ammunition to use in that battle.

Scott had good looks, a charming personality – when he wanted to – and lots of money. I was just a nice guy with a decent job. He even had a bigger dick than I did. From my point of view, he offered a better package and Robin would be a fool to pass it up.

I ate my soup and decided my next step. I'd call Robin, check on how she felt and politely tell her I was letting her go. I wasn't going to hold her back. This job, this relationship she had with Scott, was too good to pass up.

We didn't have kids or much of an estate to divide up. I was sure we could end our marriage peacefully and remain friends.

After I finished my meal, I washed the dishes, tidied up the kitchen and sat down to call Robin. I pressed her icon on my phone and the line immediately went to voice mail. I had already left my apology the night before – actually earlier that morning. I wasn't going to leave a break-up message. I sent her another text message instead.

- Call Me

Now it was up to her.

A minute later the phone buzzed. It was an unknown number.

“Hello?” I said.

“Where is she?” It was Scott.

“Where's who?”

“Your wife, you idiot.” Scott said, his voice low but full of anger. “The person you just texted.”

“How'd you know I...”

“She left her fucking phone here.”

That was not like Robin. She must have really been pissed.

“If you have her phone,” I said, “then you must have heard the voice mail I sent and you must know I have no idea where she is.”

“I didn't listen to any goddamn messages because, a, I wouldn't do that and b, the phone's locked and I don't have her password.”

So I knew her phone password and Scott, her lover, didn't. That was comforting. I could have told him it was Beas4ver, but I didn't.

“I only saw the few texts you sent,” Scott said. “On the screen. So I called you.”

He must have thought she was with me, trying to find her phone.

“Well, I don't know where she is,” I said. “I haven't seen her since last night.”

“She's not at her apartment,” Scott said. “And she's not at the spa. I figured she had to be with you.”

“Yeah, well, I thought she'd be with you.” We were both in the same boat, Scott and I. Both desiring the same woman and neither of us with an advantage.

“She's not,” Scott said. “You have any phone numbers for her relatives? I want to call them, see if she's there.”

“No,” I lied. The last thing I wanted was Scott calling my in-laws.

“I'm pretty sure you're lying to me, but anyway. If she contacts you, tell her to call me.”

“Sure thing, Scott.” I lied, again. “Bye.” I ended the call.

I had no intention of telling Robin to call Scott, and I doubted he'd tell her to call me.

Despite sleeping in most of the day, I was still tired so I went back to bed. I lay there, tossing and turning, my mind racing against my body's weariness. Sleep avoided me.

Although I was worried about Robin, I knew there was nothing I could do. She was an adult and she wasn't drunk when she left. If anything had happened, the cops would have called me. In the morning, I'd call my wife's family in Jersey, see if she'd contacted them, although I didn't know how she'd do that without her cell phone.

I had no idea what to do after that. File a missing persons report? How long do you wait to do that? Twenty-four hours seemed too soon, that's what I learned from all the cop shows I watch.

Most likely, Robin was fine. She just needed to blow off some steam. She'd been under a lot of pressure with the job, the pregnancy and her affair with Scott.

Now that the spa was up and running and doing well, her lover and I were the only issues she still had to deal with.

I finally nodded off with a vision of Robin, pacing some room, contemplating dumping Scott or me. My last conscious thought was the realization she could dump both of us.

The next morning I went to work and tried to act like nothing was wrong. I gave a few rabies shots and checked one kitten for worms. At lunch, I called my father-in-law in Newark. It was a short call. I didn't come out and say I was looking for Robin; I didn't want to needlessly alarm them. After a few minutes of pointless conversation, I concluded Robin hadn't called them within the last few days. I made an excuse and politely ended the call.

Throughout the second half of the day, I tried to think of other avenues of investigation, other than calling the police. I was getting ready to head

home around five-thirty, when I got a call. It was from the same number as last night, the one Scott called from. I didn't answer it. Let the fucker leave a message.

A minute later the icon on my phone indicated he did just that. I listened to the message.

“Peter,” It wasn't Scott. It was a vaguely familiar female voice. “This is Marylyn at the Spirit Spa.” So even they started abbreviating that ridiculously long name. “I wanted to call and tell you Robin called us. She wanted me to pass along a message to you. Don't try to call her because she doesn't have her phone. She's fine and will be in touch. I hope everything's okay; that's from me. Thanks. Bye.”

Well, that was to the point, and very vague. Would she call me soon? Would her lawyer be getting in touch? I had no fucking clue. So for the next few days I was in a state of emotional limbo. I went to work and came home. I didn't feel like going out much or trying to have any fun. My heart wasn't in it.

I still felt married and even though we had an open relationship, it felt wrong to date someone else while my own status with Robin was up in the air.

Funny thing was, I had no clue what my wife was doing. She might have been fucking Scott, or maybe with some other man she met. I didn't think about that too much. It hurt. So, instead, I imagined she was being as chaste as I was.

On the first Saturday of the New Year I contacted a legal aid hotline and got the information I needed to file for divorce in Arizona. I was not going to be caught off-guard by her lawyer, if that was the route she was taking.

What I found astounded me. It was ludicrously easy to end a marriage. As long as there were no kids and no arguments over property, it was simply filling out some forms and paying court costs, and even those could be waived. After sixty days my marriage could be dissolved. I could be a single man again before my next wedding anniversary.

I went online and started filling out the forms. It was an emotionally painful process. Each key stroke was a stab at my heart. I only got about a quarter of the way through it before I had to stop. I saved the little progress I had made and went to get a drink.

The Oasis parking lot was about half full, as was to be expected this early on a Saturday. Inside was busy, but not packed. I could have sat in a booth and watched the crowd, but that would make it too easy to wallow in my pity. Instead, I took a seat at the bar and started chatting with Angie.

“Haven't seen you in a while,” the red-head said to me as she set down my scotch. “Thought you found a new favorite watering hole.”

I took Angie's wrist and kissed the back of her hand. “Nothing could replace you, dear.”

“Funny.”

Angie continued making drinks and talking with me when she had a chance. At one point she had to head to the back to change a beer keg. I thought of the last time I went back there with her and I started getting an erection.

“So, you know Angie?” The voice came from the bar stool on my left. She was a blonde, with long wavy hair and golden tanned skin. She had a figure that would look good on the cover of Maxim magazine, but she was about my age, so those lads would never think of featuring her. Their loss.

“Yeah,” I said. “I come here, on and off.” I wasn't about to get into how well I knew Angie.

“I'm Susan, by the way.”

“Sorry. I'm Peter.” We shook hands. “So what do you do, Susan?”

Best way to get over one failed relationship was to start another one, I guess.

“I'm in real estate. I'm celebrating a big sale out in Fountain Hills.”

“Congratulations,” I raised my tumbler and noticed my companion's was empty. “Angie, get Susan here another. On me.”

We toasted to her success. She thanked me for the drink. We chatted for a bit, mostly about our jobs. All the time I couldn't help but notice Angie would occasionally look my way and smirk. I asked her about it when Susan got up to use the ladies' room.

“You jealous?” I asked her.

“If you only knew.” Angie said.

“What's that mean.”

“You thinking of hooking up with her?”

“Wasn't planning on it.” I wasn't, but now that Angie put that thought into my head. “But maybe.”

“She's married.” My cock started twitching.

“Guess I'm not getting lucky tonight.” I said.

Angie leaned across the bar and whispered to me. “You might be surprised.”

Susan came back and sat down before I could ask the red-head to elaborate.

“You miss me?” Susan asked.

“Kinda.” I was enjoying flirting, harmless conversation, that might or might not lead to anything. I was betting on, might not. I wasn't in the mood and Susan was married. I glanced at her left hand and noticed a

marked absence of a wedding ring, although I did see a light impression on her ring finger where one would be.

I started nervously twirling my own ring.

“You expecting your wife?” Susan said when she saw what I was doing. “Think she'll get pissed, you talking to blond like me?”

I laughed. Robin was the last person I expected to see.

“No. I was wondering when your spouse was going to show up.”

Susan looked a little shaken. “How?”

“You can't just take the ring off before you head out to the bar.” I indicated the discoloration on her finger.

“It's my first time.”

I doubted it. “You cheating?”

“We're just flirting. I could go somewhere else, if you're uncomfortable.”

“No. I like your company. Helps take my mind off my problems.”

We talked a little more, but when she realized I wasn't going to hit on her she lost interest and excused herself.

“So what's her game?” I asked Angie when she came to collect Susan's empty glass.

“Not sure,” Angie said. “Seen her in here a couple times with a tall blond white guy. But I've also seen her chat up lonely guys like you.”

“Thanks.” I said.

“Truth hurts. Never seen her leave with anyone else. Maybe she just likes the casual flirting.”

I had Angie save my seat and went to the men's room. While I was peeing I thought about Susan and the game she was playing. Was she going behind her husband's back? That seemed unlikely, since she was doing it in a bar they both frequented. He must know. Maybe he even encouraged her

to chat up other guys. It wasn't hard to imagine a guy getting off on seeing other guy's hitting on his wife. Maybe he liked watching other men try to hook up with her, knowing she'd eventually shoot them down and go home to fuck him, instead.

Or maybe he was one of those freaks who liked to watch her fuck other men. One of those freaks like me. I had discovered the world was full of sexual variations, and thought it was a good thing.

I was washing my hands when I noticed a familiar tune come over the sound system. I hadn't really been paying attention to the music, but this song drew my attention. For one thing, it wasn't the normal classic rock or alternative stuff the Oasis usually played. And for another, it was our song.

“Why the hell are you playing this?” I asked Angie as I returned to my seat.

The beautiful bartender smiled and kept wiping off the rocks glass she had in her hand.

“Why the hell are you playing, Little River Band?”

“Because I asked her to,” someone behind me said.

I turned to face the source of the voice.

It was Robin. “Surprise.”

My wife grabbed my face and kissed me.

My mind was reeling as our tongues wrestled. I was lost in a miasma of passion, confusion and emotional pain. When Robin finally pulled away, all I could say was, “What the fuck?”

“You, Peter. I choose you.”

My wife sat down at the vacant stool next to mine and ordered a white wine from Angie. I still stood stunned by what had happened, realizing Robin had answered the question I had first posed months ago.

Eventually, the fact that my marriage wasn't over hit me and I wanted to shout, but I didn't. I still had so many questions that needed answering.

“How the hell did you know I was here?” was my first. I realized the answer when I saw Robin look up at our bartender and smile.

“Angie called me,” Robin said.

“When you said I might still get lucky,” I said, speaking to the red-head, “you weren't talking about the hot blonde.”

“A blonde?” Robin said in mock horror.

“She could have been a back-up,” Angie said, “but no, I was thinking about your wife.”

I took another sip of Scotch as Robin explained how she had stopped by the Oasis a couple of days prior and told my fuck buddy to call when I eventually came around; yes, she used that phrase and yes, Angie winked at me in response.

“Why not come to me? Stop at the house, or the clinic?” I said.

I must have sounded a bit pissed because Robin's cheeks took on a bit of red. “I wanted to surprise you.”

“You sure the fuck did. What if I never came back here?”

“I didn't figure you could stay away from your favorite bartender for long.”

Now it was my turn to blush. “We haven't dated in like, two or three months,” I said.

“Wasn't my fault,” Angie said, before going to pour beers for another couple.

“I wouldn't have minded,” Robin said, although I doubted she was being a hundred percent honest. “Wasn't like I was there to take care of your,” she reached down to grab my penis, “needs.”

“Too many things going on in my head,” I said. Robin squeezed, “my other head.” My wife seemed to be enjoying herself, but I thought it was a serious issue. “I’ve been filling out divorce papers.”

Robin's smile disappeared and she withdrew her hand. “You're divorcing me?” It was like some surprise she didn't see coming. I thought about playing out the tension, maybe demonstrate how much it hurt not knowing what your partner was thinking. I didn't do that.

“I couldn't get through the first page and a half,” I said.

Robin's face eased a bit and she took a drink.

“We have to resolve this, Robin. I love you, but I can't be a part-time husband.”

“Oh, Peter.” My wife reached up and touched my cheek. “I never wanted that either. I thought I could control myself. I got carried away. I'm sorry I let my lust for Scott turn to love.”

She wasn't apologizing for the affair, just the aftermath. It was a start.

“I'm sorry for asking you to let me watch you...” I paused and looked to make sure no one was paying any attention to us. I leaned in and whispered, “fuck him.”

Robin smiled and said, “I'm not. That threesome was so fucking fun. I'm just sorry I went back to his place after. That's when I accepted his offer and fell in love.”

“When did you know it was over?” I wasn't sure it mattered, but I really wanted to know. Secrecy and suspicion had grown like a cancer in our life and getting everything out in the open was the only way to get rid of it.

“Let's take this somewhere a little more private,” Robin said.

I spied a free booth in the corner of the bar and we moved to it. It was darker and more quiet and we could discuss our personal matters without

anyone overhearing. The booth was U-shaped and we could have sat next to each other, but I wanted to sit across from my wife so I could look into her eyes as we spoke. Robin had a way for conveying emotions with her face that I loved.

We sat and stared at each other for a while. Our relationship had been a roller coaster for the last eight months. It was going to take some time for us to settle down. We would never go back to how things were, before Vegas.

Eventually, Robin started telling her side of the story.

“I think it was right after you took me to the women's clinic that I realized Scott was not the man I thought he was. And when he felt my health wasn't as important as the fetus inside me – I lost a lot of respect for him that day.”

“I could have told you Scott was an ass long before that,” I said.

“I wouldn't have listened. When I'm with Scott I find him irresistible. He exudes a charm that drives me wild.”

“I know.”

“But over the past few months I've had to spend lots of time alone. When I wasn't working on the spa, I was thinking about the two of you.”

“Why did it take so long? So long to decide.”

“It never felt like the right time, and it really wasn't that urgent. We both seemed to be in a relatively happy place at the time. I was working. Scott was off dealing with other problems. I probably would have said something at the soft open, but you didn't show up. I was pissed off and Scott was there. All of a sudden I was uncertain. I figured you were with Angie, or someone else, and didn't think you needed to call me.

“I was wrong. I know it. But it's the truth.”

“What about New Years?” I said.

“I would have told you at midnight. But Scott showed up, and you two started acting like a couple of fourteen-year-old boys.”

“I gave you plenty of opportunities.”

“Peter, you know me. You know I don't like being forced into anything. I have to act when it's right – right for me. You were putting me under a lot of pressure, and Scott, with his fucking job offer. That's when I realized what his plan was.”

I leaned across the table and took her hands in mine.

“So we stay married,” I said. Not a question, at least not on my end.

“Yes. As long as you'll have me.”

“Robin, I've put up with a lot of shit to keep our marriage intact. I ain't letting it go that easy. Not if it's still something you want.”

“Oh, sweetie, believe me, it is.”

I waived over at Angie for two more drinks.

“So what now?” I asked.

“Obviously, I'm not moving to Los Angeles. I figure that's a deal breaker for us.”

I didn't say yes or no. She knew she was right; she didn't need my confirmation. Like she said, she had to come to her decisions on her own, without pressure.

“I thought about staying on at the Spirit, managing the shop, but without the relationship with the owner. It's not like he could fire me without a huge harassment suit.”

I think my own feelings were clouding my ability to read my wife's face. I couldn't tell if the thought of working in Sedona made her happy, or not. It was an excellent position and she seemed to thrive there. I would have rather she come home, but I wasn't going to force it. It was her career.

Robin ended my worry when she said, “But I realized I want to come back and live with you.”

I sighed and smiled. Robin leaned over and kissed my hands. “We have a lot of catching up to do,” she said.

“I couldn't agree more. I miss having you around. I miss our morning hugs as I head off to work. I miss the smell of you on the pillows. I miss picking up the panties you leave laying around the house.” She smacked my hand. She didn't do that. “Well you can start, I won't mind.”

“That's good, cause I gave my two week notice. Marylyn will take over and I'm sure the spa will do fine without me.”

“I guess you're gonna have to give back that sweet little ride you bought,” I said. It was a nice car, but I didn't think we would be able to handle the payments on just my salary.

“Fat chance, buster,” Robin said.

“Everything alright over here?” Angie asked as she delivered our drinks.

“No,” Robin said. “Peter thinks he's going to make me give up my new Miata.”

Angie shook her head. “Good luck with that,” she said before heading back to the bar.

I knew when to give up. I figured we could trim expenses somewhere else, maybe not go out to eat so often or drop the premium cable channels. That'd save a hundred bucks a month right there. I shouldn't have been worried about it. As usual, Robin had it covered.

“Don't worry about the payments,” my wife said. “I got hired at the Windwalker Ranch Resort. I'm their new assistant manager. I interviewed on Tuesday and got the offer yesterday. They heard about how things were going at the Spirit Spa and were thrilled I was interested.”

“And Scott gave a good recommendation?”

“Scott gave a glowing recommendation.”

“So, he knew you were leaving before I did.”

“You're not going to get pissy with me are you?”

“I'm surprised he didn't try to fuck things up.”

Robin didn't say anything right away. She looked down at her wine, glanced up at me and took a sip.

“Okay, what did he try to fuck up?” I said.

“Oh. He offered more money. Made a few vague threats that I knew were empty. Eventually he accepted defeat. He knows he can't intimidate me as much as he can you.”

I wanted to say something, but it was the truth so I just took a drink.

We chatted a little bit more and finished our beverages. We could have ordered another round – the night was still young – but we both agreed we'd rather continue our reunion at home, cuddle up on the sofa and enjoy each other's company again.

So we settled our bill with Angie and we headed out.

We were laying in bed, naked, sweat dripping from our pores, my cock slick with our combined juices, my semen seeping out of Robin's sex. We basked in the afterglow of the best make-up sex I'd ever had and I decided now was the time to bring up our arrangement.

“So, I guess this means I'll have to stop seeing Angie?” It was a rhetorical question since for all intents and purposes I already had. I was thinking about Susan and Kelly and yeah, sure, Angie as well.

“Do you want to?” Robin was tracking her fingers through the sticky mess on my chest.

It's a trap!, I thought to myself – not a lot of good honest answers to that, so I tried turning it around on her.

“Do you want me to want to do that?”

Robin slapped my chest. “Don't be silly,” she said, “just answer the question.”

“To be honest. No. But I will if you want me to.”

Robin rolled on top of me, her breast felt good squished against me. My penis started stirring between her thighs. “Peter, the reason I wanted to come home was to be with you. To experience life with you. That includes our sexual adventures.”

I liked what I was hearing, as did my cock.

Robin continued. “So as long as we both agree, I think we should keep exploring. Can I take your twitching erection poking at my cunt means you agree?”

“Yup” I twitched some more. “Let me explore your ass with my hands.” I moved my hands down to grab and maul her butt. “Let me explore your mouth with my tongue.” I kissed her hard and passionately. “And let me explore your pussy with my cock.” I thrust my hips forward and slid smoothly into her well-lubricated opening.

We didn't get much sleep that night.

Epilogue

We were riding the escalator down to the main gaming floor at the Excalibur Hotel and Casino in Las Vegas. I took out our money roll and drew off two, hundred dollar bills. I handed them to Robin.

“You want to go play slots while I try a little blackjack?” I asked.

Robin took the bills and said no. “I want to play roulette.”

“Now, you're just fucking with me,” I said. I had been surprised when she told me she wanted to go back to Vegas when I asked her how she wanted to celebrate our fourth wedding anniversary.

“Trying to find another handsome rich man to flirt with?” I asked.

“Odds are pretty low on that,” Robin said as she lead me across the floor, past the blinking lights and clanging sounds – anachronistic since they don't pay out quarters anymore.

“Yeah, lightning doesn't strike the same place twice.”

“You know that's wrong, right?” Robin said.

We found an open table and traded our two hundred dollars for two hundred purple chips. We played five or ten chips at a time and were having fun when I heard a voice behind me.

“Mind if I join you?”

“Fuck,” I said. I turned around, not knowing what to expect.

She was a vision – Jessica Rabbit made flesh. Her hair flowed over her head and down her shoulders like a crimson waterfall. The black sequin dress she wore hugged her many curves like a Porsche at Le Mans. Her makeup was glamorous but not too gaudy, bold black lashes with a dusting of brown to make her hazel eyes pop. Her lips a luscious red, like a juicy apple waiting to be bitten.

My jaw fell open and I dropped the ice cube I'd been sucking on. If I'd been a cartoon character my eyeballs would have shot out of my skull and my tongue would be rolled out on the floor.

She was sin personified.

"Happy Anniversary, you guys," Angie said.

"No more bets," the croupier called out. I don't remember if we had placed any bets and I was too consumed by the beauty in front of me to care.

Robin ran over and hugged her. "I'm so glad you made it."

"You invited Angie?" I said.

"Happy Anniversary, sweetheart," Robin said.

I looked around nervously. "Anyone else I should expect?"

"Not unless you asked them. This weekend, it's just the three of us."

"I got these for you," Angie said. She handed my wife a large gift bag. "Don't open it here," she quickly added.

I peeked down inside and saw what looked like a moderately large dildo attached to a leather strap and three tubes of K-Y jelly. I looked up at Angie. She had a gleam in her eye that bore right through me.

"Really? Really? That's what you got us?"

"Yeah. It's for both of you. I envision lots of fun."

Robin smiled, "oh, yes. Lots."

I rubbed my backside, remembering my last adventure with Angie and sex toys.

"Okay. Well, since you gave us a gift. It's only fair I give you one." Now it was Robin's turn to look surprised. She had no clue what was going to hit her. I pulled out the envelope I had tucked in my jacket pocket.

"Here, Angie. This is for you."

The gorgeous red-head opened the envelope, read the card inside and smiled. “one full-body massage. Hmmm. With a happy ending.”

“Peter! That was for you?”

I smiled. “I was going to use that this weekend, but I think I'll get more pleasure watching Angie use it.”

Robin smacked me on the arm. “If I honor that card and If I let you watch.”

I knew she'd honor it. She wouldn't have invited Angie along if some sort of sexual exploration wasn't in order.

If Angie joined us, and I felt certain she would, she would be the first partner we'd invited into our bed since our new agreement.

From the look on the women's faces as they thought about the massage and the strap-on and the lube, we were all going to have many happy endings.

Afterward

When I started, I had a simple plan. A couple in Vegas hook up with another man and have some fun. Well, as you see, it got out of hand. The characters did and said things I hadn't planned them to. That's the fun of writing. While this wraps up the story of Peter and Robin and Scott, you might see some of the characters from this series in other stories.

Despite the fact I thought up the plot while I was in Las Vegas, none of the events in this story even approaches reality. I do appreciate feedback and I can be reached at seangeist@outlook.com. I try to answer all my e-mail. You can also follow me on twitter @SeanGeist.

Also by Sean Geist

[Things We Do For Lust: To The Edge](#)

A seminar in Las Vegas created a perfect opportunity for Peter and Robin to mix business and pleasure. Peter would spend a few days in meetings, while Robin relaxed at the pool – then at night they'd kick back and enjoy all that Sin City had to offer. Ending the week celebrating their anniversary was just a bonus.

But, an unexpected stroke of good fortune interrupts the happy couple's plans. They win a nice little jackpot, and the attention of a handsome stranger. Suddenly they find themselves celebrating with a man they hardly know – someone both Robin and Peter find intriguing.

A night of flirting and a day of seduction later finds the married couple at a crossroads. Will Robin be lured away by another man? Or will she be able to control her desires for a man other than Peter? Or maybe – something else.

[Going Down To Get Up \(The Things We Do For Lust Bk 2\)](#)

A week in the fantasy playground of Las Vegas left a permanent mark on Peter and Robin's marriage. She has a new job, a new boss and a new lover. He has to learn to deal with the situation, with a little help from some very sexy friends.

Can love survive when shared three ways? Or will one heart have to give?

Sometimes the only way to get up is to go down.

[Sherry Tells Stories](#)

Roy thought he knew his wife. After over a decade of marriage, he didn't believe she could ever say or do anything to shock him. He was wrong.

It's date night, no kids, no worries, just a husband and wife enjoying an evening of adult fun. A chance observation at a bar leads to discussions of affairs and cheating and the intersection of reality and fantasy. And soon Roy is faced with the uncomfortable fact that his wife has secret desires of her own. Secrets he never imagined.

And when Sherry starts telling stories, there will be revelations that could very well change their lives, forever.

What Flirting Leads To

Everyone loved Michael and Jennifer's parties. They were always fun, always memorable and always unpredictable. Their New Year's Eve blow out to end the twentieth century promised to eclipse all expectations

Jennifer has not one, but two men interested in more than just a dance, and neither of them is her husband. Michael investigates what kind of naughtiness harmless flirting can lead to. And their friends will learn more about each other than they bargained for.

Relationships will be tested. Secrets revealed. And fantasies fulfilled.

Zahara

Frank Thompson, a successful author of erotic literature, has hit a wall. The words that used to spring forth from his pen – words that made women swoon and men hard - are no longer flowing. Now, his publisher is demanding a new story, one that will return Frank to the top of best-seller lists. Frank promises himself he'll get the book written, but first, he has to deal with his lovely new neighbor.